

Nigerian national dies under mysterious circumstances

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 32-year-old Nigerian national died under mysterious circumstances after being apprehended by the Special Staff of the West district during an operation “Kavach” in West Delhi, police said on Monday. Delhi Police, in a statement, said that the incident took place on the evening of Sunday as part of an ongoing drive “Operation Kavach”, aimed at intensified patrolling in busy areas and along major roads to check suspicious activities. “The Special Staff was on routine patrol when they spotted a man riding a black scooter on the wrong side of the road near Rajouri Garden

Metro station. Finding his movement suspicious, the team signalled him to stop for questioning,” Deputy Commissioner of Police (West) Darade Sharad Bhaskar in the statement said. However, instead of halting, the rider rammed his scooter into a police motorcycle and fell on the road. He then abandoned the vehicle and attempted to flee, prompting the police team to chase and apprehend him after a brief pursuit, read the statement. The suspect was subsequently taken to the Special Staff office located near Tagore Garden for further questioning. During interaction, the man did not cooperate with the police and complained of uneasiness, it read.



Sensing his deteriorating condition, the police team immediately shifted him to Guru Gobind Singh Hospital in Khyala for medical examination. However, doctors at the hospital declared him “brought dead”, as per the medical reports. The deceased has been identified

as Christian Eze Promise, a Nigerian national. His body has been preserved at the mortuary of AIIMS in New Delhi for further legal formalities, including a postmortem. Police said due procedure has been followed in the case, and intimation

regarding the incident has been sent to the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), the Ministry of External Affairs, and the High Commission of Nigeria, in accordance with standing guidelines issued by the Police Headquarters (PHQ) in cases involving foreign nationals. Police added that all mandatory protocols are being adhered to, and documentation related to the case has been completed as per norms. Meanwhile, a police officer said, “We have stepped up security outside the police station to maintain law and order.” With the death occurring under unclear circumstances, police sources said a parallel inquiry is also

being conducted to ascertain whether it qualifies as a case of custodial death. A team of senior officers has been tasked with conducting a thorough probe into the sequence of events. Investigators will examine CCTV footage covering the entire chain of events — from the location where the suspect was first spotted and apprehended near Rajouri Garden to his movement towards the Special Staff office and subsequent visit to the hospital — to establish the exact circumstances leading to his death. Further legal action will be taken based on the findings of the inquiry and post-mortem report, police sources added.

Delhi Government releases ₹20.26 cr for cow welfare



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has released ₹20.26 crore to support cow welfare and strengthen *gaushala* infrastructure. The Chief Minister, Rekha Gupta, made an announcement on Monday and outlined a plan to develop 10 modern *gaushalas* in the first phase.

The funds aim to clear pending dues, ensure regular fodder supply, and improve facilities for stray cattle across the Capital. Lease extensions and licences for existing *gaushalas* have also been renewed to ensure uninterrupted operations. “Our Government is fully committed to the protection and welfare of stray cattle. *Gaushalas* must function without financial or administrative hurdles,” the Chief Minister said while addressing an event at the Jan Seva Sadan.

The financial package includes ₹7.64 crore to clear pending liabilities from June 2024 to March 2025 and ₹12.62 crore towards fodder expenses from April 2025 to January 2026. Officials said the move will help ensure timely feeding, shelter, and medical care for cattle housed in these facilities.

The Chief Minister also handed over lease extension certificates and official documents to representatives of four Government-supported *gaushalas* located in Sultanpur Dabas, Rewla Khanpur, Harewali, and Surhera. These *gaushalas* operate under the Animal Husbandry Unit and cater to stray cattle brought in by local civic bodies.

The Chief Minister said the Government plans to transform *gaushalas* into modern, well-equipped centres for animal care. “In the first phase, 10 modern *gaushalas* will be developed. Our goal is to eventually equip around 40 *gaushalas* with improved infrastructure and services,” she said. The initiative also includes

financial assistance for setting up biogas plants at *gaushalas*. Officials said this will help convert cow dung into clean energy, promoting sustainability and better sanitation. The Chief Minister stressed that *gaushalas* should not be seen merely as shelters but as centres of compassion and service. She said protecting stray animals, especially abandoned cows, and is essential in a large urban centre like Delhi. “*Gaushalas* provide not just shelter but also nutrition and medical care to animals that cannot fend for themselves. It is our responsibility to ensure they live with dignity,” she said.

The Chief Minister added that clearing long-pending dues and renewing licenses reflects the Government’s intent to remove bottlenecks faced by *gaushala* managements. She said authorities want operators to focus entirely on animal welfare without worrying about funding or regulatory delays.

Officials said the Government will also work with *gaushala* managements to introduce better fodder management systems and modern veterinary services. The focus will be on improving overall efficiency and ensuring higher standards of care.

The Chief Minister noted that long-term success will require cooperation between the Government and society. She said public participation and awareness are key to addressing the issue of stray cattle in the city.

Representatives of the *gaushalas* present at the event welcomed the move and expressed gratitude for the financial support. They said the funds and policy decisions will help improve facilities and ensure better care for animals.

The initiative is part of a broader effort by the Delhi Government to address stray cattle issues while promoting animal welfare and sustainable practices.

RAIN, GUSTY WINDS BRING RELIEF TO DELHI AFTER HOT DAY

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi witnessed rain and strong winds of up to 56 kmph on Monday evening, bringing relief after a warm and humid day, even as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued an orange alert for the national Capital.

The sudden weather change disrupted the afternoon heat, with rainfall recorded across multiple stations between 2:30 pm and 5:30 pm. According to data, Mayur Vihar recorded the highest rainfall at 1 mm, followed by Lodi Road at 0.7



mm, Ayanagar at 0.6 mm, and Safdarjung, Pusa, and Janakpuri at 0.5 mm each. Palam and Ridge recorded 0.2 mm of rainfall.

However, most parts of the city saw little to no rainfall earlier in the day. Between 8:30 am and 2:30 pm, only traces of very light rain were recorded at a few locations. Strong winds accompanied the showers in the late afternoon.

CM Rekha attends mass marriage ceremony



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday attended a grand mass marriage ceremony at Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, where 51 couples were married in a State-supported initiative aimed at promoting dignity, equality, and social support for women.

The event, attended by several prominent dignitaries, focused on supporting brides from economically weaker sections with financial aid, education tools, and long-term welfare measures. “This is not merely a wedding, but a celebration of the dignity and empowerment of daughters,” the CM said.

She said the initiative goes beyond solemnising marriages and reflects a broader commitment to social equality and inclusion. “This is a strong step towards ensuring a safe, dignified, and self-reliant future for daughters,” she added.

The ceremony was held in the presence of spiritual leader Swami Avdheshanand Giri of the Juna Akhara.

Former President Ram Nath Kovind, his wife Savita Kovind, and Union Minister of State for Youth Affairs and Sports Raksha Khadse were also present.

Officials said each bride was provided with a comprehensive support package to help her begin married life with financial stability and independence. This included direct financial assistance of ₹1 lakh.

In addition, after marriage, each bride will receive skill development and training worth up to ₹1 lakh to improve employment opportunities. To encourage education, each bride was given a laptop and e-learning material. Healthcare support was also included in the package. Each bride has been covered under a health insurance scheme of up to ₹7.5 lakh for a period of three years. The premium for the scheme will be borne by the organising institution.

The Chief Minister reiterated that the Delhi Government will continue to support such initiatives that promote inclusivity and respect for women.

LG reviews Bhalswa landfill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu visited the Bhalswa landfill site on Monday to review the progress of ongoing bioremediation efforts and said that while work has picked up in recent years, more needs to be done.

According to a post on X, LG’s official handle posted that the visit comes in the backdrop of Prime Minister Narendra Modi earlier flagging the three major garbage dump sites in the city, namely Bhalswa, Chazipur and Okhla as “mountains of garbage” and calling for their removal, following which work began in 2022. “While significant



progress has been made over the past year, much remains to be done,” the Lieutenant Governor said.

He advised officials to explore emerging global technologies in waste management, along with international benchmarks and expert consultation, to speed up the work. The LG also directed the

Municipal Corporation of Delhi to address not only the legacy waste at the landfill sites but also the continuous inflow of fresh waste, the post on X read. He underscored the need to put preventive measures in place to avoid fire incidents at the dump sites, especially with the onset of summer.

Rajasthan Day celebrated at Delhi Secretariat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday organised a grand cultural event at the Delhi Secretariat to mark Rajasthan Day, with vibrant folk performances and participation from artists showcasing the State’s rich heritage.

The event, organised by the Department of Art, Culture and Languages through the Sahitya Kala Parishad, featured traditional music and dance forms of Rajasthan, drawing attention to the State’s cultural diversity. “Rajasthan has contributed tales of valor and a rich, diverse folk culture,” said Delhi Cabinet Minister Kapil Mishra, who attended the event and extended greetings to the people of Rajasthan.

Around 25 artists performed at the event, presenting well-known folk dance forms such as Kalbelia, Ghoomar, and



Bhavai. The performances captivated the audience and highlighted Rajasthan’s traditional art forms.

Mishra said the event was part of a broader initiative by the Government to celebrate State Foundation Days in line with the vision of “Ek Bharat-Shreshtha Bharat” promoted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. “Under the leadership of Chief Minister, such celebrations are being organised to strengthen national unity,” he said.

National Highways Authority of India (Ministry of Road Transport & Highways, Govt. of India)

PUBLIC NOTICE
National Highway-NH-02 (New NH-19) New User Fee Applicable on Badarpur & Faridabad Toll Plaza
PUBLIC NOTICE ON NEW USER FEE (TOLL) RATES AT TOLL BADARPUR ELEVATED HIGHWAY SECTION (KM. 16.100 TO 20.500) APPLICABLE FROM 01.04.2026

The public are hereby informed that pursuant to the approval of new user fee rates from Competent Authority, NHAI vide e-office, the user fee rates to be effective from 01.04.2026 the user fee rates for use of section from Km. 16.100 to Km. 20.500 (Delhi-Agra Section) of NH-2 are going to be revised as under w.e.f. 01.04.2026 at Badarpur Toll Plaza (Chainage: 18.700 Km.) in the state of New Delhi and at Faridabad Toll Plaza (Chainage: 20.200 Km.) in the state of Haryana:-

Badarpur Elevated Highway Section (KM. 16.100 to 20.500)				
Category of Vehicles/ Applicable fee for completed length of 4.4 Km. (Km.16.100 to 20.500)	Fee for single Journey (Rs.)	Fee for Return Journey within a day (Rs.)	Fee for Monthly Pass Valid for 50 Journeys	Fee for commercial vehicles registered within the district (Rs.)
Car/Jeep/Van/Light Motor Vehicle	35	50	1110	15
LCV/LGV/Mini Bus	55	80	1790	25
Bus/Truck (Two Axles)	115	170	3750	55
Three Axle Commercial Vehicles	125	185	4090	60
Heavy construction Machinery (HCM) or Earth Moving Equipment (EME) of Multi Axle Vehicle (MAV) (4 to 6 Axles)	175	265	5880	90
Oversized Vehicles (Seven or More Axles)	215	320	7160	105

Note: Rate of monthly pass for a person who owns a mechanical vehicle registered for non-commercial purpose and resides within a distance of twenty kilometres from the fee plaza is Rs. 350.00 (Rupees Three Hundred Fifty Only) for the Year 2026-27.

1. Name and address are as under, for any enquiry and/or giving complaint suggestions:-

Toll Agency	IE	PD of NHAI
Mr. Satyandra Singh	Mr. Rajesh Sharma	Mr. Dhiraj Singh
M/s Karmveer	M/s L.N. Malviya Office Project Pvt.,Ltd	National Highways Authority of India, CMU- Mathura. Plot no. 08. Near Toll Plaza Building, Faridabad Haryana-121003
Mobile, no. 8218611660	9812908579	8130006117

BUILDING A NATION, NOT JUST ROADS

National Highways Authority of India (Ministry of Road Transport & Highways, Govt. of India)

PUBLIC NOTICE
National Highway-148 NA New User Fee Applicable on Delhi Vadodara Expressway
PUBLIC NOTICE ON NEW USER FEE (TOLL) RATES AT TOLL KIRANJ (KM. 55-880) NH-148 APPLICABLE FROM 01.04.2026

The public are hereby informed that pursuant to the approval of new user fee rates from Competent Authority, NHAI vide e-office, the user fee rates to be effective from 01.04.2026 at Construction of six-lane Access Controlled Highway from Jaitpur-Pushta Road to Junction near KMP Expressway with: NE-4 (Delhi Vadodara Expressway)-Design Ch. 9.000 to Ch. 59+063 in the states of Delhi & Haryana on Hybrid Annuity Mode under Bharatmala Pariyojana (Package II-III)-NH-148NA. The Revised user fee rates for Kiranj Toll Plaza at Km 55+880 w.e.f., 00:00 Hrs of 01.04.2026 are as under:

NEW USER FEE RATE OF KIRANJ TOLL PLAZA (KM. 55+880)				
Category of Vehicles/ Applicable fee for completed length of 50.063 Km. (Km.9+000 to 59+063)	Fee for single Journey (Rs.)	Fee for Return Journey within a day (Rs.)	Fee for Monthly Pass Valid for 50 Journeys	Fee for commercial vehicles registered within the district (Rs.)
Car/Jeep/Van/Light Motor Vehicle	155	235	5185	80
LCV/LGV/Mini Bus	250	375	8375	125
Bus/Truck (Two Axles)	525	790	17545	265
Three Axle Commercial Vehicles	575	860	19140	285
Heavy construction Machinery (HCM) or Earth Moving Equipment (EME) of Multi Axle Vehicle (MAV) (4 to 6 Axles)	825	1240	27510	415
Oversized Vehicles (Seven or More Axles)	1005	1505	33490	500

Note: Rate of monthly pass for a person who owns a mechanical vehicle registered for non-commercial purpose and resides within a distance of twenty kilometres from the fee plaza is Rs. 350.00 (Rupees Three Hundred Fifty Only) for the Year 2026-27.

1. Name and address are as under, for any enquiry and/or giving complaint suggestions:-

Toll Agency	Concessionaire	IE	PD of NHAI
Mr. Mahadev Singh	Mr. Hemanth Pathak	Mr. Deepil Singh	Mr. Dhiraj Singh
M/s Ayushajay Constructi on Private Limited	M/s Dineshchandra Vaishnodevi Infra Pvt Ltd. & M/s Dineshchandra Giriraj Infra Pvt Ltd, Kiran Toll Plaza, Haryana	M/s Interconfidential Consultants and Technocrats Pvt. Ltd.	National Highways Authority of India, CMU- Mathura. Plot no. 08. Near Toll Plaza Building, Faridabad Haryana-121003
Mobile, no. 8750856310	9582583896	8529745524	8130006117

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RUNGTA IRRIGATION LIMITED
REGD. & HEAD OFFICE:
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Tel: 011-40453330,331,332 | CIN : L74899DL1986PLC023934
E-mail: info@runghairrigation.in | Website: www.runghairrigation.in

POSTAL BALLOT NOTICE TO MEMBERS

The Members of Rungha Irrigation Limited (the “company”) are hereby informed that pursuant to the provisions of section 110 and all other applicable provisions, if any, of Companies Act, 2013 (the “Act”), read together with Rules 20 and 22 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 (including any statutory modification(s) or re-enactment(s) thereof, for the time being in force) (“Rules”), Regulation 44 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (the “SEBI Listing Regulations”), General Circular Nos. 14/2020 dated 8th April, 2020, 17/2020 dated 13th April, 2020, 20/2020 dated 5th May, 2020, 22/2020 dated 15th June, 2020, 33/2020 dated 28th September, 2020, 39/2020 dated 31st December, 2020, 10/2021 dated 23rd June, 2021, 20/2021 dated 8th December, 2021, 3/2022 dated 5th May, 2022, 11/2022 dated 28th December, 2022, 9/2023 dated 25th September, 2023 9/2024 dated 19th September, 2024 and 03/2025 dated 22nd September, 2025 issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, Government of India (MCA Circulars), Secretarial Standard on General Meetings (“SS-2”) (as amended) issued by the Institute of Company Secretaries of India and any other applicable law, rules and regulations (including any statutory modification(s) or re-enactment(s) thereof, for the time being in force) the Company seeks the approval of the Members for the Special Business by way of Ordinary Resolution as set out in the Postal Ballot Notice dated 27th March, 2026 along with the explanatory statement (the “Notice”), by way of electronic means (i.e. remote e-voting) only. Subject matter of the business to be transacted through postal ballot is as follows

S.No.	Description
1.	Increase in Authorised Share Capital and consequential amendment of Memorandum of Association of the Company.

The dispatch of electronic copies of Postal Ballot Notice (“Notice”) along with the Explanatory Statement has been completed on Monday, 30th March, 2026, to those Members whose names appear on the Register of Members/List of Beneficial Owners as on Friday, 27th March 2026 (“cut-off date”) and who have registered their e-mail addresses with the Company/Depositories. Physical copies of the Postal Ballot Notice along with Postal Ballot forms and pre-paid business reply envelopes are not being sent to Members for this Postal Ballot in line with the exemption provided in the MCA Circulars.

The documents referred to in Postal Ballot Notice are available for inspection and members seeking inspection can send an email to cs@runghairrigation.in.

Notice is available on the website of the Company i.e. www.runghairrigation.in and of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and of the NSDL at www.evotingindia.com.

In light of the MCA Circulars, Members who have not registered their e-mail address and in consequence could not receive the Postal Ballot Notice may temporarily get their e-mail address registered with the Company’s RTA, M/s. Beetal Computer Services Private Limited. Post successful registration of the e-mail, the member would get soft copy of the Notice and the procedure for e-voting along with the User ID and Password to enable e-voting for this Postal Ballot.

The Company provides the Members the facility to exercise their right to vote by electronic means through E-voting services provided by National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL). The detailed instructions for E-voting have been provided in the Notice.

The remote E-voting facility is available during the following period:

Commencement of e-voting period	9.00 a.m. IST on Thursday, April 02, 2026
Conclusion of e-voting period	5.00 p.m. IST on Friday, May 01, 2026
Cut-off date for eligibility to vote	Friday, March 27, 2026

The remote e-voting module shall be disabled by NSDL for voting thereafter.

During this period, Members holding shares either in physical form or in dematerialized form as on Friday, 27th March, 2026 (“cut-off date”) may cast their vote by e-voting. Once the vote on a resolution is cast by the Member, he/she is not allowed to change it subsequently. The voting rights of the Members shall be in proportion to their share of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the cut-off date i.e. Friday, 27th March, 2026. A person who is not a member as on the cut-off date should treat this Notice for information purpose only.

The Board of Directors of the Company has appointed M/s Ishant & Associates, Practising Company Secretary (Membership No. FCS132408 & C.P. No. 19941) as the Scrutinizer for conducting the postal ballot process in a fair and transparent manner.

The Scrutinizer will submit his report to the Chairman or any authorised person of the Company and the results of the Postal Ballot will be announced within 2 working days. The said results would be displayed at the Registered Office of the Company and intimated to the BSE Limited (“BSE”) where the shares of the Company are listed. Additionally, the results will also be uploaded on the Company’s website www.runghairrigation.in and on the website of NSDL www.evotingindia.com.

For any queries or grievances pertaining to e-voting, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQS) and e-voting manual available at www.evotingindia.com under help section or shareholders are requested to contact to beetalta@gmail.com or by post to BEETAL HOUSE, 3rd Floor,99, Madangir, Behind LSC, New Delhi - 110062. Shareholders can also contact Pallavi Mhatre, Senior Manager, National Securities Depository Limited, 4th Floor, A Wing, Trade World, Kamala Mills Compound, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai – 400013, India, Contact details: evoting@nsdl.com Contact number- 022 – 4886 7000 during working hours on all working days.

By Order of the Board
For Rungha Irrigation Limited
Sd/-
Rekha Rathore
Company Secretary cum Compliance Officer

Date: March 30, 2026
Place: New Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

Subject: Transfer of Ownership in respect of Entire House no 742, Ward No. 10, Gali no. 10, Near Indira Gandhi Public School, Bhim Nagar, Gurugram, Haryana - 122001 consequent upon the intestate death of Late Sh. Puran Chand S/o Late Sh. Jhangei Ram R/o House No 742, Ward No. 10, Gali No. 10, Near Indira Gandhi Public School, Bhim Nagar, Gurugram, Haryana-122001. As per record Late Sh. Puran Chand has died on 26-10-2021 leaving behind following legal heirs: 1. Mrs. Meenu & Mr. Reshma Daughters. Mrs. Meenu & Mrs. Reshma Daughters intends to apply for transfer of the said in his favour through the legal heirs and requests for transfer deed/ relinquishment deed/ Bank account in the name. If any person is having objection against the transfer of the house he/she can submit objection in writing to the Sub Registrar Gurugram/ concerned Authority, along-in with supporting documents within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice, otherwise the state Office may accord permission to transfer/ Movable and immovable of the said property as per concerned authority policy and may not entertain subsequent claim if any.

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that S Amandeep Singh and Harshan Kaur Sethi (hereinafter called the owners) claims to be owner and in possession of Second Floor, Property No. 87, Block J-6, Rajouri Garden, Delhi State, Delhi (hereinafter called the said property) by virtue of sale deed dated 03.10.2024 regd. Doc. No. 2024/25/126824 executed by Bhupinder Kaur, said Bhupinder Kaur had inherited the said property after the death of Basant Kaur and Harbans Kaur on execution of Relinquishment Deeds dated 04.09.2009 & 17.12.2009 along with Release Deed dated 13.09.2019 Doc. No. 19615 by the legal heirs of Late Basant Kaur and Harbans Kaur, and said Basant Kaur and Harbans Kaur were the owner of said property by virtue of sale deed dated 10.10.1966 regd. Doc. No. 13724, said Owner's have agreed to create a mortgage in favour of our clients Indus Bank Ltd., Hyatt Regency, Bilkaji Casa Place, Delhi., any person's having claim against the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, lien or otherwise howsoever, are hereby intimating to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned and our client shall proceed with the disbursement of loan and subsequent creation of mortgage in respect thereof. Vishal Diwan (Advocate) Diwan & Company Ho.No.2 (LGF), NRI Complex, N.D-19 Mobile No. 9818399999

DJB’s Summer Action Plan prioritises water conservation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Unveiling the Delhi Jal Board (DJB)’s annual “Summer Action Plan-2026”, Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Monday appealed to the people to conserve water, focusing on improving water distribution, AI integration and long-term planning. Water demand in the city reaches its peak during the summer season; for this, the Delhi Government comes up with its summer action plan. Under this water production target of 1002 million gallons per day has been set this year.

Singh has urged the people not to leave the tap running while brushing, shaving, washing dishes and clothes; do not use a hose to wash the car; use half a bucket of water and a cloth to clean your car

better; and use a broom to sweep your doorway or garage sidewalk instead of using water.

Singh said that the DJB has deployed 1,221 water tankers this summer season to provide water to deficit areas and increase water production through additional tubewells. All the tankers will be tracked through the GPS.

“Despite challenges, we are working to provide drinking water to the growing population of Delhi. Our sources of water are limited, and there are several hurdles in installing new areas for borewells, but it is our responsibility to ensure that every citizen receives an adequate supply,” Singh said.

According to the plan, to augment the water supply, the DJB will install 436 additional tubewells soon at

various locations, after which about 6,290 tubewells will be in operation. Additionally, 500 water ATMs will also be installed at places with high footfall, providing drinking water.

Currently, the DJB has nine water treatment plants, which treat raw water, mostly from the Yamuna River, to supply lakhs of residents of the city. However, this supply occasionally gets disrupted because of high levels of pollution in the raw water.

The water minister said that providing water is the work of ‘Punya’ (good deed) and that the water tanker system is just a temporary solution till the current problems are resolved.

“There will be continuous monitoring of raw water quality, including ammonia levels, to avoid disruptions.



DJB is also taking up the upgradation of old pumps, motors and electro-mechanical systems to enhance efficiency,” the plan States. “We

are planning for the next 50 years. A water master plan is being prepared. Also, the new tankers have GPS installed in them. It is estimat-

ed that in the next few years, 20 lakh flats are going to be added in Delhi; we are taking this into account while planning,” he added.

Singh said that digitisation through artificial intelligence integration has started, and the DJB has tied up with IIT-Kanpur, which is working on projects like an AI chatbot.

The water minister also said that in the next two years, DJB will complete the Chandrawal water treatment plant upgradation project, which will resolve the water management system in at least 10 Assembly constituencies; other areas will also be developed similarly.

The water minister launched a new system for complaint tracking and escalation, the DJB 1,916 mobile app for real-time complaint registration and an AI-powered Chatbot for instant grievance support.

“Earlier, outdated systems slowed down our work. Today, we are introducing modern,

transparent systems where citizens themselves can monitor services, clean water supply, and Yamuna rejuvenation are not just duties, but a shared responsibility. With the Summer Action Plan 2026-27, our focus is clear: 1 reliable water supply, 2 technology-driven transparency, as this is not just about systems, it’s about delivering results on the ground,” he said.

Under the summer action plan, DJB has also informed that out of 1,799 unauthorised colonies, water pipelines have been laid in 1,646 colonies. “Work on remaining colonies is ongoing in a phased manner,” the plan added. The water minister also said that the Delhi Government is discussing with the Haryana Government for 51 cusecs of additional water.

Metro disruption after man falls on track at Vishwavidyalaya

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Services on the Delhi Metro’s Yellow Line were disrupted for nearly one-and-a-half hours during the Monday morning rush after a 52-year-old man fell onto the tracks at Vishwavidyalaya station.

The incident led to delays, overcrowding, and longer waiting times across several stations on one of the Capital’s busiest corridors. “A passenger fell on the track at Vishwavidyalaya station and sustained injuries. He was shifted to the hospital. Services were regulated briefly for safety,” a senior officer from the Metro unit said.

According to the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), train movement on the Yellow Line was slowed as a precaution after the incident. In a post on X, DMRC said there was



a delay in services “due to a passenger on the track at Vishwavidyalaya metro station.”

The disruption occurred during peak office hours, affecting thousands of commuters travelling between North and Central Delhi. The Yellow Line connects key areas, including Samaypur Badli, Kashmere Gate, Central Secretariat, and HUDA City Centre, making it one of the busiest routes in the network.

Eyewitnesses and com-

muters reported heavy crowding on platforms as trains arrived at longer intervals. “It’s office time, and there is a huge rush. Even when trains are coming, they are too crowded to board easily,” said Amit, a commuter waiting at one of the stations.

The injured was identified as Anil Kumar, a resident of Karawal Nagar in north-east Delhi. Police said Kumar told them that he accidentally fell onto the tracks after losing balance while stand-

ing close to the edge of the platform. “He stated that he went too close to the edge and lost balance. There is no foul play suspected,” an officer said.

Kumar suffered a head injury but was conscious when admitted to the hospital. His condition is reported to be stable. Officials clarified that the incident appears to be accidental and not a case of intentional jumping.

Following standard safety protocols, train services were temporarily regulated on the affected stretch to ensure passenger safety and allow emergency response teams to act. This resulted in a cascading effect on train frequency across the line, leading to crowd build-up at multiple stations. Metro authorities restored normal services after about 90 minutes. However, the ripple impact of the disruption was felt for some time even after operations resumed.

President urges youth to remember India’s martyrs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Monday called upon the nation, especially the youth, to keep alive the memory of India’s martyrs, as Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta met her to commemorate the 1919 Rowlatt Satyagraha in Chandni Chowk.

During the meeting at Rashtrapati Bhavan, the President emphasised the need to remain connected to the sacrifices made during the freedom struggle. “We must keep the flame of remembrance burning bright. The sacrifice of our martyrs is the fuel for this flame,” she said.

Speaker Vijender Gupta briefed the President on the historical significance of March 30, 1919, when a peaceful protest against the Rowlatt Act in Delhi turned tragic after British forces opened fire on unarmed

demonstrators. The President also urged young people to remain rooted in patriotism. “Whatever you become, never let the spirit of patriotism and the memory of our martyrs fade from your heart,” she said, stressing that the present generation must understand the price paid for India’s freedom.

The meeting marked the anniversary of the historic Rowlatt Satyagraha, one of the earliest mass protests against British rule. Gupta apprised the President that over 50 unarmed Indians were killed when British troops opened fire near the Old Delhi Railway Station during a peaceful procession led by Swami Shraddhanand.

He also highlighted that Mahatma Gandhi was present in Delhi at the time and later reflected on the unity displayed during the protest. Gandhi had described the strike as unprecedented, noting the coming together of



Hindus and Muslims in a shared cause. During the interaction, Gupta presented a coffee table book titled ‘Shatabdi Yatra-Vir Vithalbhai Patel’, published by the Delhi Assembly Secretariat. The President directed that the book be included in the Rashtrapati Bhavan Library, acknowledging its historical and archival value.

Officials said the President personally reviewed accounts of the 1919 event

and appreciated efforts to document this chapter of history. She noted that such initiatives play a key role in preserving the legacy of India’s freedom movement.

Gupta said the event was not merely ceremonial but a reminder of the sacrifices that shaped India’s democratic foundations. He reaffirmed the Assembly’s commitment to preserving and promoting the city’s historical and political legacy.

नमो अरिहंताणं, नमो सिद्धाणं

भगवान

महावीर

जयंती

की समस्त देशवासियों को

हार्दिक शुभकामनाएं

शांति, संयम और सद्भावना से जुड़े भगवान महावीर के संदेश विकसित भारत के निर्माण में देश के लिए प्रेरणापुंज हैं।

- नरेन्द्र मोदी, प्रधानमंत्री

सत्यमेव जयते

दिल्ली सरकार

DIP/Shabdarth/Display/0162/25-26

IN FOCUS



A man walks past shikaras holding an umbrella during rainfall at Dal Lake in Srinagar on Monday

Camels used to smuggle liquor into Delhi, 1 arrested



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's Special Staff, South District, busted an illicit liquor smuggling racket with an unusual twist: the contraband was not being moved in a truck or an auto. It was loaded onto two camels and walked through forest routes into the Capital in the dead of night.

One accused, Vinod Bhadana, 48, a resident of Village Anandpur in Faridabad, Haryana, was arrested in the early hours of Sunday from the Sangam Vihar forest area. Police recovered 39 cartons of illicit liquor, totalling 1,938 quarters, along with the two camels and equipment used to carry the load.

The logic behind Bhadana's method was straightforward and, in its own way, audacious.

Intensified checking on roads connecting Delhi and Faridabad under Operation Kavach had made conventional transportation too risky. So Bhadana turned to forest routes and animals that no checkpoint was built to stop.

By loading liquor onto camels and navigating through the forest belt between Faridabad and Sangam Vihar, he could bypass every checking point, every patrol, every CCTV camera on the road. It was an old smuggler's trick adapted for modern enforcement pressure, and it very nearly worked.

On the intervening night of March 29 and 30, specific intelligence was received about the smuggling attempt. A strategic trap was laid in the Sangam Vihar forest area.

Shadow of red terror lifted, Amit Shah tells...

"Lay down your arms, and the Government will ensure your rehabilitation," he said. However, he drew a sharp line, "Our Government's policy is clear, we are open to dialogue with those who surrender their weapons. Those who choose violence will be met with a firm response."

The discussion quickly turned political, with BJP members accusing the Congress of allowing Maoism to proliferate during its nearly 60 years in power out of India's 75 years of independence. Shah escalated the critique, linking the human cost of the insurgency directly to past Governmental failure. Maoist violence has claimed the lives of approximately 20,000 young people and affected over 120 million citizens, he noted. "It was a failure of the Congress Government that tribal and several other communities were deprived of development," Shah said. "Over the last 75 years, the Congress party governed for 60 years. Why, then, did the tribal communities remain deprived of development?", Shah thundered.

"He invoked a statement by former Prime Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh, who had described Naxalism as a greater internal threat than militancy in Kashmir or the North-East." Despite this, nothing was done," Shah remarked, underscoring what the BJP portrays as historic inaction by the previous regime.

The March 31, 2026 deadline was first prominently set by Shah in late 2025 and repeatedly reaffirmed in 2026 during visits to Bastar and other affected regions. Earlier this year, he had highlighted an 85 per cent drop in civilian killings by Naxalites and the liberation of 9 per cent of previously Maoist-dominated areas. Development indicators in Bastar, including reopened schools, new roads, mobile towers, electricity, and drinking water have been cited as proof that security gains are being converted into tangible progress for tribal populations.

While the Government expresses confidence that the March 31 target will be met, officials have indicated that residual pockets, if any, will be addressed through continued operations and development in the months ahead, with a longer-term vision to make Bastar one of India's most developed tribal regions within five years.

Shah's speech marks a confident assertion that India is on the cusp of fulfilling a long-standing national security goal. For years, Maoist groups controlled large swathes of the "Red Corridor" across several states, running parallel administrations and exploiting tribal grievances. The Modi Government's multi-pronged approach and intelligence-led operations, infrastructure development under schemes like the Aspirational Districts Programme, and surrender-and-rehabilitation policies, has been credited with steadily shrinking the insurgency's footprint.

As the clock ticks down to March 31, 2026's

Iranian aircraft hit in airstrikes before humanitarian mission

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

An Iranian aircraft scheduled to fly to New Delhi to collect humanitarian supplies was damaged in airstrikes attributed to the United States and Israel, just days before its planned departure, according to diplomatic sources.

The aircraft, operated by Mahan Air, was set to depart from Mashhad and arrive in the Indian capital on Wednesday morning. Its mission was to transport medicines procured by the Iranian embassy in India using funds donated by Indian citizens during the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

Officials familiar with the development said the plane sustained damage on Sunday, disrupting the planned humanitarian operation. The medicines, intended for civilians affected by the conflict, were purchased through contributions collected over several weeks. The Iranian embassy actively facilitated donations, including sharing bank details and digital payment options to streamline contributions.



Despite the setback, Iranian authorities are reportedly working to arrange an alternative flight in the coming days to ensure the supplies reach their destination.

The incident comes amid a rapidly escalating conflict involving Iran, Israel, and the United States, now entering its fifth week. The hostilities have intensified recently, with repeated strikes targeting critical infrastructure across the region.

The broader crisis has had significant humanitarian and economic repercussions. An

attack in Kuwait recently resulted in the death of an Indian national, highlighting the risks faced by expatriates. Indian authorities have reiterated that the safety of citizens abroad remains a top priority, especially in a region that is home to millions of Indians.

The conflict has also disrupted global energy markets. Military activity around the Strait of Hormuz — a vital route for global oil shipments — has led to supply concerns and rising crude prices. In response, the United States has temporarily

eased certain sanctions to stabilise oil availability.

Diplomatic efforts to de-escalate tensions are ongoing, with multiple countries engaging in dialogue to broker peace. However, the situation on the ground remains volatile, with continued exchanges of strikes and growing regional instability.

As tensions persist, the damage to the Iranian aircraft underscores the wider impact of the conflict, extending beyond military targets to humanitarian initiatives aimed at aiding civilians caught in the crisis.

CAG slams MEA for over ₹30 crore in avoidable waste

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delay in finalising the licence fee for its office space in Akbar Bhawan in New Delhi with the NDMC by the MEA led to an avoidable expenditure of ₹27 crores, the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) in its report on Monday said. The financial watchdog also flagged cases like not undertaking timely repairs in the Indian embassy in China, and its embassy in Denmark not adhering to the rental ceiling, which also caused wasteful and avoidable expenditure. Similarly, the delay by the Indian embassy and the MEA in Israel for acquiring a property there also led to unnecessary financial outgo, the report said.

The report tabled in the parliament lays cracks in the

ministry's fiscal oversight, which include ₹27.43 crore excess expenditure on unused space in Delhi, ₹3.22 crore avoidable rent due to uninhabitable embassy housing in Beijing and others.

The report state that the ministry retained the unutilised space at Akbar Bhawan, New Delhi, for 15 months without formalising pro-rata license fees with the New Delhi Municipal Corporation for the space actually utilised by it, which resulted in excess expenditure of ₹27.43 crore towards licence fee for unutilised space.

Though the Embassy of India, Beijing, China, had incurred significant expenditure on repairs and maintenance of 16 residential units constructed in 2011 in the New Chancery Premises, six residential units had become



uninhabitable within a span of 10 to 13 years. Delay in carrying out necessary comprehensive repairs and renovation of these six vacant units resulted in avoidable rental outgo of ₹3.22 crore up to

February 2025. Moreover, the mission had made continued payment of heating charges for the Old Chancery Premises, which was not in use since 2014, leading to wasteful expenditure of ₹74

SP insults constitutional institutions, PM: Yogi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Monday accused the Samajwadi Party of insulting the constitutional institutions by commenting on the Election Commission, the judiciary, and the prime minister.

He also accused the party of renaming a college in Kannauj named after B R Ambedkar, and another in Lucknow named after BSP founder Kanshi Ram.

"In other words, while they could not build institutions themselves, they were experts at changing their names. This stemmed from their deep-seated animosity. Even today, by engaging in such acts, they continue to insult society," Adityanath said at an event where students were disbursed scholarship money.

The SP insulted constitutional institutions, which was akin to insulting Ambedkar, the chief architect of the Constitution, the chief minister alleged.

"They make remarks about the Parliament. They make insulting comments on the prime minister, the leader who speaks for Sabka Saath,



Sabka Vikas'. They make comments on the Election Commission and the judiciary. To question India's constitutional institutions and to point fingers at India's national symbols means an insult to the Constitution drafted by Babasaheb Bhimrao Ambedkar... and the Dalits of India can never accept that," he said.

Adityanath said the party insulted Vande Mataram and the National Anthem.

"They will divide society on caste lines. And, when they were in power, they did everything solely to sustain and enrich their own family. These are the people who divide society by creating social discord. In the name of appeasement, they played with national security. It was precisely because of their nefarious deeds that this state had become a 'BIMARU' (sick) state," said the BJP leader.

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data sets will be published in 2027 itself," Narayan added. He also said that individual data collected for the Census 2027 will be kept confidential under Section 15 of the Census Act, 1948 urging citizens to give accurate information to Census enumerators.

During the self-enumeration process, a person can fill in the details of her household on a dedicated portal and once it is submitted, a self-enumeration number is generated. This ID is to be handed over to the enumerator during the field visit and after confirming the self-enumeration data, the enumerator will include it in the original database. The 'Houselisting and Housing Census' is the first phase of Census and will be conducted across India between April 1 and September 30 during which details related to housing conditions, assets and households amenities are collected.

This will be followed by the second phase in February next year when population is counted, and details of caste, demographic, socio-economic, cultural and other details of every person in each household are collected.

Asked about caste being included in the Census and the apprehension that people may not give correct information, the Registrar General said the data related to caste will be collected during the second phase, and the questions will be decided after exhaustive discussions. Since the individual data shared by any person with a Census enumerator will be strictly confidential and cannot be used to derive benefit from any Government scheme, he said the apprehension that it will be misused is misplaced.

The last comprehensive caste-based count was done between 1881 and 1931. Caste was excluded from all census operations conducted since Independence.

End of Nitish era stirs emotion, uncertainty...

Sources in the JD(U) have asserted that they will insist on a fair share in the new Cabinet with Nitish's son Nishant as Deputy CM, and a lightweight CM. A bigger, well-known CM would make it difficult for JD(U) to negotiate the alliance at a later stage.

Pramod Kumar (Chandravanshi), Environment and Forests and Cooperatives Minister in Bihar, joined the BJP in 2023. He previously contested the 2020 Assembly elections as an Independent from Obra and is an MLC. Known for his clean record, Chandravanshi, a Kahar by caste, holds a degree from Magadh University and comes from a humble background.

Another lesser-known politician, Dharamshilla Gupta, entered the Rajya Sabha in February 2024 in place of the late Deputy CM Sushil Modi. Gupta, who hails from Darbhanga, is considered to be in the race because she suits the party's agenda of having one more woman as CM to also give a polit-

ical message in the neighbouring poll-bound West Bengal, governed by Mamata Banerjee. "Madam Gupta may be one choice if we recall the remarks of Prime Minister Narendra Modi after the massive win of NDA in last year's assembly polls. PM had mentioned the Ganga will flow now from Bihar to Bengal, where elections are scheduled in April 2026," as a senior BJP functionary said. Names of other probables doing the rounds are Samrat Choudhary, the Deputy Chief Minister who holds the crucial Home portfolio. Choudhary is a Koeri, a numerically significant OBC group which has so far not been aligned with any particular party, unlike the Yadavs, who are die-hard supporters of Lalu Prasad's RJD, or the Kurmis who revere Nitish Kumar. But a drawback in his appointment could be his nearly two decades of association with RJD and JD(U), before joining the BJP.

Another prominent name doing the rounds is that of Nityanand Rai, a former state BJP president, who is the deputy of Home Minister Amit Shah. Meanwhile, Leader of Opposition Tejashwi Yadav alleged that Nitish Kumar was "forced" to resign. "The BJP has not just swindled him but the entire electorate of Bihar," he said.

CCTV norms tightened, Chinese companies hit

Sources said more than 500 CCTV models have already received certification under the new regime, so the framework is operational and the process is moving.

CCTV and surveillance devices are considered critical as they collect sensitive data. They also monitor important public spaces like — airports, Government buildings and transport hubs.

Chinese experts and industry insiders have sharply criticized the move, arguing that it is essentially a discriminatory trade protection measure disguised as "cybersecurity," which not only violates international trade rules but also harms India's own market interests. According to *Global Times*, India's new rules lack reasonable justification and constitute targeted trade discrimination.

Police crack metro poster plot, LeT coordinator...

Acting on specific intelligence, the Special Cell team, led by DCP Praveen Kumar Tripathi, laid a trap in the Gazipur area and arrested the individual around 10:30 pm. "This is a significant breakthrough. The accused was actively working to radicalise and recruit vulnerable youth. His arrest has prevented further expansion of the network," said Additional Commissioner of Police (Special Cell) Pramod Singh Kushwah.

In February, anti-national posters glorifying slain militant Burhan Wani and carrying pro-terror slogans were pasted at metro stations, including

Janpath, and at multiple locations in Delhi and Kolkata. Eight operatives were arrested, but the man pulling the strings was still at large. That man was Lone. The posters pasted in Delhi and Kolkata were sent to Lone by Pakistan-based, LeT commander, Sumama Babar, the police said. They were pasted by Malda-based Umar Farooq and Bangladeshi national Robi ul Islam. The duo also conducted reconnaissance of high-footfall areas in India, particularly commercial and religious sites, the police added.

According to the police, Lone's radicalisation began in his own village. Between 2004 and 2005, LeT terrorists, including Abu Huzaifa, frequently visited his locality for food and logistical support. Abu Huzaifa recruited him into LeT during that period. In 2007, the Special Cell arrested Lone in a case involving the recovery of a heavy cache of arms and ammunition, including AK-47 rifles and grenades. He was convicted. In 2016, he was arrested again in an arms case in Parimpora, J&K, alongside one Sajjad Gul. Gul, who was later released, fled to Pakistan, and now heads The Resistance Front: a LeT offshoot behind several terror strikes, including the Pahalgam attack.

By 2025, — based LeT commander Babar tasked Lone with a new mission: recruit Bangladeshis and Indian youth from states beyond J&K for terror operations on Indian soil. Lone shifted to Gurugram, recruited Farukh, a co-accused in the metro poster case, and in March 2025, crossed into Bangladesh with his family. He set up a base in Saidpur, Bangladesh, and even married a local Bangladeshi woman to blend in with the local population, the police claim.

Delhi Police termed Lone a "hardcore and highly trained terrorist" who had established direct links with ISI-backed handlers. Investigators believe his arrest has prevented fresh recruitment of vulnerable youth into LeT's ranks at a critical juncture.

TDS rules updated, savings rate steady

It added that the scope also covers banks and banking institutions referred to under Section 51 of that Act, even if not explicitly mentioned in the new law. As a result, such institutions will not be required to deduct income tax on amounts below the specified thresholds under Section 393(1). Separately, the Government said it has decided to keep interest rates on small savings schemes unchanged for the eighth consecutive quarter, starting April 1, 2026. In a notification, the finance ministry said rates for the April-June quarter of FY 2026-27 will remain the same as those in the January-March quarter of FY 2025-26. With this decision, interest rates on small savings instruments widely used by retail investors through post offices and banks have now remained steady since the last revision in the fourth quarter of 2023-24.

Nishikant Dubey refutes claims of disrespecting Biju Patnaik

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The BJP's Nishikant Dubey on Monday refuted allegations that he disrespected Biju Patnaik, asserting that he always held the former Odisha chief minister in high regard, as political leaders from the State hit back at the MP.

Dubey, in a statement on March 27, had claimed that Patnaik was the link between former Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru and the (US spy agency) CIA during the war against China in the 1960s.

"There has never been any lack of respect for Biju Patnaik. When the Congress treated Biju Babu unjustly, it was the Jana Sangh and the Bharatiya Janata Party that stood by him. What I said that day, and what I repeat again today, is that I am running a continuous series exposing the deeds of the Nehru-Gandhi family and the Congress," Dubey told reporters in the Parliament House complex on Monday.



This came after the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) on Monday staged a walkout from the Rajya Sabha, protesting purportedly disparaging remarks by Dubey against Patnaik.

Soon after the official listed papers were laid on the table, BJD leader Sasmit Patra rose to record a "serious protest against the disparaging, false and concocted statements made by MP Nishikant Dubey against Biju Patnaik".

"He (Dubey) has called Biju Patnaik a CIA agent. This is the level to which the ruling party has fallen," Patra said. "This is utterly shame-

ful. Biju Janata Dal strongly opposes it and in protest we are walking out."

Patra had on Saturday (March 28, 2026) resigned from the Parliamentary Standing Committee on IT and Communications, protesting panel chairperson Dubey's remarks.

Condemning Dubey's comments, BJD chief Naveen Patnaik said, "I think the BJP MP needs some mental doctor's attention for saying these outrageous things."

BJP national vice-president Baijayan Panda said Biju Patnaik's patriotism could never be questioned.

"Biju uncle was a towering personality, not just Odisha's tallest leader of his era, but among the leading lights of the nation. Most importantly, he was one of the greatest patriots of modern Bharat.

"National pride burned deep in his veins & he dedicated his life to liberating India & uplifting Odisha. He did that as a pilot, industrialist, political leader, & global trouble shooter," Panda said in a post on X.

"Casting aspersions on his patriotism is fantastical & patently ludicrous. Such attacks on him are unworthy, uninformed, & totally unacceptable," Panda said, without naming Dubey.

Patnaik, a two-time Chief Minister of Odisha (1961-63 and 1990-95), was a freedom fighter and aviator known for his role in daring missions, including flying to Jakarta in 1947 to rescue Indonesian independence leaders and participating in operations linked to the Battle of Stalingrad during World War II.

Omar Abdullah vows to protect walnut trees in J&K

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Citing serious risks to the region's economy and identity, Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Monday said that his Government will not allow indiscriminate felling of walnut trees. He said the Union Territory is contributing nearly 3.5 lakh tonnes, over 90 per cent of the country's total walnut production.

Opposing the private members' bill moved by National Conference legislator Altaf Ahmad Wani seeking amendment in the Jammu and Kashmir Preservation of Specified Trees, Act, to grant owners the free will to cut Walnut trees on their land, Abdullah said, while land and trees may belong to individuals, restrictions on cutting them exist for valid reasons, including conservation and long-term economic interests.

He said, similar to protections extended to chinar trees, several other species are safeguarded under existing frameworks. Highlighting the economic stakes, he said walnuts form



a significant component of the region's economy.

"If unrestricted permission is given, people may cut walnut trees, but may not replant them. Instead, there is a risk of land being diverted for construction, which would reduce walnut production to negligible levels," he said.

The chief minister acknowledged concerns about corruption in the permission process, stating that such issues arise wherever restrictions exist. He suggested that bringing permissions for tree felling under the Public Services Guarantee Act with fixed timelines could help reduce delays and curb corruption.

Ashwini Vaishnaw proposes centre of excellence at Gati Shakti Vishwavidyalay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said on Monday that a Centre of Excellence should be established at Gati Shakti Vishwavidyalay (GSV) for development of talent in the field of manufacturing technology.

Gati Shakti Vishwavidyalay (GSV), a central university established in 2022 in Vadodara, Gujarat, under the railway ministry, follows a demand-driven curriculum to meet the industry needs of the transportation sector.

Addressing the media during an MoU signing event between GSV and the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) to revamp training for aircraft maintenance engineering, Vaishnaw said manufacturing technology training for sectors such as aviation, railways, marine, electronics, etc needed a high level of precision and effort.

He sought support from Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu, who was present in the event, for the initiative and expressed gratitude after receiving an affirmative response. "If we



establish this Centre of Excellence at Gati Shakti Vishwavidyalay, catering to manufacturing technology, it will be a very significant

step," Vaishnaw said, urging senior aviation and railway officials to prepare a blueprint.

He asked officials to follow

the precision training standards of developed countries such as Germany, the US, and Japan to design the course and to set a high-level benchmark without worrying about the financial aspect. "At least about 1,000 students should receive quality training in manufacturing technology courses every year," he added, urging officials to also seek assistance from industry.

Officials said that under the MoU, both GSV and the DGCA will collaboratively design a future-ready three-year BSc (AME) curriculum

that seamlessly integrates academic depth, regulatory compliance, and industry-aligned competencies to power India's next-generation MRO (Maintenance, Repair, and Overhaul) workforce.

Calling the MoU a historic milestone, Aviation Minister Naidu said that the initiative will transform the overall aviation sector in terms of the workforce that it is trying to build for the future. He said as the aviation sector is growing at a great pace, its workforce needs to be built up to global standards.

Government restores kerosene distribution amid energy crisis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Government has allowed ad-hoc allocation of public distribution system (PDS) kerosene in 21 States and Union Territories, including regions previously classified as kerosene-free, to support household cooking and lighting needs amid global energy supply pressures. The move follows the month-long war in West Asia, disrupting the energy supply chain, particularly cooking gas LPG.

India imports 60 per cent of its cooking gas needs, 85-90 per cent of which comes from the Gulf countries. The war has stopped those supplies, forcing the curtailment of supplies to commercial users like hotels and restaurants.

While domestic households have been given priority in the supply of the available LPG, the limited stocks have led to panic buying and long queues.

To ease pressure on LPG, the Government allowed the temporary use of kerosene for cooking and lighting throughout the country, including the 21 States and UTs that were previously declared kerosene-free.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas has issued a notification allowing temporary exemptions under the



Petroleum Act, 1934 and Petroleum Rules, 2002, to facilitate the distribution of PDS kerosene in 21 States and UTs, according to a gazette notification of March 29.

Under the notification, up to two designated PSU oil marketing company (OMC) service stations per district - preferably company-owned and operated - will be permitted to store up to 5,000 litres of kerosene, subject to prescribed safety conditions.

Agents and dealers have been exempted from obtaining licences for decanting kerosene at these designated stations, while tank vehicles with existing licences will also not require additional permits for the same purpose.

The exemptions are conditional on strict adherence to safety norms and operational guidelines issued by the Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation (PESO).

Rescind FCRA amendments in interest of Constitutional morality: CPI(M)

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CPI(M) on Monday demanded the rescinding of the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, in the interest of "constitutional morality," warning that it may bring excessive Government control and erode federalism. In a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, party general secretary MA Baby expressed "deep concern" over the proposed amendment.

"We demand, in the interest of constitutional morality and democratic principles, that the Government immediately rescind this legisla-

tion," Baby said in the letter.

The CPI(M) leader said the proposed amendments "cross the threshold from reasonable regulation to excessive control, enabling executive overreach", even as he acknowledged the State's prerogative to regulate the flow of foreign contributions to ensure transparency and national security.

Baby pointed out that the bill proposes the creation of a powerful 'Designated Authority' empowered to take over, manage, and dispose of assets created out of foreign funds by NGOs whose registration has been suspended, cancelled, or not renewed.

"This is an extreme provi-



sion that threatens the very existence of civil society organisations," he said.

"Granting the executive the power to permanently vest such assets, without adequate judicial oversight, amounts to a punitive measure that goes far

beyond the scope of regulatory oversight," he said.

The Left leader said the bill's provision mandating that the State Governments seek prior approval from the Union to initiate any FCRA-related investigation undermines "the federal structure enshrined in

Katra-Baramulla rail line inspected ahead of launch

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Ahead of launching the rail services between the Kashmir valley and the rest of the country, General Manager, Northern Railway, Rajesh Kumar Pandey, inspected the Katra-Baramulla rail line and directed officials to complete pending works within timelines while ensuring strict safety compliance.

Accompanied by the Divisional Railway Manager, Jammu Vivek Kumar and other senior divisional officials, Pandey carried out an extensive inspection from



Katra to Srinagar on Sunday and from Budgam to Baramulla on Monday, a Public Relations Officer said in a statement.

He said the GM reviewed the Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Line (USBRL) project to assess operational

readiness. Pandey conducted a rigorous examination of the safety of railway tracks, bridges, and tunnels, particularly given the region's challenging terrain.

During his inspection, he issued directives to all divisional officials to ensure the

completion of all pending works within the stipulated timelines and to strictly adhere to safety standards in operations without any compromise.

"This inspection marks a significant step towards establishing direct rail connectivity between Kashmir Valley and the rest of India," the statement said.

Presently, a train service including Vande Bharat express are operating from Katra in Jammu region to Srinagar since June last year following completion of the USBRL project and its inauguration by the Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Nation Focus



Kejriwal arrives in Goa to campaign for Ponda bypoll

Aam Aadmi Party national convener Arvind Kejriwal arrived in Goa on Monday to campaign for his party's candidate in the Ponda bypoll scheduled for April 9. Party leaders said he will be meeting renowned seer Swami Brahmeshanand in Kundaime near Ponda and visit St Annes Church on Tuesday. The former Delhi chief minister will address a public meeting in Ponda on Wednesday, they added. Businessman Geetesh Naik is AAP's candidate for Ponda bypoll. He will take on BJP's Ritesh Naik, son of former agriculture minister Ravi Naik, whose death necessitated the bypoll. The Congress has fielded physiotherapist Dr Ketan Bhatikar.



Not right to play politics over war: Priyanka slams PM

Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Monday hit back at Prime Minister Narendra Modi after he accused the opposition party of making "dangerous" remarks that could put Indians living in the Gulf at risk, and said it is not right to play politics over war. She also asked what plan does the Government have to bring Indians stranded in the Gulf out of harm's way. Her remarks came a day after Modi accused the Congress of making "dangerous" remarks that could put Indians living in the Gulf at risk to gain political advantage. Asked about the PM's remarks, Priyanka Gandhi told reporters in the Parliament House complex, "Lives are in danger because bombs are raining from above. What is he doing about that? What is the plan for bringing people out of harm's way? It is not right to do politics on these things, on war."

our Constitution."

"This creates an environment of fear where organisations working in areas such as human rights, environmental protection, and minority welfare may find themselves targeted not for violations of law, but for dissent against Government policies," he said.

Baby said the bill places minority institutions under an excessively stringent regulatory framework, raising serious concerns about undue interference in their functioning, and noted "with dismay" that no consultations were done before its drafting.

"The Government's hostility towards non-

Governmental organisations is evident in the series of amendments made to the FCRA since 2016. The cumulative effect of these amendments has been to make the functioning of NGOs increasingly difficult," he alleged.

"The 2026 Bill is a continuation of this trend, threatening to effectively 'kill' organisations that accept legitimate foreign contributions for charitable, educational, or human rights work," he said.

He demanded that the bill must be rescinded, and all contentious provisions that "empower the executive to seize and manage assets without judicial oversight" be withdrawn.

9 Maoists surrender in Andhra Pradesh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Amaravati

Nine Maoists, including senior leader C Narayana Rao, have surrendered before police, Andhra Pradesh DGP Harish Kumar Gupta said on Monday.

He also claimed that "Left Wing Extremism (LWE) has come to an end in the State".

The DGP observed that the central Government promised to end LWE before March 31, 2026 and the State police has also contributed its bit towards this goal.

According to Gupta, Rao was secretary of Andhra Odisha Border (AOB) and had operated in the Maoist move-

ment for 36 years.

"The Centre gave a promise that it would bring an end to LWE before March 31, 2026. In this process, we did our bit over the last two years. Today, LWE has come to an end in Andhra Pradesh," Gupta told reporters.

The top cop noted that incidents like exchange of fire and surrenders have occurred, including operations carried out by special forces, greyhounds and other units.

On the latest development, the DGP said the police gave a call to the Maoists to surrender and integrate into the mainstream society.



Kerala CM accepts LoP Satheesan's debate challenge ahead of polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

With days left for the crucial Assembly elections, Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan on Monday accepted Leader of Opposition VD Satheesan's challenge for a public debate, intensifying the political heat ahead of the April 9 polls.

A day after Satheesan threw the challenge, Vijayan, in a social media post, shared what he described as the LDF Government's "report card" and said the debate could be held based on its

listed achievements. Highlighting what he termed an "A-plus" performance of his Government, the chief minister asked whether the opposition was ready to engage on those points.

Soon after, Satheesan said he was prepared to participate in the debate at a time and venue decided by the chief minister. "Now that the chief minister has said he is ready for a debate, he can decide the place and time. I will be there accordingly. Let the people decide the rest," Satheesan said in a Facebook post.

Addressing a press confer-



ence in Kollam later, Vijayan welcomed the Opposition's readiness for a debate, noting that the Assembly remained the most important forum for discussions in the State.

He alleged that the opposition had failed to raise issues



effectively in the Assembly and ran away from the debates and discussions there, fearing replies from the ruling front.

The UDF had not even moved any adjournment motion against the Government during the last session

■ States Focus ■



PM PAYS TRIBUTE TO FREEDOM FIGHTER SHYAMJI KRISHNA VARMA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday paid tributes to freedom fighter Shyamji Krishna Varma on his death anniversary and said his life and ideals will continue to inspire every generation to serve the country. Varma was born on October 4, 1857, in Mandvi town of Kutch district in Gujarat and died on this day in 1930. "Homage to the brave son of Mother India, Shyamji Krishna Varma, on his death anniversary. Through his revolutionary ideas, he awakened a new consciousness in the freedom movement. His life and ideals will continue to inspire every generation of the nation to serve the country," Modi said in a post on X.



VIJAY FILES NOMINATION FROM PERAMBUR IN CHENNAI

TVK chief, actor-politician Vijay on Monday filed his nomination to contest Assembly polls from Perambur constituency in Chennai and appealed to the people to give an opportunity to his party TVK and vote for the party's whistle symbol on April 23. After filing his papers, Vijay, addressing the people from his open-top campaign vehicle, reiterated his allegation that the DMK was an evil force. He slammed the DMK regime alleging there was no safety for women and hit out at the Government over the degraded law and order situation and for the alleged prevalence of drugs. "We have to save Tamil Nadu. Who is responsible for this plight? The evil force DMK is the reason for this situation, Stalin sir is the reason," he alleged.

Congress allowed Bangladeshi infiltrators to enter country: Nabin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jageroad (Assam)

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Monday accused the Congress of having facilitated the entry of Bangladeshis into Assam illegally when it was in power and claimed that it was the BJP which plugged their entry after forming a Government in the State.

At a rally here in support of BJP candidates in Morigaon district, he alleged that Congress leader Rahul Gandhi did not wear the traditional Assamese scarf, 'gamocha', when it was offered to him at an event in Delhi, thereby hurting the sentiments of the State's people. "But he regularly visits mosques



and happily wears the skull cap," the BJP national people alleged. He accused the Congress of supporting infiltrators.

"They had allowed Bangladeshi infiltrators to enter the country. It is the State's BJP Government which is reversing the trend and showing the exit path to illegal immigrants," he said.

He also asserted that Assam witnessed massive development in the 10 years of the BJP rule.

"People must remember the situation prior to that. Extremism, violence, investors fleeing and broken dreams of the youth dominated the discourse. We must ensure that such things do not recur," the BJP leader said.

Polling for the 126-member Assam Assembly will be held on April 9, while the results will be declared on May 4.

DMK poll manifesto is game-changing plan for Tamil Nadu: CM Stalin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief MK Stalin on Monday said his party manifesto for the April 23 Assembly election was a "game-changing" plan for Tamil Nadu as it underscored the steps towards progress.

The monetary support announced in the poll manifesto, he said, was a "smart economic multiplier" that would uplift the local economy, support small businesses, upskill people, and upgrade long-term outcomes.

"Development and welfare move together proving you can build infrastructure, grow the economy, and uplift people simultaneously. From one-size-fits-all to choice-based governance," the Tamil Nadu chief minister said, and added "people decide what works for them."



CM MK Stalin campaigns after filing his nomination papers from the Kolathur constituency in Chennai PTI

Live-in couples to be counted in census from April 1

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Couples living together in a live-in relationship will be counted as a couple for the upcoming census starting from April 1, according to the FAQs given on the self-enumeration portal.

The portal has been opened for people opting for self-enumeration during the Census. It will be available for both phases of the Census — Houselisting and Housing Census (HLO) and Population Enumeration.

The portal has a list of Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) to make it easy for the public to answer questions posed during the 16th Census of the country.

"Will a couple in a live-in relationship be considered a married couple? If they consider their relationship as a stable union, they should be treated as a married couple," the FAQ States.

The Government has notified 33 questions that will be put to citizens during the first phase of the Census houselisting and housing enumeration, starting April 1, 2026.

Questions such as the material used in house flooring and roof, number of married couples living there, sex of the head of the household, type of cereal



consumed, access to basic and modern necessities, and types of vehicles owned shall be put forth during the first phase.

The questions will start with asking the building number (municipal or local authority or census number), census house number, predominant material used in the floor, wall and roof of the house.

The enumerators will then ask about the use of the house, its condition, and the number of persons normally residing in the household.

Officials will also collect information about the head of the household, like the name and sex, whether the head of the household belongs to the Scheduled Caste, the Scheduled Tribe or other communities and the ownership status.

Mamata vs Suvendu: Battle heats up in Bhabanipur

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

In the calculus of West Bengal's electoral politics, Bhabanipur has emerged as the X factor. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee is pitted in a pitched battle with the BJP's Suvendu Adhikari in her long-held bastion, making it the State's most closely watched Assembly seat.

While the Trinamool Congress (TMC) is looking to retain its stronghold in south Kolkata with organisational strength and emotion, the BJP wants to breach the keep by banking on social arithmetic and symbolism.

The fight is reminiscent of the electoral clash between Banerjee and Adhikari in the 2021 Assembly polls, when the chief minister had taken on her protege-turned-rival, who had then just joined the BJP, in the latter's home turf, Nandigram.

Banerjee had lost the fight, although the BJP had been

drubbed by the TMC five years ago. She later won the Bhabanipur Assembly bypolls. The turf has changed, and it remains to be seen if the result does too.

Mamata Banerjee's party is banking on the 'ghorer meye' (girl next door) pitch, organisational muscle and continuity. On the other hand, the BJP is looking to wrest the chief minister's "safest" seat with caste calculations, Ram Navami imagery and booth-level social engineering.

The TMC has revived the emotional cadence of "Bangla Nijer Meyekei Chay" (Bengal wants its own daughter) from its 2021 assembly polls playbook in a more localised form.

At a strategy meeting chaired by State TMC president Subrata Bakshi, councillors were instructed to push the slogan: "Banglar unnayan ghore ghore, ghoror meye Bhabanipure". The message is simple: Bhabanipur is not merely electing a CM; it is



standing by its own daughter. Councillors have been told to go door-to-door, avoid confrontation and distribute leaflets highlighting Banerjee's development work.

The TMC has also set up 'photo corners' across the constituency, where people can pose with life-size cutouts of Banerjee.

The first such booth has come up at Muktdal More in Ward 73, where Banerjee lives, carrying the appeal: "Stand beside Mamata Banerjee, take a picture together, speak for Bengal".



For the TMC, however, it is more than a gimmick. It is an attempt to portray Banerjee not as a chief minister, but a familiar neighbourhood figure.

"We are not fighting this election with aggression. We are fighting it with emotion, with connect and with the work Banerjee has done in Bhabanipur," a senior TMC leader said.

Despite the TMC's confidence, the BJP believes the ground has shifted. Bhabanipur has long been a "mini-India" of sorts, comprising Bengali bhadralok neigh-

bourhoods, Marwari and Gujarati traders, Sikh and Jain families and a sizeable Muslim electorate. Roughly 42 per cent of voters are Bengali Hindus, 34 per cent non-Bengali Hindus and around 24 per cent Muslims.

It is this social arithmetic that appears to have encouraged Adhikari to challenge Banerjee on her home turf.

For months, the BJP has quietly mapped Bhabanipur booth by booth and community by community.

Party leaders claim Kayasthas make up 26.2 per cent of the electorate, Muslims 24.5 per cent, eastern Indian migrant communities 14.9 per cent, Marwaris 10.4 per cent and Brahmins 7.6 per cent.

The survey identified where Bengali Hindus dominate, where Hindi-speaking traders are concentrated and which booths are likely to be influenced by Muslim voters.

"The battle in Bhabanipur cannot be fought with one slogan. It has to be fought

booth by booth, community by community," a BJP functionary said.

That explains Adhikari attending the recent Ram Navami procession that traversed through Bhabanipur, culminating at Hazra crossing, near Banerjee's residence.

"The State now wants Ram Rajya. People are tired of appeasement politics. They want good governance," Adhikari said.

Political observers say the BJP is trying to consolidate Hindu votes, cutting across Bengali and non-Bengali communities, and simultaneously putting Banerjee on the defensive over minority politics.

"The BJP knows that social arithmetic alone may not be enough. So, it is attempting at emotional and ideological polarisation through Ram Navami and Ram Rajya pitch in the seat where the majority are Hindus, while a considerable portion of them are non-Bengali Hindu voters," political analyst Biswanath Chakraborty said.

NCP legislators back merger with NCP (SP)

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Two months after the tragic death of then deputy chief minister and Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) chief Ajit Pawar in a plane crash in Baramati, two NCP leaders have voiced support for the merger of the party, now headed by Sunetra Pawar, with the Sharad Pawar-led NCP (SP).

Immediately after Ajit Pawar's demise on January 28, senior NCP (SP) leaders had claimed that a merger was in the works before the senior leader died. Leaders of the NCP had then dismissed the claim, saying no such decision was taken.

"If both the parties are to come together and the NCP is to grow under the leadership of deputy chief minister Sunetra Pawar, the time has not passed yet," said Sunil Shelke, NCP MLA from Maval.

Shelke, who was considered a staunch loyalist of Ajit Pawar, was supported by deputy speaker of the legislative assembly, Anna Bansode.



BJP delegation meets ECI, alleges TMC voter intimidation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday approached the Election Commission of India (ECI), alleging that West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and the ruling TMC are "intimidating" electors to dissuade them from voting for the saffron party in the upcoming assembly polls.

Submitting a petition in this regard, the BJP del-



Union Ministers Kiren Rijiju, Piyush Goyal, and Minister of State for Education Sukanta Majumdar, addressing the media at the ECI headquarters in New Delhi on Monday PANKAJ KUMAR

egation urged the ECI to take necessary action to ensure that a free and

fair election is conducted in the State. Union ministers Kiren

Rijiju, Piyush Goyal and Sukanta Majumdar, and BJP chief spokesperson Anil Baluni were part of the delegation.

"While the assembly polls are scheduled to be held in four States and one Union territory, Mamata Banerjee has wreaked havoc to deprive electors of their right to vote in West Bengal and hijack the election," Rijiju told reporters after the meeting.

PM Modi links infiltration to national security and identity

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Accusing the Congress of "allowing" land grabbing by infiltrators, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Monday that infiltration into Assam is not just an election issue but is about safeguarding the identity of the State and national security.

Addressing virtually the BJP's booth-level workers in Assam ahead of the April 9 assembly polls, Modi said that the State saw a long span of instability but things changed over the past decade as the party's double-engine Government made every effort to ensure peace.

There is a need to remind first-time voters of the

"misrule" of previous Congress Governments in Assam and caution them that even the smallest mistake can push the State back, he said, noting that the BJP members were working hard to ensure a hat-trick for the party in the State.

"Infiltration is not just an election issue. It is an issue to safeguard the identity of Assam and national security. Congress allowed illegal land grabbing by infiltrators.

"Wherever infiltrators settle, they capture small businesses and the livelihoods of local people," he said during the 'Mera Booth, Sabse Mazboot Samvaad' initiative by the ruling BJP that is aimed at connecting



directly with party activists in poll-bound States.

The Prime Minister said the BJP workers must be fully aware of illegal land grabbing cases and the problems faced by local people, and the ordeal of those who have suffered due to illegal infiltrators must be known. "People must know that

Congress allowed encroachment, but the BJP is protecting rights," he said.

Modi noted that 12 peace agreements were signed by the Government with different organisations in the Northeast. He said the BJP workers must remind people how the Congress "used to make agreements only on

paper to create headlines and mislead people". "We have seen the era when Assam was burning in violence, Assam saw a long span of instability, but things have changed in the past decade. But today, we can see a new confidence as the BJP's double-engine Government has made every effort for peace," he said.

Under the Congress, peace agreements were pushed aside and the youths were left to suffer and drift towards unrest, Modi alleged.

No agreement with insurgents and student organisations worked during the Congress rule in Assam. The Congress betrayed the Bodo cause.

Rahul Gandhi bats for woman CM in Kerala, crowd cheers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Monday drew loud cheers from the crowd when he said he was looking forward to Kerala having a woman chief minister. Addressing a rally in Puthupally in Kottayam, Rahul spoke about the guarantees announced by the Congress if it comes to power, including free KSRTC bus travel for women and a monthly assistance of ₹1,000 for college-going girl students. He said the Congress wants women to be active participants in Kerala's development.

"In fact, we are looking forward to the day when we have a woman chief



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi rides a bicycle as he campaigns in support of UDF candidates for the upcoming Kerala Assembly elections in Kottayam district PTI

minister of Kerala," he said, drawing a loud response from the crowd.

He also remarked that men were not clapping enough for the statement. "We want women of Kerala to fulfil their dreams. Whatever they want to do, we want them to succeed," he said. He said the Congress would ensure that women have the freedom to go wherever they want and pursue the jobs they choose. "For this purpose, our guarantees include free travel for women in KSRTC buses," he said.

Rahul Gandhi alleged that under the proposed FCRA amendments, only the RSS would be able to receive foreign funds, while other organisations would be restricted. FCRA has

emerged as a key issue in Kottayam district, which has a large Christian community. "Suddenly, we noticed that an FCRA bill has been brought in. The interesting thing is that there is only one organisation that can get money from abroad. No other organisation can get money from abroad except the RSS," he alleged.

He further claimed that Prime Minister Narendra Modi could access foreign finances through industrialist Gautam Adani, while the RSS would benefit through the proposed FCRA norms. "What is special about the RSS that there are separate rules for them? They spread hatred and divide people. That is how the BJP functions," he said.



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Delhi High Court bars misuse of Aniruddhacharya's image in viral videos



In a significant development concerning digital misuse of personality rights, the Delhi High Court has granted interim protection to renowned spiritual orator Aniruddhacharya Maharaj against unauthorised and misleading online content circulating across social media platforms.

Represented by Deepriya Snehi and Yashika Kaushik, founding partners of Asraya Legal, a law firm based in New Delhi, the petitioner argued that the circulation of such manipulated content posed a serious threat to the preacher's reputation and could mislead his followers. The Court, presided over by Justice Tushar Rao Gedela, passed directions restraining the continued dissemination of infringing content on platforms including YouTube, Instagram, and Google search results. The matter involved morphed videos, AI-generated deepfakes, and selectively edited clips that allegedly misrepresented the preacher's statements and persona. During the proceedings, the Court acknowledged the evolving nature of online harm, particularly the risks posed by artificial intelligence-driven content and deepfake technology. It was specifically highlighted that certain clips falsely depicted the spiritual leader making statements he had never made, thereby constituting actionable harm.

While the Court engaged in a broader discussion on criticism, free speech, and the role of public figures, it drew a clear distinction between legitimate critique and fabricated or manipulated content. Recognising this distinction, the Court found merit in granting interim protection against content that prima facie appeared to distort the identity and speech of the petitioner.

Importantly, the Court noted that such technologically altered material, including deepfakes, raises serious concerns and warrants judicial intervention where personality rights are infringed. It was held accordingly, the Plaintiff has established a, prima facie, case for grant of an ex parte injunction. Balance of convenience lies in favour of the Plaintiff in the present case considering that the Defendants are infringing his personality rights as well as right to privacy. If an injunction is not granted in the present case, it will lead to irreparable loss/harm to the Plaintiff and his family, not only financially but also with his right to live with dignity.

Nation must guard soldiers' interests, says CJI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Highlighting the role of armed forces, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant has said the country must not compel them to "fight two battles at once", one at the border and another at home for their legal rights, calling for better judicial access for soldiers.

Delivering a speech titled "Pointers for Hon'ble the Chief Justice's Talk" on Sunday at Leh, Justice Kant highlighted the symbiotic relationship between the judiciary and the armed forces, stating that while courts safeguard constitutional values, it is the soldiers who create the conditions necessary for those ideals to endure.

Against the backdrop of the serene yet rugged Himalayan landscape, the CJI began his address by paying homage to the bravery of soldiers and made a special reference to the 1962 battle of Rezang La, recalling the sacrifice of Major Shaitan Singh Bhati and the 114 soldiers of Charlie Company, 13 Kumaon. "While the Constitution speaks in the



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant

language of rights, dignity, equality, and justice, entire credit for the same goes to you for securing the conditions in which those promises are able to survive for the people of India," he said. "A nation cannot meaningfully speak of liberty or justice if it cannot preserve its sovereignty, its stability, and its peace.

In that sense, the work of the Court and the work of the soldier are different in method, but united in purpose and complementary to each other," the CJI said.

Referring to the difficulties faced by soldiers, he said the service in uniform does not exempt one from the ordinary burdens of life, and a

soldier may still face a land dispute. "A veteran may struggle for service or welfare entitlements. A family may find itself caught in pension-related delays, housing issues, matrimonial discord, or bureaucratic indifference," he said.

"The nation must never place its soldiers in the position of fighting two battles at once — one at the frontier, and another at home for what is lawfully theirs. The law must travel to the soldier, because the soldier cannot always travel to the law," he said, highlighting a lack of easy access to legal guidance.

This is not only a matter of sympathy but rather a constitutional duty, he said, adding that if the institutions of the State cannot ensure timely legal support to those who stand guard over the integrity of the nation, then they fall short of their own moral and constitutional responsibilities.

The CJI then referred to the 'Veer Parivar Sahayata Yojana' launched to provide free legal aid, assistance and support services to serving defence personnel, ex-servicemen,

their dependent family members, and members of the Paramilitary Forces and CAPFs when he was the executive head of the National Legal Services Authority (NALSA).

He said conceiving and enacting the scheme for armed forces was one of the greatest highlights as the executive chairman of NALSA.

He said so far, 14,929 beneficiaries have been assisted nationwide, and 438 Legal Services Clinics have been made operational, including all 34 Rajya Sainik Boards and 404 Zila Sainik Boards. He said a workforce of 1,123 persons, including 378 members from the defence backgrounds, was deployed to ensure a culture of trust and empathy.

Under the scheme, resolution of issues ranging from property disputes and pension delays to matrimonial discord and school admissions has been undertaken, he said.

Concluding the address, the CJI assured the forces, saying, "You guard the nation at her frontiers. It is the duty of the nation's institutions to ensure that they guard all your interests arduously."

LS passes insolvency law amendments; FM says bill will help maximise value for stakeholders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Lok Sabha on Monday passed a bill to amend the insolvency law to provide for strict timelines, an out-of-court settlement option and enable the framework for cross-border insolvency processes.

Piloting the bill in the Lok Sabha, Finance and Corporate Affairs Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said that 12 amendments are being made in the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), which came into force in 2016, that would help maximise the value for stakeholders and improve the governing process itself.

Amendments seek to strengthen the existing insolvency framework, as well as address practical challenges, and incorporate evolving global best practices, the minister said, and added that the law has been a major factor in improving the health of the country's banking sector. The Lower House cleared the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (Amendment) Bill, 2025, as reported by the Select Committee. On August 12, 2025, the Government introduced the bill in the Lok Sabha to amend the Insolvency and Bankruptcy



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman speaks in the Lok Sabha during the second part of the Budget session of Parliament in New Delhi

Code (IBC), proposing a raft of changes, including provisions to reduce the time taken for admission of insolvency resolution applications.

The bill was referred to a select committee of the Lok Sabha, which submitted its report in December 2025.

Sitharaman stated that all the committee's recommendations have been accepted. IBC has been amended seven times so far.

The bill replaces the under-utilised fast-track process with a new creditor-initiated insolvency framework, featuring out-of-court initiation, debtor-in-possession and creditor-in-control model, where management continues to vest in the existing Board of Directors or partners with safeguards, and defined timelines. Also, there is an enabling framework for

group insolvency and cross-border insolvency to promote investor confidence and align domestic practices with best international practices, Sitharaman said.

Stricter timelines will be put in place to ensure the timely resolution of stressed companies, and there will be penalties to deter vexatious and frivolous complaints that delay the process.

Among other changes, an application for initiating the insolvency resolution process has to be admitted within 14 days if the default by a company has been established, and appeals related to IBC before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) have to be decided upon within three months. Sitharaman said the primary cause of delay is extensive litigation and that

various steps are being proposed in the bill to address the issue, including new provisions for penalties ranging from Rs 1 lakh to up to ₹2 crore on persons initiating frivolous proceedings to prevent abuse and delays.

The Adjudicating Authority (AA) has to approve or reject a resolution plan within 30 days of receipt, and there will also be the creditor-initiated resolution process, which is a new out-of-court initiation mechanism with a compressed 150-day timeline, the minister said.

Responding to concerns related to the efficiency of the IBC framework, Sitharaman asserted that companies have been doing well post-resolution and cited a study to mention that the market capitalisation of such firms grew from ₹2.8 lakh crore to ₹9 lakh crore in five years after resolution.

Noting that the IBC is a major and very crucial factor in improving the health of the country's banking sector, the minister said Scheduled Commercial Banks (SCBs) have recovered a total of ₹1,04,099 crore through various channels and out of the total amount, the IBC channel alone contributed a significant ₹54,528 crore, accounting for 52.3 per cent of the total recoveries.

Freeze amount, not account: Rajasthan HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

In a significant ruling on the scope of police powers during financial investigations, the Jodhpur bench of the Rajasthan High Court has held that banks cannot impose a blanket freeze on accounts at the behest of investigating agencies.

The court stated that any restriction must be proportionate and confined to the amount under dispute.

continue unhindered. The proceedings arise from an FIR registered in Udaipur on a complaint by Ajay Mudiya, alleging a ₹30-crore fraud.

The banks had blocked all savings accounts of the petitioners at the instruction of the investigating officer in the case.

The petitioners challenged the freeze and contended that the funds were legitimate professional earnings and that the police had bypassed due process by



The observations were made during a hearing on March 19 in a case involving filmmaker Vikram Bhatt and co-petitioner Shwetambari Bhatt, whose accounts were fully frozen during a fraud probe.

Allowing partial relief to them, the court directed that only the disputed sum of ₹30 crore should be under restriction, as it permitted all other legitimate transactions to

directing a complete freeze. They argued that the move crippled their financial functioning, leaving them unable to meet routine expenses, honour business commitments, or pay salaries and loan instalments.

Justice Farjand Ali, after reviewing the material on record, emphasised that freezing a bank account is an extraordinary step that must be exercised with caution.

NCLAT rejects MMTC plea against one-time settlement between NSEL and traders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Appellate tribunal NCLAT on Monday set aside an appeal by state-owned trading firm MMTC, challenging the one-time settlement (OTS) between 63 Moons-backed National Spot Exchange Ltd (NSEL) and traders.

The Mumbai bench of the National Company Law Tribunal had on November 28, 2025 approved a ₹1,950-crore settlement scheme between NSEL, along with its promoter 63 Moons, and traders who had dues aggregating nearly ₹4,300 crore.



The scheme was challenged by MMTC before the National Company Law

Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) saying it is "prejudicial to the public interest" and opposed to the public policy.

During the course of hearing, the NCLAT pointed out that the said National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order of November 11, 2025 has already been approved by it earlier and also been affirmed by the Supreme Court in a civil appeal on March 9, 2026.

However, Additional Solicitor General Vikramjit Banerjee, representing MMTC, argued that even if approved by "NCLT and this Tribunal and affirmed by the Supreme Court, can be recalled if it is proved the scheme is vitiated by fraud".

Interfaith live-in relationship not an offence, protected under Constitution: Allahabad HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has held that an interfaith live-in relationship is neither prohibited nor an offence under any law, while granting protection to a couple facing threats from the woman's family.

Allowing a petition filed by Kajal Prajapati and her Muslim partner from Sonbhadra, Justice Vivek Kumar Singh observed that merely being in an interfaith relationship does not deprive individuals of their fundamental rights guaranteed under the Constitution. "No discrimination can be made on the basis of caste, creed, sex or religion," the



court said. The couple had approached the court seeking protection from the woman's family, claiming that their pleas to police had gone unheeded.

The state Government's counsel informed the court that the petitioners are majors and no FIR has been regis-

tered against them for living together. The court said the petitioners are at liberty to approach the police for redressal of their grievances in case any harm is caused to them. It further directed police to examine the matter and the age of the petitioners.

High Court directed that police must act in accordance with the law if they find any substance in the allegations of the petitioners.

"A live-in relation is neither prohibited nor punishable under any law. Therefore, considering Articles 14, 15 and 21 of the Constitution of India and the Act, 2021, it cannot be said that the live-in relationship of an interfaith couple is an offence," the court observed.

Vedanta moves SC against Adani's ₹14,535-crore bid for Jaiprakash Associates

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Mining giant Vedanta Ltd has moved the Supreme Court seeking a stay on the NCLT's order approving Adani Group's ₹14,535 crore bid to acquire Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL).

According to the information available on the top court's website, Vedanta filed its appeal on March 25, a day after the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) refused to stay implementation of the plan.

Adani Enterprises Ltd., meanwhile, has also filed a caveat in the Supreme Court, requesting to be heard before any order is passed on Vedanta Group's petition in the matter. The Insolvency appellate tribunal on March 24 declined any interim stay over the Vedanta Group's

plea against the order passed by the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) approving the ₹14,535 crore bid by Adani Group's bid for acquiring JAL.

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal's (NCLAT) two-member bench sought a response from the Committee of Creditors (CoC) of JAL within a week. It is also directed to list the matter on April 10 for the next hearing.

Vedanta group was in the race to acquire JAL through an insolvency process, but the lenders in November last year approved the resolution plan of Adani Enterprises Ltd. The NCLAT approved the Adani Group's bid.

Challenging the NCLAT order, Anil Agarwal headed Vedanta group has filed two appeals before the NCLAT. In the first, it has challenged the validity of the resolution plan,



(L-R) Gautam Adani, Anil Agarwal

matter needs to be decided at an early date.

However, the bench comprising Chairperson Justice Ashok Bhushan and Member (Technical) Barun Mitra clarified that the implementation of the plan would be subject to the outcome of the appeals

filed by the Anil Agarwal-led Vedanta Group. The NCLAT also took on record submissions from the counsel for the CoC that "in the event delisting takes place of the Corporate Debtor (JAL) as per the approved resolution plan under the impugned order

and the impugned order is set aside by this Tribunal, there shall be automatic cancellation of all delisting actions."

On March 17, the NCLAT, Allahabad bench, approved Adani Enterprises Ltd's ₹14,535 crore bid to acquire JAL through the insolvency process. This was challenged by Vedanta before the NCLAT, which directed that Adani Enterprises be a party.

During the proceedings of the NCLAT, the counsel representing Vedanta had contended that it was declared the highest bidder by JAL's Committee of Creditors. Vedanta's bid value was ₹16,726 crores, and Adani Enterprises' bid was ₹14,535 crores. The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code suggests the maximisation of the value of the stressed asset. However, the lender body,

CoC, despite emphasising the importance of value maximisation and compliance with the IBC framework, failed to do so.

The CoC's discretion in the selection of a resolution plan must be exercised only in line with the applicable law and the governing documents, Vedanta's counsel contended before the appellate tribunal.

They further contend that participation in the bidding rounds must be a fair and equal opportunity, as no negotiation was done after putting Vedanta through multiple rounds of bidding.

In November last year, the CoC approved the resolution plan by business tycoon Gautam Adani to acquire JAL.

Adani Enterprises had outbid Vedanta and Dalmia Bharat to win the bid for JAL. Adani got the maximum 89 per cent votes from creditors,

followed by Dalmia Cement (Bharat) and Vedanta Group.

The CoC, however, defended its decision, saying the process complied with all insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) rules. They maintained that no bidder has a guaranteed right to win, even if it offers the highest value.

They said plans were evaluated on multiple factors, including upfront cash, feasibility, and execution, not just headline value.

Adani's bid was preferred as it offered around ₹6,000 crore upfront and faster payments within two years, compared with Vedanta's longer payment timeline of up to five years.

Lenders also rejected Vedanta's revised offer, saying it was submitted after bidding had closed and accepting it would require restarting the process.

Editor's
TAKE

West Asia crisis:
India's balancing act

The Centre's decision to constitute an all-party monitoring group on West Asia crisis signals both the seriousness and the need for national consensus

It has been a month now, and West Asia is still burning – along with the precious oil that fuels economies and provides cooking gas for the common man. The impact of the West Asian crisis is reaching far and wide, and its heat can be felt back home. India is particularly vulnerable, given its almost total dependence on imported oil and gas, and a vast pool of diaspora present in Western Asian countries. To take stock of the situation and watch the unfolding conflict closely, the government has established a high-level committee including key ministers such as Amit Shah and Nirmala Sitharaman to recommend interventions to tide over the impact of the shockwaves reaching Indian shores. With India sourcing a significant portion of its oil from the region, any disruption translates into rising fuel prices, inflationary pressures, and strain on public finances. The government's decision to cut excise duties and support oil marketing companies is an attempt to shield consumers while ensuring an uninterrupted supply. But it does not stop at energy scarcity; it has a ripple effect on the economy as a whole, as rising oil prices raise the overall cost of freight, reflected in higher prices of goods consumed on a daily basis, especially eatables. The Indian stock market is clearly reeling under pressure and showing signs of anxiety as the key indices take a turn downwards. Besides, trade routes, shipping insurance costs, and currency fluctuations could further complicate India's external sector. To add to the woes of the common man, there is an ongoing rumour that the government might enforce another lockdown to keep things under control. Such rumours only increase anxiety and trigger panic reactions from people buying and stocking essential goods, which further adds to scarcity and leads to spiralling prices. Thankfully, the Finance Ministry's reassurance against panic measures like lockdowns is helping to maintain market confidence and public calm. Another critical dimension is the safety of the Indian diaspora in West Asia. Millions of Indians live and work in the Gulf region, contributing significantly through remittances. Escalating conflict raises concerns about their security and potential evacuation challenges, reminiscent of past crises. Though so far they are safe, the government must mull a contingency plan for their evacuation should things worsen.Strategically, India must walk a tightrope. India has been a neutral country and maintains strong ties with Israel while also engaging Iran for energy and connectivity projects like the Chabahar Port. Simultaneously, its partnership with the United States makes its position precarious. It cannot definitively side with one party and condemn the other, and that ambiguity is dangerous for Indian interests. In this situation, India must further diversify its energy sources, accelerate investments in renewables and explore alternative suppliers. The government must communicate to the public in clear terms what steps it is taking so as to prevent panic. Finally, India must proactively advocate for de-escalation and stability in the region and get involved in the space that is now being taken up by Pakistan.

PIC TALK



An artisan shapes a traditional earthen pot in Prayagraj. PHOTO: PTI

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Kerala polls: A sharper three-way contest

With the BJP-led NDA striving to expand its footprint and fracture traditional vote banks, the election promises to test not only Kerala's long-standing pattern of alternating power but also the resilience and adaptability of its major political players



KALYANI SHANKAR

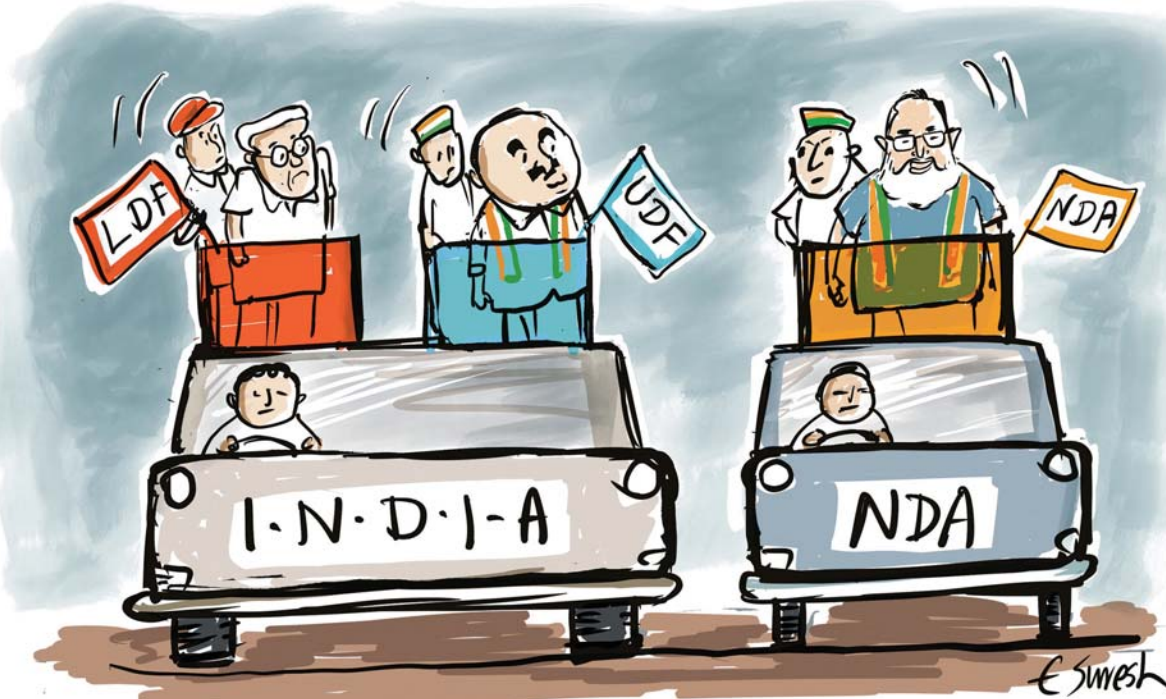
After a decade in the Opposition, the Congress Party is striving to regain its influence in Kerala ahead of the 2026 elections. The Congress-led UDF wants to snatch power, bolstered by strong results in past Lok Sabha elections and local body polls. The ruling CPI(M) is intensifying efforts to retain the state. The upcoming election will test the LDF's ability to maintain power against a formidable challenge from the UDF. Since 1982, voters have alternated their support between the Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the United Democratic Front (UDF) every five years, preventing any government from maintaining long-term power. In 2021, the LDF, led by Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, won a second consecutive term. Both parties are currently opposing the Modi government and vying for Muslim voters' support. The NDA wants to grow its influence in Kerala. The BJP is focused on increasing its vote share and winning important seats. Congress officials at the state level feel confident. However, there are serious problems at the local level that could hurt their chances in future elections. The Left Democratic Front (LDF) is the dominant political coalition in Kerala, primarily supported by Hindus. In contrast, the United Democratic Front (UDF) relies on support from minority groups. The BJP has drawn some votes from the UDF. This coalition includes the Indian Union Muslim League (IUMI) and the Kerala Congress, representing about 27 per cent of Muslims and 18 per cent of Christians, respectively. Kerala has at least ten swing constituencies in six districts. These constituencies are important because, in the last two Assembly elections, all three coalitions received similar levels of voter support. The internal conflicts within the Congress, especially over candidate selection, underscore the importance of party cohesion. Even though leaders like VD Satheesan, Ramesh Chennithala, and KC Venugopal seem united ahead of the Assembly elections, they are still competing for the Chief Minister's post if the UDF wins. In the 2026 Kerala Assembly elections, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is trying hard to connect with Christian voters, especially in central Kerala. The party plans to engage with local communities, focus on key issues, and involve senior leaders in its efforts. It aims to present itself as a strong alternative to the usual United Democratic Front (UDF) coalition.

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 The Pioneer



The party is focused on infrastructure, jobs, and safety. Recently, the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) has done well in local elections. This shows that the political landscape in Kerala, dominated by the UDF (United Democratic Front) and the LDF (Left Democratic Front), might be changing. Disagreements within the Congress over candidate selection, including Rahul Gandhi's concerns about ticket distribution, could weaken party cohesion and affect voter confidence. About 60 per cent of candidates on the proposed list are linked to KC Venugopal, the Lok Sabha member and party general secretary. Gandhi has urged a more organised approach within Congress. The Election Committee is focusing on key factors such as caste dynamics, winnability, and past electoral results, rather than relying solely on nominations from the state unit. Party members are also concerned about the lack of women represented in the candidate list. On the ground, the situation is clear. The CPI(M) has made strong progress through effective campaigning and clear organisation. In contrast, Congress is still having trouble getting its members organised. Some people who want to be Chief Minister are working hard to secure tickets for their supporters. They are not just helping loyal workers or creating new leaders; they are also looking to strengthen their own groups. Satheesan, Chennithala, and Venugopal are showing rare unity ahead of the Assembly

polls. Still, the competition for political leadership remains clear. The Kerala Assembly elections in 2026 are seeing the BJP actively reach out to Christian voters, particularly the Syro-Malabar community in central Kerala. By engaging locally, running issue-oriented campaigns, and facilitating high-level interactions with leadership, the party aims to present itself as a viable alternative to the traditional UDF alignment. Recent local body elections and early surveys indicate that the United Democratic Front (UDF) is slightly ahead but is facing internal divisions. If the BJP-led alliance maintains its 19 per cent vote share from the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, it could gain 7 per cent compared to 2021. The key question is whether this gain will take votes from the Left Democratic Front (LDF) or the UDF. How will the Christian and Muslim communities vote? Recent surveys indicate that the UDF is slightly ahead but faces challenges. There is uncertainty over whether, after a decade in Opposition, Congress is crafting a comeback narrative for the 2026 elections. It is unclear whether voters will return to the Congress Party or remain with the LDF, which some view as better positioned to challenge the BJP. The results in the 47 seats held by these communities could determine the outcome of the 2026 elections. Ultimately, the question is whether the UDF can win a majority or whether the LDF can create a record with a third term. Now the decision goes into the hands of the voters.

The question is whether the UDF can win a majority or whether the LDF can create a record with a third term. Now the decision goes into the hands of the voters

SINCE 1865

Balancing work and family in an age of uncertainty



SAKSHI SETHI

2ND OPINION

As the world observes the ongoing conflict in West Asia, its effects are being experienced far beyond the immediate region. Rising fuel prices, economic uncertainty, and a constant stream of distressing news have begun to influence everyday life across societies. At the same time, with technology and global connectivity shaping modern work patterns, balancing professional duties with family life has become less of a choice and more of a necessity, though it continues to remain a difficult task. The contemporary workplace, heavily influenced by digital tools, has significantly changed daily routines. The clear boundary that once separated work from personal time is gradually disappearing. Work now extends into homes through smartphones and laptops, making it increasingly hard for individuals to disengage. While this transformation has improved efficiency and provided flexibility, it has also resulted in constant accessibility, often interfering with time meant for family and personal well-being. In many households today, people live together physically but remain absorbed in their own digital spaces. A parent may be occupied with work emails, while a child is engaged with a screen, and conversations are limited to short, functional exchanges. Being physically present no longer ensures emotional closeness. This gradual weakening of personal connections is one of the less acknowledged outcomes of a fast-paced, always-connected lifestyle. The present global situation has added to these existing pressures. The conflict in West Asia has contributed to increasing living costs and heightened financial concerns. Families are dealing with worries about stability, employment, and the future. Continuous exposure to news updates further adds to stress and anxiety, which often affects the atmosphere within homes. Even children, though not always directly involved in such discussions, can sense the tension around them. In such circumstances, the importance of family as a source of emotional support becomes more evident. People look to their homes for reassurance and stability. However, this sense of comfort can only exist when relationships are actively maintained. It is not just about spending time together, but about being truly attentive. Listening carefully, engaging in meaningful conversations, and creating shared experiences within busy routines help strengthen bonds. Simple activities like eating together without distractions, taking a walk, or discussing daily events can contribute to emotional security and stronger relationships. Maintaining clear boundaries between work and personal life is also necessary. While work responsibilities cannot always be avoided, allowing them to dominate personal time can strain relationships. Fixing work hours, reducing communication beyond those hours, and consciously stepping away from devices during family time are practical ways to maintain balance. Parents play a crucial role in ensuring stability within the family. By providing reassurance, guidance, and a supportive environment, they help children feel secure even during uncertain times. A calm home atmosphere allows children to cope better with external stress. When parents invest time in meaningful interactions, they contribute to building a stable and supportive environment. Organisations also have a responsibility to support their employees by encouraging reasonable working hours and respecting personal time. Perfect balance may not always be possible, but conscious effort can help manage both responsibilities. Balancing work and family life is not just about managing time but also about recognising priorities.

The writer is an educator

ANCIENT WISDOM FOR A RESTLESS MODERN WORLD

As we observe the 2624th birth anniversary of Lord Mahavira on March 31, 2026, it is both timely and necessary to reflect on the enduring relevance of his teachings in today's rapidly evolving world. His philosophy, rooted in compassion, restraint and ethical living, continues to offer guidance even in an age defined by rapid technological and economic transformation. In an era marked by artificial intelligence, drone warfare and growing consumerism, Mahavira's principles of Ahimsa (non-violence) and Aparigraha (non-attachment) offer profound guidance. His message of "Live and Let Live" extends beyond interpersonal conduct to include ethical technological development, environmental sustainability and responsible consumption. These ideas are not merely spiritual concepts but practical principles for peaceful coexistence and sustainable development. Recent global conversations around minimalism, climate responsibility and ethical AI echo these ancient values. Increasingly, young people are embracing mindful living – not as withdrawal, but as a conscious effort to align progress with compassion, sustainability and restraint. Mahavira's philosophy reminds us that true progress lies not merely in innovation or economic growth, but in cultivating moral responsibility and harmony with all living beings. On this Mahavir Jayanti, reaffirming these values can help guide humanity towards a more balanced, ethical and humane future.

Y REDDY KETHIRI | TELANGANA

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Unequal burden of Climate

Apropos, "Doomsday for the Developing World," Mar 30. The intensifying trauma of climate change is borne disproportionately by developing nations, revealing a stark moral imbalance in the global order. Those who contribute the least to environmental degradation-daily wage labourers, farmers, and vulnerable communities—are the ones most exposed to its harsh consequences. Their livelihoods, closely tied to land and weather, are disrupted by rising temperatures, erratic rainfall, and extreme weather events. This injustice is further compounded by the silence around meaningful prevention. Global discourse appears increasingly resigned to adaptation rather than urgent mitigation. The historical responsibility of industrialised economies cannot be ignored; decades of unchecked emissions by developed nations have contributed significantly to this crisis. Yet, the burden of survival is being shifted onto those least equipped to cope. A compassionate response demands more than rhetoric. It requires accountability, equitable climate financing, and genuine commitment to emission reduction. Without such measures, climate change will remain not only an environmental crisis but also a profound humanitarian failure.

N SADHASIVA REDDY | BENGALURU

Europe faces age of coalitions

Denmark's recent election was expected to deliver a clear mandate to its popular Prime Minister, Mette Frederiksen. Yet her slender victory with a reduced vote share is a pointer to Europe's evolving political mood. Across the continent in Germany, where Olaf Scholz presides over a complex three-party coalition; in Spain, where Pedro Sánchez governs through delicate alliances; and in Italy, long accustomed to revolving coalitions now steadied yet still constrained under Giorgia Meloni-electorates appear less inclined to deliver decisive mandates, instead dispersing power across a wider political spectrum. Such fragmentation marks a departure from Europe's post-war decades, when clearer ideological divisions enabled governments to act with continuity and purpose. The present multiplicity of voices reflects deeper currents: economic uncertainty, cultural anxieties, and declining faith in traditional party structures. Coalition governments, while democratic in nature, often operate within narrow margins, with energies absorbed in maintaining consensus rather than pursuing transformative agendas. Europe must rediscover a unifying political purpose. Without such direction, fragmentation may lead not to progressive transition but to gradual political drift.

R NARAYANAN | NAVI MUMBAI

Developing world bears heavier burden

In response to the March 30, 2026 article "Doomsday for the Developing World," the latest OECD-sponsored Climate Impact Club report proposes accelerated industrial decarbonisation strategies for both the Global North and the Global South. The report reveals a stark reality: the North's carbon-intensive industrialisation has left the South highly vulnerable to severe climate impacts across multiple sectors. Water shortages, rising temperatures, melting Himalayan glaciers, and erratic monsoons-bringing droughts in some areas and floods in others-have intensified agrarian distress, threatening food security for millions. Declining crop yields are making rural livelihoods increasingly precarious and pushing many households into poverty. Constrained by low GDP and fragile finances, Global South nations lack the resources for climate adaptation, public health strengthening, green urban planning, early warning systems, and clean energy transitions. The Global North must demonstrate genuine solidarity through technology transfer, capacity-building, and grants instead of high-interest loans to support climate justice and sustainable development.

SK PRABHAKAR | GURUGRAM

The emerging risk of resource extinction in India

The perceived reliability and value of Indian Gum Karaya have suffered in the global pharmaceutical market and adversely affected India's export reputation. While we celebrated 'rights' and democratisation, Sterculia trees silently moved towards extinction and rural livelihood generation shifted to African countries



BKP SINHA ARVIND KUMAR JHA

Forests have long served as a crucial source of subsistence and economic security for human societies. In India, this relationship remains particularly significant for millions of tribals and forest-dwelling communities, where the central element of this socio-economic connection is Minor Forest Produce (MFP), also known as Non-Timber Forest Produce. It includes all non-timber forest produce such as fruits, seeds, tendu leaves, resins, gums, medicinal plants, honey, bamboo, lac, etc.

Gum karaya, commercially known as Indian tragacanth, is an important MFP obtained from the exudate of the Sterculia urens tree. Also known as the 'ghost tree' because of its smooth, papery, shimmering silver bark with an apparent nocturnal luminosity, it is commonly found in central and peninsular India, primarily in Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra, Telangana, and Andhra Pradesh. Gum Karaya finds use in the food, pharmaceutical, textile, printing, and cosmetics industries.

Till 1996, the Forest Department auctioned Gum Karaya and controlled its removal through Transit Permits. The administrative oversight over both extraction and trade was ensured by enforcement of non-destructive methods of extraction and assessment of the harvestable gum from the designated forest tracts. Institutions like the Girijan Cooperative Corporation (GCC), Andhra Pradesh (est. 1956); Tribal Development Corporation (TDC), Maharashtra (est. 1972); and MFP Federation, Madhya Pradesh (est. 1984) predominantly handled its trade and ensured remunerative prices for the gum collectors. Simultaneously reducing the dominance of private intermediaries, they strengthened the institutional framework for marketing, storage, and distribution. The Panchayats (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Act, 1996 (PESA) marked

a significant step towards decentralised governance. It endowed Gram Sabhas with the ownership of MFPs. Within six years, another nationwide framework for governance of 'biological resources' was created through the Biological Diversity Act 2002 (BDA).

Under this, the Biodiversity Management Committees (BMCs) at the local level were empowered to document the biological resources, charge a levy on those moving into the market, and assist the access-and-benefit-sharing mechanism associated with their commercial utilisation. Thereafter, the Forest Rights Act 2006 (FRA) was enacted to recognise and vest in Forest Dwelling Scheduled Tribes (FDSTs) and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (OTFDs) the rights of ownership, access, and disposal over MFPs traditionally collected by them.

Interestingly, separate institutions handle the five major statutory instruments exercising control over the MFPs, including Gum Karaya. The Indian Forest Act 1927 (IFA) and Wildlife (P) Act 1972 (WLPA) are implemented by the Forest Department in forest areas, except in the 'Community Forest Resource' areas where Gram Sabhas under the Rural Development Department (RDD) implement FRA Rules; BDA by the institutions under the National Biodiversity Authority on all lands; PESA by the Panchayati Raj Ministry in 'scheduled areas'; and FRA by the Tribal and Social Welfare/Rural Development Department on forest lands.

While overlapping legal mandates and institutional ambiguities have impacted different dimensions of MFP governance, the enforcement of misinterpreted provisions of the Acts is pushing MFPs' resource bases towards a biological collapse. The Gram Sabhas, endowed with "ownership of minor forest produce" in scheduled areas as per PESA, were expected to manage the 'commercial aspects' of the produce after it was "severed" from the tree or forest land. These could include MFP trade, distribution to members, value addition, pricing, etc.

The management of the MFP's 'biological aspect', being 'species-specific' and inextricably linked to the integrated treatment of total biodiversity in the area of its occurrence, requires adherence to silvicultural principles. It has traditionally been handled by the Forest Department. An over-enthusiasm for democratisation, perhaps, led to the glossing over of this critical



ical aspect, and management of the resource base, i.e. the forest ecosystem, was given to Gram Sabhas.

While implementing the FRA also, the interpretation of the 'right of ownership on the MFP traditionally collected' has been overstretched to presume that it inherently includes the 'right of management of the forest that produces the MFP'. The clause 'MFP which has been traditionally collected' has been stretched to hand over the complete commercial exploitation and trade of MFPs like tendu leaves to the Gram Sabhas. Further, although the FRA is mandated to benefit only the FDST and OTFD communities, the rights of ownership of MFP and management of the community forest resource area are recognised in favour of Gram Sabhas, considering them to be 'eligible communities', while completely disregarding their heterogeneity and without fulfilment of criteria mandated under the FRA.

From 1996 onwards, the institutional role of the forestry sector, of providing technical guidance on management practices, though a critical requirement, has not been incorporated into the governance frameworks created by different ministries. State-specific PESA Rules, such as those notified in Maharashtra, grant Gram Sabhas the discretion to seek technical advice from the Forest Department and to

value chains have tended to prioritise immediate economic returns over long-term resource stewardship. The over-stretched interpretation of 'owning the resource' has rendered the field-level enforcement of seasonal restrictions, tapping permits, transit rules and, in some instances, temporary bans on harvesting to promote resource conservation and sustainable yield management, executed previously by the Forest Department, a thing of the past. The ecological consequences of these, as evident in the case of Sterculia species as a representative source of MFP, have simply been disastrous.

Sterculia trees demonstrably suffered the proverbial 'tragedy of the commons', with widespread tree mortality threatening their extinction. With the forests treated practically as a commodity warehouse, Gum Karaya's domestic production reduced from 2720 MT to 540 MT, an eighty per cent fall in the last thirty years.

Institutions like GCC, historically a monopoly buyer, have started importing, processing and re-exporting Gum Karaya sourced from African countries; MP and Chhattisgarh Federations had to transition from "Service Providers" to "Revenue Earners" for the State, and with the only tool with the State being a "ban on tapping", these organisations are now gasping for the resource with just the Bastar area available for harvesting today. The TDC in Maharashtra approaches Gram Sabhas, buying even from areas where the gum collectors have been trained to inject the trees with chemical stimulants (like ethephon) for increasing the yield. The perceived reliability and value of Indian Gum Karaya have suffered in the global pharmaceutical market and have adversely affected India's export reputation. While we celebrated 'rights' and democratisation, Sterculia trees silently moved towards extinction and the site of rural livelihood generation shifted from India to African countries. India cannot afford to let forests become biologically unproductive and economically irrelevant. It must prioritise forest sustainability since the long-term resilience of MFP-based livelihoods will depend on the development of a seamlessly integrated governance framework that harmonises people's rights, scientific forest management, and market regulation, while avoiding an apparent jurisdictional turf war amongst sectors. An integrated approach is no longer a choice but a necessity for the survival of our natural resources.



STERCULIA TREES DEMONSTRABLY SUFFERED THE PROVERBIAL 'TRAGEDY OF THE COMMONS', WITH WIDESPREAD TREE MORTALITY THREATENING THEIR EXTINCTION

The writers are Former PCCFs of UP and Maharashtra

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The Pioneer

West Asia crisis fallout: When energy crisis hits your kitchen

GOPAL K SARANGI, ARABINDA MISHRA and DEBAJIT PALIT

Cooking energy transition has recently gained sudden attention due to the crisis triggered by the conflict in West Asia. As maritime disruptions push up gas prices and raise domestic supply concerns in India, electric cooking options are witnessing a surge in demand. This piece goes deeper into the question of cooking energy transition challenges in India and highlights how this crisis could be turned into an opportunity for the country.

Cooking energy: A critical blind spot in the energy transition discourse

Despite the importance of cooking energy, it has not really received due emphasis in the country's energy transition narrative. Rather, the energy transition issues are swayed away by big-ticket transition questions such as renewable energy (RE) acceleration and electric vehicle (EV) penetration. This is primarily due to the decentralised nature of cooking activities, conjugated with less investment appetite among investors to invest in this sector. Delisting of improved cookstoves (ICS) from the activities under Article 6.2 of the international carbon market further added to the woe. Available statistics show that close to 37 per cent of Indian households continue to use traditional biomass fuels.

However, the cooking energy sector has huge transformative potential, and the ongoing energy crisis could act as an opportune moment for the sector to transform. Beyond mitigation, clean cooking options could generate significant health benefits, particularly for women and children. Household indoor pollution (HAP)-related death statistics show that an estimated 2.8 million deaths globally could be attributed to HAP resulting majorly from traditional biomass and charcoal-based cooking in 2023. Besides, clean cooking options, in particular e-cooking options, could save precious foreign exchange by minimising the import of expensive energy sources.

Presence of rigid stacking problem and (dis)integration challenges

Deep diving into the transition trajectory of the cooking energy space unfolds some interesting emerging patterns. The Indian cooking energy landscape is governed by a rigid energy stacking problem, which has historically been characterised by poor availability, inaccessibility and limited affordability of cooking fuel options. However, recent trends suggest emerging pat-



challenge lies in the availability of feedstock and their implications for other sectors. For instance, first-generation biofuels which use food-based feedstock could create conflicts around food-energy trade-offs.

Could e-cooking act as a long-term sustainable solution? The question is whether e-cooking option(s) could be a cost-effective, long-term sustainable cooking option. The recent NITI report highlights the importance of e-cooking for the Net Zero scenario for the country. The National Efficient Cooking Programme, launched in November 2023, is promoting affordable, energy-efficient induction cookstoves for households. However, the penetration of e-cooking is limited to only 5 per cent of Indian households and is largely confined to urban centres as a supplementary cooking choice. Estimates by the authors and other studies show that stove cost and fuel expenditure in the case of induction cookstoves is almost the same as or lower than LPG. With expanding renewable energy in a big way, fuel security could be achieved. However, achieving decarbonisation through e-cooking depends on the greening of the electric grid.

While e-cooking options look like promising long-term sustainable cooking options, the real challenge lies in provisioning e-cooking systems in rural areas due to grid reliability problems. Besides, an important consideration which could act as a deterrent is the presence of tele-scopic subsidised slab-based electricity tariff structures for households. The question often raised is whether cooking energy could be considered as a separate category of consumption within household electricity consumption and could be billed separately. The other feasible option that could become a game changer is through linking the PM Suryaghar scheme with household cooking. Though the programme is for household electrification, it could effectively be used as a source of cooking energy. To conclude, the present crisis has the potential to be converted into an opportunity for e-cooking to ensure fuel security, clean kitchens and decarbonisation of the sector. The need of the hour is framing and implementing the right kind of policy for clean cooking.

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PARAG ACHARYA

The tragic story of Tilikum, a captive killer whale featured in the documentary *Blackfish* (2013), shocked the world and continues to raise uncomfortable questions about how humans treat wild animals. Tilikum was involved in the deaths of three people, including experienced marine trainer Dawn Brancheau, and became a powerful symbol of the consequences of keeping such animals in captivity. The documentary showed how confinement, isolation and forced performances can damage animal psychology, leading to stress, frustration and sometimes dangerous behaviour.

Another tragic incident occurred in India on March 20, 2026, when a young veterinarian, Dr Sameeksha Reddy, was killed by a pregnant hippopotamus during a late-night check-up at a safari park in Karnataka. The animal had reportedly stopped eating for days — a condition sometimes normal during pregnancy — but suddenly became aggressive. This incident highlights a critical reality: even routine veterinary care can turn dangerous when animals are stressed, vulnerable or undergoing physiological changes.

Veterinarians and animal handlers work in high-risk environments, closely interacting with animals under unpredictable conditions. Nearly 46-50 per cent of occupational hazards in veterinary practice are due to physical injuries, while over 40 per cent of veterinarians have reportedly experienced at least one zoonotic disease during their careers. These risks reflect a wider global issue. Each year, around 2.93 million people die from work-related causes.

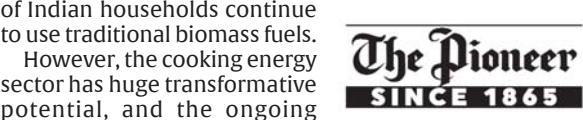
However, risk does not arise from interaction alone, but from how it is managed. Well-managed human-animal relationships can improve welfare, reducing stress and enhancing reproduction in species like rhinos and leopards, while benefiting elephants and handlers. The goal is not to avoid interaction, but to ensure it is informed, respectful and scientifically guided. Yet, a deeper contradiction persists — the "Lennie Small paradox", inspired by John Steinbeck's *Of Mice and Men*, where harm arises from affection without understanding. In the novel, Lennie unintentionally harms the creatures he loves due to a lack of awareness and control. Similarly, humans often harm animals despite good intentions. Efforts to connect through zoos, aquariums and domestication may lead to suffering when animals are removed from natural environments and their biological and behavioural needs are unmet.

Captivity itself presents serious challenges. Animals adapted to vast territories are confined to limited spaces, restricting movement and natural behaviours. This often leads to frustration, boredom and psychological distress, sometimes resulting in aggression. In the wild, animals can avoid conflict by moving away from threats or establishing territories. Captivity removes this choice, forcing animals into close proximity with humans or other animals, which can escalate tensions. Human error is another important factor. Routine activities such as feeding, cleaning and training require close contact, and even experienced handlers can misinterpret animal signals, leading to unintended provocation.

Numerous incidents reinforce this reality. Beyond Tilikum, attacks involving tigers, elephants and primates demonstrate that no wild animal is entirely predictable in confined environments. There have been multiple cases of panda attacks in captivity, challenging the perception of these animals as harmless. These examples reinforce the idea that captivity alters behaviour in ways that can be dangerous for both animals and humans.

Preventing such incidents requires a comprehensive approach. Enclosure design must prioritise adequate space, natural elements and environmental enrichment to allow animals to express instinctive behaviours. Providing hiding spaces and reducing unnecessary human contact can lower stress levels. Proper health management, including quarantine and monitoring, is essential. Equally important is staff training — handlers and veterinarians must understand species-specific behaviour, safe handling techniques and emergency protocols. Regular safety audits and the use of protected contact systems can further minimise risk.

Ultimately, the lessons from these tragedies extend beyond individual cases. Whether in marine parks, zoos, farms or veterinary settings, the principle remains the same: respect the nature of animals and prioritise safety. Good intentions alone are not enough; they must be supported by knowledge, planning and responsibility. The deaths of individuals like Dawn Brancheau and Sameeksha Reddy serve as stark reminders of the risks involved in working with animals and the consequences of overlooking those risks. At the same time, they highlight the urgent need for better systems, stronger policies and greater awareness. Protecting both human lives and animal welfare is not a choice between two priorities — it is a shared responsibility that demands careful balance, scientific understanding and continuous improvement.



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BLASÉ CAPITAL

RUPEE REBOUNDS

It worked like magic. It was brutal economics at its best. The central bank put the fear of God into the souls of the bankers, and the rupee, which was frantically trying to maintain its position, despite the protection and support from the central bank, bounced back with a bang. It lost more than a rupee against the dollar during the day, and came down to below Rs 94 to a dollar. At one end, the central bank’s policy to force the banks to drastically pare down short foreign positions did what it was intended to do. At the other, it ushered in an era where one can sense fear and loathing within the central bank, which may lead the speculators to take the game to the next level. Nothing is static in the war for profits, especially when a real near-global war is on, and Iran bombards new targets as it ups its war games.

Some bankers admit that the central bank’s move to limit each bank’s end-of-the-day’s short position to \$100 million by April 10, was due to concerns about the “sharp and rapid depreciation... in recent weeks.” They said that positions may have expanded due to the arbitrage opportunities, as well as straightforward ones due to the continuously falling rupee. The persistent dollar outflows due to imports, equity outflows, and other global factors led the banks to “build short positions domestically while hedging overseas, creating pressure on the rupee.” Hence, the winding down was critical to stop speculation. This is exactly what the central bank did in 2011, during a period of similar currency movements, and when it was felt that “moral suasion” would not work. Of course, the official line is that the central bank did not want the banks to lose money due to the speculative tendency.

Ironically, losses are what the banks will need to immediately book due to the new limit on short positions. According to the bankers, there is no option but to unwind the current positions, estimated at \$40 billion, with some banks having positions as high as \$500 million each. They will opt for mark-to-market, and slowly unwind the positions over the next 11 days until April 10. In the process, they will incur losses, and lose their ability to serve their customers better. According to some estimates, positions worth \$18 billion may be wound down, and this may lead to the rupee gaining more than a rupee against the dollar. However, yesterday the dollar was a rupee down, and maybe the central bank’s move may strengthen the rupee more than expected. Which implies that the feeling of fear and loathing on the main street extends to the individual banks as much as to the regulator.

The supporters of the central bank contend that the freedom that was given to the boards of the banks to manage their short positions since 2011 was to improve efficiency and autonomy, but the overriding theme was that they should not impact the balance sheets in an adverse manner. Hence, if speculation ruled, and the positions were driven by expectations and greed, it was time to restrain them. State-owned banks blame the foreign and private banks for the aggression in the short positions to book future profits, and make hay while the rupee declined. Things were going out of hand, as the rupee declined by four per cent within a month, although such a fall happens in 12 months or so. Clearly, there was excessive speculation, and unwarranted activity, which needed to be curbed. This is what the central bank did, as its job to safeguard the rupee, and the banks’ future financials.

The contrarian view is that speculation may increase in the future after, of course, a breather till the unwinding is done. Later, new speculators, sensing that the central bank is unduly worried, which implies that the situation is worse than what is visible, may enter more aggressively. If the banks are not allowed more than \$100 million net positions, the ones chasing profits will find other ways to beat the rupee down. If a currency is weak due to macro factors, which the rupee is, and if the situation continues or escalates, the manipulators will sense their chances, and use them ruthlessly. In this sense, the central bank may have inadvertently sent a wrong message to the market. Now, even the bankers may believe that the rupee is weaker than what it seems, and the latest strengthening is a sign of weakening. There may be more attacks on the rupee, and many may skirt the laws.

Experts hope that the central bank is wrong, and the speculative activity was not a major concern before its policy move. If this is true, new speculation may stay away, and the rupee may hold on, neither going up nor down. But if speculation was, and is, rampant, we will have a different ball game, either a home run, or several strikes. The problem is not about the fall, but its steepness and suddenness. The central bank is okay to let the rupee find its level, but at a steady pace. After all, the rupee has lost ₹20 to a dollar since the pandemic.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | MARCH 31, 2026

BUSINESS10

Coal’s cool, cracking comeback

Black gold recovered its sheen due to war, and may keep shining

India was turning green. Black was out, and so was an era of crude energy sources, even if refined adequately, and used as liquefied gas. Yet, the shine on coal, the black gold, has intensified in the past few weeks. Thanks to huge global shortages in crude oil, and gas, including LNG (liquefied natural gas), India, along with other nations, is re-focusing energy security. It demands a back-to-black tactics, and giving green a breather, even as the future of fossil fuels seems iffy. Black is in, even if it remains dirty, messy, and polluting.

Desperate to manage the energy crisis due to the Iran war, Indian officials have asked coal-based power utilities to ensure uninterrupted supply as the summer season looms. Utilities across Asia hope to boost coal-fired generation due to the shortage of fossil fuels, especially gas and LNG. For example, Bangladesh and the Philippines focus on higher coal burn. Coal production is a top priority, as India nudges the state-owned near-monopoly, Coal India, to aim for higher output. Thailand desires the same from its largest coal plant, South Korea plans to remove ceilings on coal, and Japan wants high capacities in coal plants.

One of the major reasons in India’s case is the possibility of power outages due to the lack of gas and LNG, especially the latter. Iranian attacks knocked out 17 per cent of Qatar’s LNG export capacity, and the damages, according to local experts, may take years to repair. For the import-dependent buyers in Asia, the fate of gas-fired power seems in a limbo, almost in a coma over the next few months. Over the years, India has emerged as an important buyer of Qatar’s

LNG, with long-term lucrative contracts. They are up in smoke.

Apart from the shortages of LNG, the economies have shifted towards coal-based power. According to reports, within one month of the war, Asian LNG prices rose by 143 per cent, with an 85 per cent hike in European gas prices. The rise in Brent crude was 55 per cent, although it threatened to more than double, and even zoom up by more than three times. In comparison, coal prices are up, but by a manageable 13 per cent during March 2026. Hence, it makes sense to use coal rather than gas, which is anyway in short supply, or not available.

In addition, India has more than adequate domestic coal supplies. The coal ministry insists that the country has more than 200 million tonnes in stock, which is enough for 88 days of consumption. Coal-fired plants hold more than 50 million, which is enough for 24 days at the current burn rates. Coal India sits on a record 121.4 million tonnes of pithead stock. The country’s annual production crossed a billion-tonne mark for the second consecutive year, which enabled high inventories at both the producers and consumers (power plants) end.

Power demand will be a crucial element of the overall strategy to combat the negatives related to the war. The International Energy Agency states that India’s needs will grow at an average of 6.4 per cent a year through 2030. It adds that while solar energy will account for half of the additional growth, and coal another 25 per cent, coal burn is still expected to rise by 2.5 per cent

a year on an average over the next five years. Coal’s share will fall, from 70 per cent in 2025 to 60 per cent in 2030. In other words, the transition is slow and steady.

However, the war has changed these calculations, and equations. Coal demand may surge this year, and may go up in the next one, as Qatar’s LNG gets on track over the next 4-5 years. In the interim, India will need to buy expensive LNG, increase coal dependence, or do both. This is where the story turns into more than a weather-and-war one. India’s solar energy can meet the 270-GW daytime peak, but officials and experts are not sure of the evening peaks, or demand overload due to heat-waves, industrial uses, and the growing pull of digital infrastructure.

Hence, the coal comeback is not about strategy, ideology, or a reversal of climate policy. It is about what happens when a fast-growing power-guzzling nation needs to choose between transition, ambition, and reliability during crises, and stressful times. Coal’s appeal lies in three things that matter the most. These include dispatchability, availability, and price visibility. This ensures that the black gold is not just a fallback fuel, but a crucial hedge against global disruptions. Some experts contend that India can ensure coal’s higher life expectancy, despite the overriding clamour for Climate Change, if it installs more washeries, which brings down the pollution levels.

Two scenarios will determine the future fate of coal. In the first one, oil and gas prices fall back within a year, Qatar’s LNG capacity is gradually restored, and the panic proves temporary. Coal dependence will seem tactical rather than structural. Gas will regain credibility as a balancing fuel, renewables will expand, and coal’s current prominence can be seen as a response to a crisis that was amplified by an extreme summer. The IEA’s base case points in this direction, as it predicts that while coal use will remain large, its share will fall.

In the second scenario, gas remains expensive or unreliable for several years, since LNG is inherently harder to reroute, store, and recover after disruption, compared to crude oil. Buyers who pivot from gas may not reverse course quickly. Then, coal’s comeback may turn into a longer run. Not because the nations abandon the energy transition goals, but because they postpone parts of the transition that are expensive. In such a brave new world, “green” does not disappear but moves slowly. Coal will not be something to be sneered about, as it was.

What is crucial is that the green pace had faltered a bit over the past year, even before the war. Reports indicate that global registrations of electric vehicles fell by three per cent in January 2026 to just under 1.2 million units, dragged down by a 20 per cent drop in China, and a 33 per cent fall in North America due to lower subsidies, and weaker policy support. In February 2026, the registrations fell by 11 per cent year-on-year. The numbers do not reverse the long-term trend, but weaken the idea that fossil-fuel demand is on an uncomplicated slide.

OUR TAKE

Do aspirations kill happiness?

Indians do not seem satisfied, comfortable, free, or just happy

and this was aided by factors such as healthy life expectancy, generosity, apart from high per-capita GDP. Consider the crucial role of generosity in happiness. People are happy if they have enough, or at least have the mindset, to help others, as well as if they have the confidence that others will help them. Despite Adam Smith’s individualism, altruism makes people happier.

Like Finland, Denmark, the third ranked, scores high on issues such as social support, and low corruption, although “happiness here is often described as quiet and understated.” Costa Rica, which shockingly entered the top five this year, up from 23 in 2023, provides better insights into why India is ranked low. The former does not have the GDP size or growth to match India, or even the Nordic nations. But its happiness culture is shored up by a sense of rising freedom, and close community support. In this case, the feeling of being

free is enough to make people happy. It does not matter if they exercise the choices.

Sweden, which is ranked 5, is praised “for a balance between progressive urban life, and access to nature, healthy life expectancy, and low perceived corruption.” A clearer pattern emerges. Low corruption, or a feeling that it exists minimally, is important. This is not the case with India. Community support, and social support are critical, which are limited in India. Education and healthcare are crucial, and India, despite modern systems and facilities, and far-reaching welfare schemes, cannot consider itself ahead of most nations.

Freedom, or a feeling of it, is something that cannot be neglected.

Now, let us look at the flip side. That is, how India’s positives and successes may impede happiness. It is the fastest-growing among major economies, which implies that the competitiveness, hustle-and-bustle, race to

tap emerging opportunities, become richer and wealthier, and acquire an acquisition mindset contribute to stress and instability. No person can be happy in such an environment, which ultimately pushes an individual’s ambitions and aspirations, and makes life better later. During the transition, life is a blur, with no time to breathe. One is consumed by madness and craziness, and happiness is the last thought.

Rising aspirations, according to experts, results in “constant social comparison, and financial pressures (despite rising incomes) often create a feeling that one must keep achieving more.” As lifestyles improve, so do the stress levels. The comparison among parents leads to buying a bigger house, two cars, and the latest smartphone. Among the children, there is a feeling to travel abroad, seek expensive education, and buy the latest fashion accessories. The list seems unexhaustive, and continues to grow, even as a family acquires more assets. It is an unquenchable thirst, and the hunger grows till it bursts.

Migration, bigger urban cities, nuclear families, and fast-paced lives involve minimum interactions with the locals, communities, and societies. People live, as if in a relationship bubble, where the maximum one connects with the others is casually or aggressively in offices, or rarely with friends and families. There is no sense of “belonging to a neighbourhood or communities.” In many cases, residents in apartment blocks do not know their neighbours, or are not interested, until there is a crisis. Neighbours, who once offered food and beverages, when new people moved in, stay away, and seem apprehensive.

Hence, people need to move from successes to acceptances, from the desire to get more to one where the urges remain but there seems to be satisfaction and appreciation of the existing achievements. Subjective things become more important than quantitative ones. Thus, one feels better if one can relax on weekends, and spend quality and entertaining time with family and friends. One thinks it is better to work seriously for 10 hours, and get back home, minus road-rage situations, to relax, and have a nice sleep. The pull factors remain, but the pushes vanish. One moves at one’s pace, irrespective of the others.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

India’s quantum push faces a problem of proof

Can the country that built the largest digital infrastructure hold the line against quantum?



NISHANT SAHDEV

We do not usually ask what makes a digital transaction believable. It goes through, it settles, and the record stands.

That depends on a simple idea: that what is verified today will remain verifiable tomorrow. In India, that idea carries unusual weight. Every UPI payment, every Aadhaar authentication, every digitally signed document and land record relies on it. It is what allows billions of transactions to move without friction, and what gives digital records their authority.

But that expectation rests on methods that do not remain fixed.

As the old saying goes, *satya sthir hota hai* — truth endures. Indian thought has long drawn a distinction between *satya* (truth) and *pramaan* (proof). The difference now has practical consequences. Truth may remain. Proof depends on the methods used to establish it, and those methods change over time.

Nothing has stopped working. Transactions continue. Records still verify. Yet the durability we attribute to digital proof is less certain than it appears — and that changes how much weight these systems can carry as time passes.

A system built on proof at scale

India’s digital infrastructure now operates at a scale few countries have attempted. Retail digital payments crossed 22,000 crore transactions in 2024–25, with UPI accounting for the overwhelming majority, making it the largest real-time payment system globally. Aadhaar has issued over 1.3 billion identities, with authentication requests running into

billions each month. Government platforms process vast volumes of service transactions every year, spanning taxation, welfare delivery, financial access, and property records.

At this level, transactions do not depend on familiarity or discretion. They depend on the ability to verify — instantly, repeatedly, and across distance.

That changes the nature of trust. It is no longer carried only by institutions or intermediaries, but by the mechanisms that establish proof. Those mechanisms are cryptographic. They are mathematical, structured, and precise — but they are also tied to assumptions about what can and cannot be computed.

Much of the public conversation around quantum computing focuses on a dramatic future moment — when encryption breaks. That framing is misleading. Change in such systems rarely arrives as a single event. Encryption weakens as better computational methods are developed, and what was once considered secure becomes progressively easier to compromise.

This matters because data does not disappear. It is stored, copied, archived — often for long periods, sometimes indefinitely. In cybersecurity, this is described as “harvest now, decrypt later”: information can be collected today and accessed in the future when stronger tools become available. This applies not only to sensitive state communication, but to financial transactions, identity systems, corporate records, and administrative databases.

There are already early indications of this transition. The United States has begun moving toward post-quantum cryptographic standards, anticipating future risks rather than waiting for failure. International institutions such as the Bank for International Settlements and the IMF have



warned about the systemic consequences of delayed transition, especially for systems that depend on long-term data integrity. India has committed ₹6,000 crore to the National Quantum Mission, with a focus on building technological capability.

But the structural challenge lies elsewhere. It is not only about securing future systems.

It concerns the vast volume of data that has already been secured using older methods, and is expected to remain valid for years, sometimes decades.

India’s existing digital records rest on cryptographic assumptions that were never designed to hold indefinitely.

When proof stops settling questions

At everyday scale, this is not visible. Payments go through. Documents are accepted. Systems respond as expected. The issue becomes visible when records are questioned — during disputes, audits, regulatory scrutiny, or

judicial proceedings. India already has one of the largest volumes of civil litigation in the world, with



land disputes forming a substantial share. At the same time, digital lending is expanding rapidly, with agreements created and stored entirely in electronic form. Courts and regulators are relying more frequently on digital evidence.

In such an environment, even a small shift in how proof is evaluated can have large effects.

If a very small fraction of digital payment records are contested years later, the absolute number of disputes could run into the millions. Land records secured under current standards may become easier to challenge relative to newer ones. Identity-based

authentication, when examined under evolving standards, may introduce similar complications in edge cases. But the issue is not the number of disputes. It is what happens to resolution.

India’s digital infrastructure is designed to settle questions quickly — whether a payment is complete, an identity is valid, or a document is authentic.

That ability to close matters is what allows these systems to operate at scale. Without it, every transaction would carry additional verification costs, slowing down systems that are built for speed.

If the strength of proof varies over time, that property begins to weaken.

Records do not disappear, but they no longer settle questions in the same way. What was once treated as conclusive becomes open to re-examination. Older records become easier to challenge relative to newer ones, not because they are false, but because the methods behind them are no longer equally strong.

Baking the silicon cake: Why India is learning to own the global kitchen



SHUBHANSH TIWARI

Most people interact with Artificial Intelligence through a narrow slit of AI models, which they use daily, but Jensen Huang, Founder and CEO of NVIDIA, explains the AI world as a five-layered cake. At the base sits, energy as the foundation which is powered by minerals and rare earth metals, above it comes the chips and semiconductors, which is the most crucial and controversial layer, the third layer is the cloud infrastructure, the fourth houses the AI models ie the LLM(s) such as GPT-4 and Google Gemini and the top most layer is the application and implementation of these technologies. In today’s world, mastering all five layers is no longer a luxury- it has become a prerequisite for a stable and developed economic infrastructure.

In recent years, the Indian Government has been aggressively pursuing and emphasising the process of indigenisation of this stack through the Indian Semiconductor Mission (ISM), but the escalating tensions and ongoing wars in the Middle East and West Asian region have affected the global supply chain, which would affect India’s ‘Silicon Dream’ in both negative and positive ways.

After the change in regime in the United States of America and President Donald Trump’s slogan of “Make America Great Again” (MAGA), many countries, including India, have faced many trade restrictions and tariffs. These changes in policies have led to a rise in pre-existing tension among East Asian and Middle Eastern Countries. The ongoing wars in the region are affecting the ongoing ISM projects in multiple ways.

Some immediate impact of the war on the foundational and second layer of the AI stack (the energy and chips) includes the Helium gas Crisis, as Qatar produces nearly one-third of the world’s Helium, which is an essential gas used for chip cooling.

The supply of Helium gas is hindered due to the war and the blockage of the naval pathways. Another impact is the delay in the



delivery of precision machinery for Indian fab labs. The war has added another 14 to 20 days of time tax on the delivery of these machines. The rerouting of vessels from the Strait of Hormuz to the Cape of Good Hope has created a severe logistical bottleneck.



This not only increases the cost of transportation but also delays and slows down the ongoing projects under ISM due to the shortage of machinery. Trump’s MAGA mission acts as a double-edged sword for the Indian semiconductor project.

This initially created financial hurdles and barriers, such as tariff pressure, which makes it expensive for Indian chip manufacturers to enter and compete in the global market, but on the other hand, Trump’s administration is taking an aggressive stance to decouple the global market from Chinese chip manufacturers, which creates a wide range of opportunities for Indian startups and companies.

However, where geography presents hurdles, diplomacy is building bridges. In February 2026, India joined PAX-Silica, which marked a turning point in our nation’s technological

Self-reliance and development. PAX-Silica is a 12-nation coalition which includes the USA, Japan, Qatar, Australia, Israel and other technologically superior nations. By joining this trusted club, India no longer remains a random

buyer but has become a strategic ally and business partner of nations such as Qatar that control the Helium supply of the world. This provides a buffer against the Helium shortage. Currently, India relies on China for nearly 93 per cent of its rare earth minerals imports, which is the foundation of the AI stack, but PAX-Silica has created an alternative chain supply, which would connect India with mineral-rich countries such as Australia and processing experts such as Netherlands, which will allow India to build its own second layer of the AI stack without Chinese interruption. This club will also provide us with access to advanced chip-making tools, which would accelerate the ISM by 5 to 10 years.

Ultimately, the convergence of West Asian Conflicts and the change in policies by the US administration serves as a definitive stress for India’s ‘silicon dream’. At the same time, the logistic bottleneck and short-term resource scarcity present immediate hurdles.

Still, they have also effectively accelerated ISM and strengthened India’s diplomatic relations across the globe by leveraging the diplomatic shield of PAX-Silica. India is eliminating the risks and threats in the supply chain and securing the foundational layer of the AI cake.

This geopolitical instability is not just a challenge, but also proves to be a catalyst for an ATMANIRBHAR infrastructure and ecosystem. India isn’t just trying to bake the cake; it’s learning to own the kitchen.

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AI will not replace universities: It will invite them to reflect and rediscover their true purpose



RS PAVITHR

“Let us be clear about what many technology leaders and futurists are suggesting when they argue about the relevance of university degrees in the era of advanced artificial intelligence” — their argument isn’t about the advancements of just AI technologies and their exponential progress — it’s that AI will reach a point where it will make universities irrelevant and potentially replace them with knowledge-driven and content delivery AI systems.

They envision a world where a student never needs to attend a campus to earn a professional degree. Knowledge will be free and credentials will follow skills and ultimately, leading to employability. If the outcome of the university system is entirely focused on developing skills for employment, and if success is measured solely by campus placement metrics, then one could certainly argue that advanced AI-based knowledge and personalised content systems could outperform traditional university systems.

However, if we consider that the university education system extends far beyond employability, the debate takes a different direction. Indeed, the advancement of AI has sparked an important discussion between these two contrasting perspectives.

“Even a crore kinds of knowledge are ultimately for earning a livelihood” and “Education is not merely vocational but liberating, holistic, and transformative.”

How our universities quietly accepted the smaller version of themselves

In current times, it can be observed that many higher education institutions, somewhere along the way, compromised and prioritised employment over other essential attributes of true education. They packaged knowledge into degrees, degrees into salaries, and salaries into measures of student success and institutional rankings. In chasing these success metrics, institutions drifted from the deeper, comprehensive purpose of education to mere vocational and skill-based training. This is precisely



what many technology leaders and futurists are now highlighting, warning universities that, if they define success solely through placement statistics, they may not survive the AI wave.

At the same time, we should consider that their words are prompting higher education institutions to reflect, identify what they have forgotten, and rediscover their deeper purpose—one that “envisions nurturing learners who go beyond academic excellence, demonstrating creativity, emotional intelligence, ethical grounding, empathy, and social responsibility, while mastering 21st-century skills such as critical thinking, problem-solving, collaboration, communication, and digital literacy.” This reflection is essential for institutions to stay relevant and, at the same time, enhance their evaluation mechanisms by integrating all these value components into assessments and measurement criteria.

The hard truth is that universities became vulnerable not because AI became too powerful, but because they quietly accepted a smaller version of themselves and failed to prioritise all the existing value propositions qualitatively.

Perspectives of Indian education system

From the Indian perspective, education was never really about what you could do-it was about who you became. Swami Vivekananda did not describe education as a transfer of information; he referred to it as “the manifestation of the perfection already in man.”

That is a fundamentally different starting point. You are not filling an empty vessel; you are drawing something out. Rabindranath Tagore wanted students to learn under open skies, in conversation with the world

More transactions require reconciliation. Financial systems must account for a higher volume of contested outcomes. Legal processes take longer to reach closure, adding to already significant case backlogs. Administrative decisions — whether related to benefits, compliance, or enforcement — require additional layers of validation.

The cost of arriving at a final decision rises — not because systems fail, but because they cannot produce outcomes that remain final over time.

This introduces asymmetry. Two records that appear identical may not carry the same evidentiary strength, depending on when they were created and how they were secured.

Over time, this erodes the consistency with which decisions are made and accepted. That is not only a technical issue. It is a legal and administrative one too.

India’s policy approach to quantum technologies has so far been forward-looking. The focus has been on building capability, supporting research, and positioning the country within a global technological race. Regulatory frameworks have also strengthened cybersecurity practices across sectors.

But this challenge sits in a different category. Cybersecurity is concerned with protecting systems from attack, breach, or intrusion. This concerns the long-term credibility of records even in the absence of any attack.

There is also a limit to what policy can address later. Future systems can be upgraded. New cryptographic standards can be adopted. But existing records cannot be retroactively secured in the same way.

A transaction created today carries its assumptions forward into the future. As those assumptions weaken, so does the relative strength of that record.

Over time, this produces a layered system. Newer records, created under stronger and more resilient standards, retain greater integrity. Older ones, created under earlier assumptions, become more open to challenge.

India still has a window to respond before this becomes a source of systemic friction. Transition timelines for critical systems need to be clearly defined. Financial infrastructure, identity platforms, and governance databases cannot move in an uncoordinated manner. A phased approach is necessary, but it must also be time-bound.

High-risk records must be identified and prioritised. Not all data carries the same consequences. Financial contracts, land records, identity-linked systems, and regulatory filings require particular attention because they are most likely to be contested and have the highest downstream impact.

Legal and regulatory clarity is equally important. Courts and institutions will need to determine how digital evidence is evaluated as cryptographic standards evolve. Allowing these questions to be resolved only through litigation would introduce avoidable uncertainty.

India’s digital transformation has been built on the ability to verify at population scale. That achievement is substantial and of global importance. The next challenge is not expansion, but endurance.

Because the real test of any system is not whether it works in routine conditions. It is whether, years from now, it can still settle matters with the same confidence — and whether the proof it relies on continues to carry authority when it is most needed.

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The measurement problem — what is not measured is not there

Unfortunately, holistic education has been discussed since the initial policy laid out by Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan, and the same emphasis is reflected again in NEP 2020. It is now 2026.

The vision is already six years old, yet we are still waiting for implementation with full spirit and rigour. It is also important to understand that, in the institution’s consciousness, “what is measured is what exists”.

It doesn’t mean students are not developing creativity, ethical judgement, and empathy. These things are happening despite the system, not because of it. If we do not project enough emphasis on these parameters and do not assign value to these characteristics and ignore to need to bring meaningful measurements to these parameters, these components become irrelevant to the student and eventually eliminated. We all understand, there is no perfect mechanism to assess these parameters but at the same time, we do not need a perfect measurement system before we start measuring.

Even the simplest measurement model, if consistently applied, is definitely more powerful than no measurement model. It will certainly create a baseline, defines accountability, and further creates an opportunity and the possibility of improvement.

The moment demands action — not discussion

At this juncture, higher education institutions need to evolve by developing practical implementation guidelines for applying the policy; otherwise, we risk missing the boat and making our higher education system irrelevant.

Change in institutions is always hard. There are structures to protect, traditions to honor, and interests to navigate. But the proverb holds: every step feels difficult until you take the first one. The universities that survive this moment and thrive in it will be the ones that stop defending what they were and start rebuilding around what education was always meant to be. The question was never “Do we need universities?” — It was always “What kind of universities do we deserve?”

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FROM THE WORLD

INDONESIA

27 missing after boat sinks

Rescue teams raced to find 27 people missing after a passenger boat sank in rough seas on Monday on its way to a remote village in eastern Indonesia. The boat, Nazila 05, which was carrying 27 passengers and crew members, departed North Maluku province's Taliabu Island bound for Kema, a coastal village in the province just after dusk on Sunday, said Muhammad Rizal, who heads the search and rescue office in Central Sulawesi's Palu city. He said the incident was first reported to authorities on Monday morning by the ship's owner, Rifani Samatia, after the Nazila 05's captain contacted him to report that the vessel's bow had broken after hit by high waves during rough weather.

SOUTH SUDAN

Gunmen kill more than 70

Gunmen killed more than 70 people in South Sudan over a gold mining row on the outskirts of the capital over the weekend, a police spokesperson confirmed on Monday. A video of dozens of bodies at an open ground was shared online, and a local journalist said many other victims are believed to have fled to the bushes. The gold mining site at Jebel Iraq in Central Equatoria State has, in the past, been the site of violent clashes between illegal miners and mining companies. Police spokesperson Kwacijwok Dominic Amondock said he would share more information about the attack once he gets more details. "All I know is that unknown gunmen attacked Jebel Iraq at a gold mine. There are more than 70 dead and many more injured," he said. The Sudan People's Liberation Movement/Army in Opposition, or SPLM/A-IO, condemned the attack on Monday and blamed Government forces.

Israel Parliament passes Budget, Netanyahu to avoid early polls

MELANIE LIDMAN ■ Tel Aviv

Israel's Parliament on Monday passed its annual budget in a marathon overnight session, ensuring that Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's government can complete its term until the fall. Israel needed to pass a budget before April 1 in order to avoid triggering early elections. Netanyahu still reserves the right to call early elections before then if he wants. Israel's opposition slammed the budget for increasing funding to Israel's ultra-Orthodox communities at a time when the country is facing soaring costs over its war in Iran and is still reeling from a two-year war in Gaza. Opposition leader Yair Lapid called it "the greatest theft in the state's history." "The government of glutony and evasion carried out a nocturnal heist," former Prime Minister Naftali Bennett, who is expected to challenge Netanyahu in upcoming elections, wrote on X. Opposition parties were especially furious over a last-minute amendment providing an additional \$250 million to ultra-Orthodox schools. Anger has increased at the ultra-Orthodox community for its refusal to allow its young men to serve in the military while it is stretched to its breaking point and is in desperate need of additional soldiers. Military service is mandatory for most Jews.



Far-right Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich praised the budget for "taking care of all Israeli citizens, without exception." Netanyahu's government is in the final months of its four-year term and is required to hold elections by the end of October. Israeli governments rarely last their full terms, though the budget's passage means Netanyahu, whose popularity has dropped since Hamas' October 7, 2023, attack, is now likely to complete his term. The budget passed 62-55. Sirens warning of missiles launched from Iran toward Jerusalem interrupted the discussions three times, according to the parliament's spokesperson. The session took place in the building's auditorium, rather than the

plenum, because it is located closer to a bomb shelter. The USD 270 billion budget, Israel's largest ever, included a 20 per cent increase for the Ministry of Defense due to the ongoing war against Iran. The ministry's budget has swollen to USD 45 billion, forcing cuts in other government ministries. Recent opinion polls in Israel indicate that while Israelis overwhelmingly support the war, Netanyahu and his political coalition don't appear to be benefiting. Iran continues to fire missiles at Israel each day, disrupting the lives of millions of anxious and exhausted voters. Israel's war with Hezbollah militants in Lebanon also is intensifying, while the disruption of the flow of oil from the

Persian Gulf has upended the global economy. Pushing off elections until the fall could allow Netanyahu to harness momentum from the Iran war once middle-of-the-night sirens are a more distant memory for Israelis. But the election would also fall close to the anniversary of the October 7 attack, the worst in Israel's history. Israel's military recently extended its wartime guidelines for civilians, which prevent large gatherings and encourage people to stay within a certain distance of bomb shelters, for an additional week. This means the wartime guidelines will include at least the first part of the weeklong Passover holiday, which starts on Wednesday. (AP)

Gunmen kill at least 20 in night-time attack in Nigeria

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Abuja (Nigeria)

A night-time attack on a community in Nigeria's north-central region left at least 20 people dead, residents and authorities said. The attack occurred on Sunday night in Gari Ya Waye community in the Jos North area of Plateau state, Joyce Lohiya Ramnap, the state commissioner for information, said in a statement. She did not give the number of casualties, but said there was "loss of lives" and injured. The State Government imposed a 48-hour curfew to prevent further attacks, Ramnap said. No group has claimed responsibility but residents told The Associated Press



that many gunmen on bikes shot sporadically into the community. Ibukun Falodun, a resident, said that 20 people were confirmed dead. Attacks in Plateau State are part of a long-running cycle of vio-

lence in north-central Nigeria, where disputes over land and grazing between mostly Muslim Fulani herders and largely Christian farming communities frequently escalate into deadly clashes. Criminal gangs are also active.

China resumes direct flights to North Korea after 6 years



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Beijing

China's flag carrier resumed direct flights between Beijing and North Korea's capital of Pyongyang on Monday not long after the restoration of passenger train services between the capitals. The Air China flight was welcomed by the Chinese ambassador to North Korea, Wang Yajun, and other diplomats, according to Chinese state media. Passenger train service from China to North Korea had resumed March 12. Flights and passenger trains to North Korea had been suspended since the beginning of the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020. North Korean carrier Air Koryo resumed flights between the capitals in 2023. North Korea banned all

foreign tourists during the pandemic but has started easing the restrictions, with a Russian tour group entering the country in 2024. Chinese tour groups had made up 90 per cent of all visitors to North Korea prior to the ban, and the delay on resuming Chinese tours surprised observers. China is Pyongyang's biggest trading partner and major ally, but Beijing has expressed disapproval over the years at North Korea's test-launches of missiles that could be used to target South Korea and the United States. North Korean leader Kim Jong Un travelled to Beijing in September to attend a massive military parade, marking the first time a North Korean leader had been present at a Chinese military parade in decades.

Afghanistan accuses Pak of shelling outskirts of eastern city, killing and wounding civilians

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kabul

Afghanistan's government accused Pakistan's military of shelling the outskirts of an eastern Afghan city on Sunday, killing one person and wounding more than a dozen in the latest episode of renewed fighting between the two neighbouring countries. The fighting, which erupted in late February, has been the most severe between Afghanistan and Pakistan in decades. Pakistan accuses Afghanistan of providing a safe haven for militants who carry out attacks inside Pakistan, especially for the Pakistani Taliban. The group is separate but closely allied with the Afghan Taliban, which seized power in Afghanistan in 2021 during the chaotic withdrawal of US-led troops. Kabul denies the allegation.



Afghan deputy Government spokesman Hamdullah Fitrat said that "mortars and other heavy weaponry" were used Sunday afternoon to strike rural areas and civilian homes on the outskirts of the city of Asadabad in Kunar Province. In a post on X accompanied by photos of wounded children, Fitrat said that preliminary figures indicated that one person had been killed and 16 others were wounded, mostly women and children.

Protests continue in Nepal over former PM Oli's arrest for third consecutive day

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

Protests continued in Nepal for the third consecutive day following the arrest of former PM KP Sharma Oli over suppression of Gen Z protests last year, even as authorities intensified probe against three ex-prime ministers over money laundering. Oli and former home minister Ramesh Lekhak were arrested on Saturday for their alleged involvement in suppressing the Gen Z movement of September 8 and 9 last year, in which 76 people,



including around two dozen youths, were killed. The arrests came after the newly formed Balendra Shah government decided to implement the report of the probe commission into the Gen Z protests in its first cabinet meeting. Hundreds of members of Oli's Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist) and their sister organisations and student wings gathered at Naya Baneshwor area

on Monday morning carrying placards that read "Immediately release KP Oli," and "End the politics of revenge." Monday's protest rally was comparatively peaceful, unlike the protests organised by the party on Saturday and Sunday. On Sunday, over a dozen UML cadres were injured as they clashed with the riot police. In another development, Nepal's Department of Money Laundering

Investigation (DMLI) and Nepal police have intensified probe against former prime ministers Sher Bahadur Deuba, KP Sharma Oli and Pushpa Kamal Dahal after the arrest of a former minister Deepak Khadka. Before upgrading the case to a detailed investigation, the department had conducted preliminary enquiries for nearly six months, The Kathmandu Post reported. The investigation was formally intensified after discrepancies were identified during that period, prompting authorities to widen the scope of scrutiny, the report said. Former energy minister and Nepali Congress leader Deepak Khadka, arrested on Sunday in connection with a money laundering case, was admitted to Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital in Maharajguni on Monday after complaining of health problems. (PTI)

the foreign, Russia's Ministry of Foreign Affairs said. During its counterintelligence activities, the FSB identified an undeclared UK intelligence presence under the guise of the British Embassy in Moscow, it said. "Due to the violation of Russian legislation and in accordance with Article 9 of the Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations of 1961, the British side was informed of the revocation of the accreditation of this person," the Russian Foreign Ministry said. According to the Russian Foreign Ministry, an FSB investigation revealed that the second secretary had intentionally falsified information on his visa application, a direct violation of Russian law. In addition, the bureau identified signs of Rensburg's involvement in "intelligence" and "subversive activities" that posed a threat to Russia's security. In January, Moscow had expelled a second secretary of the British Embassy after the FSB uncovered his spying activities. (PTI)

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Manohar Deurmalle, Father of No.15585759X Nk(L) Deurmalle R M, R/o- Chek Pombhurna Dist-Chandrapur, Maharashtra-441224, have changed my name from Manohar Deurmalle to Manohar Nanaji Deurmalle, vide affidavit dated 30/03/2026.

PD(705)C I, Lalitabai, Mother of No.15585759X Nk(L) Deurmalle R M, R/o- Chek Pombhurna Dist-Chandrapur, Maharashtra-441224, have changed my name from Lalitabai to Lalitabai Manohar Deurmalle, vide affidavit dated 30/03/2026.

PD(706)C I, No.13629854A Hav Sunil Kumar, R/o- Vill- Makaura, PO- Jhabkra, Dist- Gurdaspur, Punjab- 143525, have changed my Daughter's name from Divya to Divya Sharma, vide affidavit dated 30/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(707)C I, Bbraj Mohan Prasad Singh, Father of JC-781655W Nb/Sub Priya Ranjan Kumar, R/o- Vill-Surhatha, Post- Bibipur, Dist-Vaishali, Bihar- 844111, have changed my name from Bbraj Mohan Prasad Singh to Braj Mohan Prasad Singh, vide affidavit dated 30/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(710)C I, Vanmala, Mother of- No.15262961A GNR Mahulkar Roshan Gajanan, R/o- Vill- Amboda, Post- Akolkhed, Teh- Akot, Dist- Akola, Maharashtra- 444101, have changed my name From Vanmala to Vanmala Gajanan Mahulkar, vide Affidavit dated 30/03/2026 Before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(711)C I, JC-710547H Nb/Sub Sunil Kumar, Unit- Army Hospital R & R, Delhi Cantt- 110010, have changed my son's name in my Army service record from Priyank Sheoran to Priyank, vide affidavit dated 30/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(712)C I, Sunita Kumari, W/o No.14660144A Hav Ajeet Pratap Singh, R/o- Vill- Ardaya, PO- Achhnera, Teh- Kiraoli, Dist- Agra, U.P.- 283101, have changed my name from Sunita Kumari to Sunita, vide affidavit dated 30/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(713)C I, Surekha Sagar Mane W/o No.14875859X NK/SHT Mane Sagar Sopan, R/o- A/P- Shegaon, Teh- Jath, Dist- Sangli, Maharashtra- 416404, have changed my name from Surekha Sagar Mane to Mane Surekha Sagar, vide affidavit dated 30/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(708)C I, No.22057759N Sep/NA Gagan Deepak G, R/o- Gange House, Gange Road, PO- R D Nagar, Kudlu, Kasaragod- 671124, declare that in my service documents my Mother's Name is wrongly written as Chithra whereas her correct Name is B N Chithra which may be amended accordingly.]

PD(709)C

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it known to all that my client **Sh. Raj Kumar & Seema Rani**, R/o H.No. B-36, Anand Vihar, Laxman Puri, Uttam Nagar, West Delhi-110059 have disowned and debarred his son namely **Sunny**, S/o Raj Kumar, R/o H.No. B-36, Anand Vihar, Laxman Puri, Uttam Nagar, West Delhi-110059 (aadhar card 7915 5812 8870) from all moveable and immovable properties because his behavior is not appropriate and has caused mental harassment to my client & my client has severed all relations with him. Anyone dealing with him may do so at his/her own risk, costs and consequences. My client shall not be responsible for any act or omission done by them.

Mohit Sharma (Advocate) Ch. No. 736, Dwarka Court Complex, Dwarka, New Delhi-110075

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of **Smt. Sangeta** who is owner of AREA MEASURING 12-BIGHAS, 65-BISWAS, OUT OF KHASRA Nos.86/222(0-07), 232(1-07), 24(1-07), 25(0-07), 92/3/34 (1-12), 4 (5-07), 7/1 (1-18), SITUATED IN THE REVENUE ESTATE OF VILLAGE BAKHTAWARPUR, DELHI-110036, having acquired the same vide Gift Deed dated 10/03/2026 duly registered in the office of SR-North Libaspur, as registration No. 2026/20/1063, Addl. Book No. 1, Page Nos. 85-94, Volume No. 1696, Dated 10/03/2026 now **Shri Praveen Kumar Bhurga** and **Smt. Sangeta** intend to mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from **Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited**. That (1) Original GPA dated 16/05/2005 in favour of **Shri Ragbir Singh** and **Shri Satyavir Singh** (Docs No. 13254), (2) GPA dated 20/02/2006 in favour of **Shri Sudhir Mullick** (Docs No. 4758), (3) GPA dated 02/03/2008 in favour of **Shri Swadesh Kumar Mullick** and (4) Sale Deed dated 20/05/2008 in favour of **Smt. Mona Arora** (docs No. 7689) has been lost/misplaced not available. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. **Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40463316 & 41667327**

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that **Mrs. Anita Arora**, is the owner of Built-up Property Bearing No. 153B-1, comprised in Khassra no. 1151/3 min., having an area measuring 105 Sq. Yds. Ward No. 2, Situated at Mehrauli, New Delhi 110030, vide GPA dated 25.06.2025, regd. as Doc. No. 2025/7/VI/1586, she is intending to mortgage the same with **Shubham Housing Development Finance Company Ltd.**, and **Mrs. Shakuntla Arora** expired leaving behind **Mr. Deepak Arora** as only the single legal heirs, who is pertaining to the said property chain. General public hereby informed that if anybody has any charge/interest in the said property or any kind of dispute kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.

Akanish Singh, Advocate Juris Core (Law Firm) Add:- 607, 6th Floor, Shivam Tower, Ansal Building RDC Ghaziabad, U.P. 201002 E-MAIL:- juriscore@gmail.com, Ph: 8076533540

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE						
SR NO.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD B&R, KARNAL	CONST. OF GOVT. COLLEGE IN VILLAGE ISRANA DISTT. PANIPAT (PDG. SUB STATION AND DG SET ONLY) + 2 WORKS	28.03.2026 06.04.2026	65.32 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01842265696 pwd-eeed-karnal@hry.nic.in
2	PWD B&R,CHANDIGARH	DEVELOPMENT OF LANDSCAPING WORK IN WAR MEMORIAL IN THE HONOUR OF MARTYRS OF THE FIRST WAR OF INDIA'S INDEPENDENCE, 1857 AT AMBALA CANTT, DISTT. AMBALA	01.04.2026 08.04.2026	18.20 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9779691170 eeehortpvd@gmail.com
3	PWD B&R, HISAR	PROVIDING SPECIAL REPAIR TO E.I INTERNAL AND ESTATE SERVICES AT BHIM STADIUM BHWANI IN DISTRICT BHWANI.	27.03.2026 04.04.2026	16.05 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
4	PANCHAYATI RAJ, KARNAL	PROVDING STONE PITCHING ON DANDU WILDA POND-B VILLAGE PADMA BLOCK MUNAK	28.03.2026 06.04.2026	40.24 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896202019 prexeeng.kri@hry.nic.in
5	CIVIL SURGEON, NUH	PUBLICATION OF E-TENDER NOTICE FOR CANTEN SERVICES, FOR HEALTH DEPARTMENT NUH (MEWT).	27.03.2026 13.04.2026	EMD 10000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9417560524 dhs.csmwt@hry.nic.in
6	CIVIL AVIATION, HARYANA CHANDIGARH	ANNUAL MAINTENANCE CONTRACT & SUB CONTRACT OF CONTINUING AIRWORTHINESS MANAGEMENT ORGANIZATION (CAMO) FOR HELICOPTER MBB BK 117 C-2 (EC-145),MSN# 9210, VT-HRY.	31.03.2026 20.04.2026	EMD 5000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01722709386 cavation@hry.nic.in
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in						RO 44309-I-27-7

PUBLIC NOTICE

My father Late Sh. SACHIN KUMAR JAIN S/o Late Sh. Naresh Chand Jain R/o Flat 1411, Tower Felecity, Mahagun Maple, Sector 50, Noida, Uttar Pradesh, India, 201301, booked flat/unit No. R390BR11106/Flat # 1106 in the project called "Supertech ORB" situated at sector-74 Supertech ORB Noida 201307, after his demise, I requested M/s Supertech ORB Project Pvt. Ltd. to transfer the said flat to on my name along with Mrs. Davinder Kaur Pahwa W/o Mr. Manish Pahwa, D-399, Tagore Garden Extension, West Delhi, Delhi, India, 110027, if anybody has any objection, he/she may contact M/s Supertech ORB Project Pvt. Ltd. office at CH-9/A, Sector 74, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, India, 201301 within 15 days of the Published notice. Ms. Sonakshi V. Jain D/o Late Sh. SACHIN KUMAR JAIN R/o Flat 1411, Tower Felecity, Mahagun Maple, Sector 50, Noida, Uttar Pradesh, India, 201301.

Myanmar transitions back to elected Govt

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bangkok

Myanmar's Parliament on Monday began the process of electing the country's next president, which will mark a nominal return to an elected Government after five years of military rule, but is widely considered to be an effort to keep power in the hands of the army.

The process began the same day that Senior Gen Min Aung Hlaing, the head of the military-led Government, announced that he was relinquishing his concurrent post of the military's commander-in-chief. The move is a prerequisite for becoming head of State, because the Constitution prohibits the president from simultaneously holding the top military position.

Min Aung Hlaing will be among three nominees to contend for the president's post, but is virtually certain to get the job as lawmakers from military-backed parties and appointed members from the military hold a commanding majority in Parliament.

Here's what to know about the nominal transition to elected democracy.
New president could be named by end of week: The Lower House, the Upper House and the military bloc



Myanmar lawmakers attend a session at Lower House of Parliament in Myanmar on Monday

AP

— which by appointment holds a quarter of the seats in the legislature — can each propose a nominee, formally for vice president. Min Aung Hlaing was one of two put forward by the Lower House, while the Upper House offered up two relatively unknown candidates, and the military did not announce their choices.

Once each group settles on a single nominee and their credentials are verified by a review committee, the 586-member legislature will vote; the candidate with the highest number of votes will become president, while the other two will serve as vice presidents.

Although the exact timing

of the vote remains unclear, the vote could come as early as Thursday.

Long history of military rule in Myanmar: Parliament's members were elected in three phases of voting held in December and January. Opponents of military rule charged that the polls were unfair, designed to legitimise military rule after ousting Aung San Suu Kyi's elected Government in February 2021.

Myanmar was under military rule from 1962 until 2016, when Suu Kyi's National League for Democracy party came to power after a landslide 2015 election victory. It won an even greater mandate in the 2020 general election, but the army seized

power before the new Parliament could convene.

Peaceful protests against military rule were put down with deadly force, and pro-democracy activists turned to armed resistance, allying themselves with ethnic minority groups who have long been fighting for greater autonomy.

Much of the country is now enmeshed in a brutal civil war, and security concerns meant voting in the recent election could be held in only 263 of the country's 330 townships.

Min Aung Hlaing has long wielded power: Min Aung Hlaing had led Myanmar's military since 2011, retaining broad political powers as

well under the 2008 military-drafted constitution. His profile rose internationally after a 2017 campaign of repression against the Rohingya Muslim ethnic minority, which drove hundreds of thousands into Bangladesh for refuge amid alleged atrocities.

State-run MRTV television reported that the 69-year-old Min Aung Hlaing transferred command of the military on Monday to his close aide, Gen. Ye Win Oo, in a ceremony in the Capital, Naypyitaw.

Ye Win Oo, 60, previously served as secretary of the ruling State Administration Council and the State Security and Peace Commission, established after the army takeover.

No significant opposition in Parliament: Major opposition parties, including Suu Kyi's former ruling National League for Democracy, were either blocked from running in the recent election or refused to compete under conditions they deemed unfair.

Suu Kyi, Myanmar's 80-year-old former leader, is serving a 27-year prison term on charges widely viewed as spurious and politically motivated. Her party was forced to dissolve in 2023 after refusing to register under new military rules.

Pakistan PM Shehbaz Sharif reviews fuel supply situation in country

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Monday reviewed the fuel supply situation in the country in the wake of the ongoing West Asia conflict while emphasising efforts to provide "further relief to weaker segments."

Implementation of Government measures for fuel savings, suggestions for the future course of action, and the current stock were discussed in the meeting, according to a statement issued by the PM Office.

An audit report by the Intelligence Bureau on the progress of implementation of the Prime Minister's fuel savings measures and the austerity campaign was also presented, it added.

An increase in the levy on high-octane fuel used in elite large vehicles has not resulted in any change in jet fuel prices, it said.

A coordination is being established with provincial Governments to expedite the ownership registration of individuals with motorcycles and rickshaws to benefit from potential relief measures.

"In this hour of difficulty, the economically weaker



segments will not be left alone," PM Sharif said.

The Prime Minister said that Government expenditures have been reduced, developmental budget cuts have been implemented, and 60 per cent of Government vehicles have been immediately suspended.

"In the current situation, the sequence of sacrifices has been started with cuts in Government expenditures," he said, adding that proposals to increase oil prices have been repeatedly rejected, and the funds obtained from savings measures have been utilised for public relief.

Sharif also said that Pakistan is making full efforts on the diplomatic front regarding peace in the region.

The meeting was held a day after the foreign ministers of Saudi Arabia, Egypt and Türkiye visited Islamabad for a quadrilateral meeting on the West Asia crisis.

After a detailed discussion, the foreign ministers went back, while Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar indicated that a meeting between the US and Iran officials was possible. (PTI)

West Asia conflict: Spain closes airspace for US planes

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Madrid

Spain has closed its airspace to US planes involved in the Iran war, Defence Minister Margarita Robles said on Monday. Spain had already said the US could not use jointly operated military bases in the country for operations related to the West Asia conflict.

"This was made perfectly clear to the American military and forces from the very beginning. Therefore, neither the bases are authorised, nor, of course, is the use of Spanish airspace authorised for any actions related to the war in Iran," Robles told reporters.

Spain's Government under Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez has been Europe's most critical voice of US and Israeli military actions in the West Asia.

Death toll in Afghanistan floods rises to 28

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kabul

Afghan authorities on Monday said the death toll from severe weather that has struck swathes of the country over the past four days has increased to 28, with 49 people injured. Dozens of people have died from extreme weather in the country so far this year.

Storms and heavy rainfall over the past few days across several provinces have led to severe flooding, landslides and lightning strikes, the Afghanistan National Disaster Management Authority said, adding that the figures could increase as more details become available.

The severe weather has destroyed 130 homes and damaged a further 436, while it has also killed more than 240 animals, wiped out 93 km of roads and destroyed irrigation canals



and agricultural land, the authority said. In all, 1,130 families have been affected, it added.

Earlier this year, heavy snowfall and flash floods left dozens of people dead across the country.

Afghanistan is highly vulnerable to extreme weather events, with snow and heavy rain that trigger flash floods, often killing dozens, or even hundreds, of people at a time. In 2024, more

than 300 people died in springtime flash floods.

Decades of conflict, coupled with poor infrastructure, a struggling economy, deforestation and the intensifying effects of climate change have amplified the impact of such disasters, particularly in remote areas where many homes are built of mud and offer limited protection against sudden deluges or heavy snowfall.

Russia to continue supplying energy resources to Cuba, says Kremlin

VINAY SHUKLA
■ Moscow

Russia will continue to supply energy resources to Havana, the Kremlin said on Monday, as a Russian tanker carrying the first consignment of 773 thousand barrels of oil reached a Cuban port.

"We will continue working. In the desperate situation the Cubans now find themselves, we cannot remain indifferent. Therefore, we will continue working on this issue," the Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov told reporters.

The official news agency TASS noted that the energy situation in Havana has worsened following the US-led military operation in Venezuela on January 3, which resulted in the capture of President Nicolas Maduro.

On January 29, the US President signed an executive order authorising Washington to impose punitive tariffs on goods from countries that supply oil to Cuba.

It was previously reported that the US does not object to periodic oil shipments to Cuba by Russia and other countries for humanitarian reasons.

Despite the de facto US fuel blockade of the island, the US Coast Guard's two patrol boats in the region did not attempt to intercept the Russian tanker, the non-government Interfax agency reported.

According to some reports circulating on social media, Anatoly Kolodkin, on the list of Russia's sanctioned "shadow fleet", was escorted at various stages of sailing through the English Channel



and Atlantic by a naval frigate and a submarine in accordance with the Government decision.

On March 25, the Maritime Board of Russia had decided to provide naval escort to vessels sailing to and from the Russian ports.

To avoid detention, the vessel operators and owners involved in shipping to and from Russia have received

detailed instructions on operational coordination with ports and naval authorities.

"Monitoring of cargo ships carrying Russian freight has been intensified. Authorities can now request, via port captains, escorts for Russian-flagged vessels from mobile fire support units, bolstering maritime security," Maritime Board had said. (PTI)

China sanctions Japanese lawmaker close to Takaichi over ties to Taiwan

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Tokyo

China announced on Monday that it is sanctioning a conservative Japanese lawmaker close to Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi, accusing him of "colluding with" separatists in Taiwan, the latest incident that underlines growing tensions between Tokyo and Beijing over the self-governed island.

China's Foreign Ministry said the sanctions include banning entry of Keiji Furuya to China, including to Hong Kong and Macao, and prohibiting his activities with organisations and individuals in China, effective immediately.

Furuya heads a bipartisan Japan-Taiwan lawmakers' consultation council and has visited Taiwan regularly. He most recently visited Taiwan's capital of Taipei,



Japanese lawmaker Keiji Furuya

where he held talks with Taiwanese President Lai Ching-te in mid-March.

Furuya is a close ally of Takaichi who headed the election strategy for their governing Liberal Democratic Party ahead of the party's electoral victory in February.

China accused Furuya of repeatedly visiting Taiwan despite China's strong opposition and of "colluding with Taiwan independence separatist forces."

The ministry said Furuya's

activities violate the one-China principle — which holds that Taiwan is a province of China — and "grossly interfere in China's internal affairs and seriously undermine China's sovereignty and territorial integrity."

Furuya said the notice came via the Japanese Foreign Ministry. He defended his actions, telling reporters that "it is only natural" for parliamentary groups to promote exchanges between "countries" with shared values.

France probes possible Iran link after bomb attack foiled outside Bank of America

SYLVIE CORBET
■ Paris

French authorities are investigating a suspected link to Iran after thwarting a bomb attack outside a Bank of America building in Paris on the weekend, the interior minister said Monday.

The authorities suspect there could be a link to Iran due to similarities to other recent attempted attacks in Europe which a pro-Iran group claimed credit for, French Interior Minister Laurent Nunez said.

On Saturday morning, Paris police officers spotted two suspects carrying a shopping bag near the premises of the Bank of America in the 8th arrondissement of the French capital. Three suspects have since been arrested and the national anti-terrorism prosecutor's office opened an investigation into

alleged terrorism-related offenses.

Authorities are making a "direct link" with Iran because the "modus operandi is in every respect similar to actions that have been carried out in the Netherlands and in Belgium," Nunez said on French radio RTL on Monday morning.

In those cases there were claims by a pro-Iranian group that "linked them to the conflict" in the Middle-East, he said.

The group, known on Telegram under the name Harakat Ashab al-Yamin al-Islamia, which translates as the Islamic Movement of the Companions of the Right, also claimed responsibility for an attack last week in London, where four ambulances belonging to a Jewish charity were set on fire.

"Typically, intelligence services of this country (Iran)



operate in this way: they use proxies, a series of sub-contractors, often common criminals, to carry out highly targeted actions aimed at US interests, the interests of the Jewish community, or Iranian opposition figures," Nunez said. He said French

authorities have stepped up security around key personalities and sites since the United States and Israel launched their war against Iran on February 28, including the personal protection of some figures from the Iranian Opposition. (AP)

Ukraine chides German defence firm over jibes about Lego drones made by housewives

ILLIA NOVIKOV
■ Kyiv

Senior officials in Kyiv are taking a swipe at the head of German defence giant Rheinmetall, whose unflattering comments about Ukrainian drone technology and the role of women in the war against Russia ignited a social media backlash.

Rheinmetall AG's Chairman and CEO Armin Papperger likened Ukraine's development of cutting-edge drone expertise to playing with "Lego" and said the drones are being built by "Ukrainian housewives."

"They have 3D printers in the kitchen, and they produce parts for drones," Papperger said in comments to The Atlantic magazine published Friday. "This is not innovation."

Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, who is offering his country's advanced drone technology to Gulf countries amid the Iran war, on Monday described Papperger's remarks as "strange."

"If every Ukrainian housewife can really produce drones, then every Ukrainian housewife could also be the

CEO of Rheinmetall," he told reporters via voicemail on WhatsApp. "I congratulate our defence-industrial complex on being at such a high level."

Ukraine has quickly grown into one of the world's leading producers of cutting-edge, battle-tested drone interceptors that are cheap and effective.

After Papperger's comments appeared, Ukrainians took to social media to berate him under the hashtag "MadeByHousewives".

Ukraine Prime Minister Yulia



Svyrydenko praised the role of Ukrainian women in the effort to thwart Russia's all-out invasion of February 2022.

"Ukrainian women are indeed an essential part of Ukraine's war effort and of Europe's security," she posted on X late Sunday. "They have stepped with courage into many areas once seen as male-dominated, bringing energy, discipline, and determination."

"And they are doing this while raising our next generation and caring for their families under wartime pressures," she added.

Zelenskyy adviser Alexander Kamyshin said he regularly visits military manufacturing plants and sees men and women working side by side. "They are great housewives, yet they have to work hard in the military factories," he said on X, adding: "They deserve respect."

Rheinmetall responded Sunday on X, saying that the company has "the utmost respect" for Ukrainian people fighting Russia.

"Every single woman and man in (Ukraine) is making an immeasurable contribution," it said. (AP)

PROSPECT

East India tops HDFC Life index in financial smarts, emergency readiness

East India outshines the national average in financial realism and preparedness, according to HDFC Life's Ready for Life Index (RLI) 2025. The Ipsos India study, based on 1,836 face-to-face interviews across metros, Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities, measures readiness on four pillars: financial planning, emergency preparedness, health & well-being, and retirement strategy. Nationally, there's a 26-point gap between perceived and actual readiness – but the East narrows it to 20 points, signaling sharper financial discipline.

“East India is more grounded in assessing readiness, especially in emergencies and health,” said Vineet Arora. “Yet retirement planning and protection awareness need a boost through better education.”

The region shines in emergencies: 53 per cent have funds lasting over four months (vs 41 per cent nationally), and nearly three-fourths can access cash in 48 hours. Health habits are stronger too, with more fitness routines and check-ups. On retirement, 68 per cent have started saving (vs 55 per cent nationally), though corpus expectations stay conservative.

JSS Public School, Noida celebrates annual sports-cum-cultural day “UDAAN 2026”

JSS Public School, Noida celebrated its Annual Sports-cum-Cultural Day “UDAAN 2026” with great enthusiasm and grandeur on March 28, 2026. The event showcased the remarkable talents, discipline, and cultural richness of the students, making it a memorable occasion for all present. The programme commenced with an auspicious Ganesh Vandana, seeking blessings for the successful conduct of the event. This was followed by the lighting of the ceremonial lamp, symbolising knowledge and positivity.

The school's Annual Report was then presented by the respected Principal, Maina Singh, highlighting the achievements and progress of the institution during the academic session. The occasion was graced by the esteemed presence of the Chief Guest, YA Rajshree, India IT Domain Lead, Alight, and the Guest of Honour, Dr MS Shashi Kumar, Scientist 'E', Department of Science and Industrial Research, Ministry of Science and Technology, Government of India. Their presence added dignity and inspiration to the celebration.

A vibrant March Past reflected the discipline and unity of the students, followed by a series of captivating performances including energetic drills, a colourful Rajasthani folk dance, a lively sports dance, impressive karate demonstrations and thrilling skating performances. Each performance received loud applause and appreciation from the audience.

The event concluded with a spectacular grand finale, followed by the soulful rendition of the National Song and National Anthem, filling the atmosphere with pride and patriotism. UDAAN 2026 truly lived up to its name by giving students a platform to soar high with confidence, talent, and determination, leaving behind an unforgettable impression of excellence and celebration.

Educate Girls marks 18th foundation day in Lucknow, lauds Govt schemes for girls education

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Educate Girls celebrated its 18th foundation day here on Monday, spotlighting its grassroots efforts to boost girls' education across communities.

Uttar Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak praised Government initiatives like Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao and Mission Shakti for enhancing access to education for the girl child.

CEO Gayatri Nair Lobo credited the organisation's success to dedicated volunteers and key partnerships that have driven real change on the ground.

The event drew over 300 stakeholders, who heard inspiring success stories from Team Balika volunteers



working tirelessly to enrol out-of-school girls, curb dropouts and dismantle social barriers – reinforcing Educate Girls' unwavering commitment to girl empowerment through education.

ED seizes ₹64,920 cr in bank fraud cases: FM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate has investigated 1,105 bank fraud cases under the PMLA and has attached proceeds of crime worth ₹64,920 crore, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Monday.

In the Lok Sabha, Sitharaman also said the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act (FEOA), 2018 was enacted to deter economic offenders from evading Indian law by

staying abroad and was applicable to offences involving ₹100 crore or more.

The actions taken under this Act include confiscation of properties, proceeds of crime, benami properties, lookout notices through Bureau of Immigration, prohibition on raising capital and acquiring shares or voting rights.

Sitharaman, who is also in charge of the corporate affairs ministry, made the remarks while replying to a discussion



on the bill to amend the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC). During the discussion, some members had mentioned fugitive economic offenders.

BHEL bags ₹13,500 cr order from NTPC for Telangana thermal power project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned BHEL on Monday said it has secured an order worth ₹13,500 crore from NTPC for main plant package of 2,400 MW Telangana Stage-II thermal power plant.

BHEL emerged as a successful bidder for this project in October 2024, a regulatory filing said. On March 29, 2026, BHEL received



a Notification of Award (NOA) from NTPC for 3x800 MW Telangana Stage-II project (Main Plant Package).

The scope of order includes design, engineering, manufacturing, supply, erection, commissioning, and testing

of the main plant package, including civil and structural works. The order size is ₹13,500 crore excluding GST.

Operational group meeting reaffirms regional stability of Assam, Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Under the aegis of Spear Corps and the Directorate General of Assam Rifles, a Quarterly Operational Group Meeting was convened at Lekhapani on January 30, 2026.

The meeting brought together senior representatives from the Indian Army, Assam Rifles, State Police and Intelligence Agencies to undertake a comprehensive review of the prevailing security situation and to reinforce inter-agency coordination across Upper Assam, South Arunachal Pradesh and adjoining areas of Nagaland.

The meeting was attended by Hibu Tamang, IGP (Ops), TCL Region, along with forma-



tion commanders of Assam Rifles, Army representatives from Upper Assam and senior police officials from the respective States.

The presence of all stakeholders reflected a unified and resolute approach towards addressing emerging security challenges in the region.

Deliberations focused on assessment of ground intelligence, enhancement of real-time information sharing and alignment of operational priorities.

Discussions covered insurgent group activities, cross-border dynamics and the need to strengthen surveillance and area domination

in vulnerable pockets. In addition, in view of the forthcoming Assam Legislative Assembly Elections, emphasis was laid on maintaining heightened vigilance and ensuring a secure environment to preclude any disruption to the electoral process.

The meeting culminated in reaffirmation of a cohesive joint operational framework, improved interoperability and streamlined coordination protocols to enable swift and effective response to contingencies.

All agencies reiterated the need for continuous adaptation, joint training and a unified operational posture in sensitive areas, reflecting a high degree of synergy, trust and professionalism among the security forces.

Proposal to rename Jewar Airport as Lord Krishna Airport sent to CM Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

A proposal to rename the upcoming Noida Jewar International Airport has been put forward by Professor KS Rana, Trade Commissioner, Gulf Countries Council (GCC), who has written to Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath suggesting it be called “Lord Krishna Airport, Braj Bhumi.”

In his letter, Professor Rana, who has served Vice Chancellor to six private Universities at different point of time, praised the State Government's swift and



forward-looking efforts in establishing the airport, noting its potential to drive economic growth, industrial development and entrepre-

neurial activity across Uttar Pradesh.

Rana emphasised the cultural and spiritual significance of the region, pointing

out that Jewar lies within the historic Braj Bhumi, closely associated with the life and legacy of Lord Krishna.

Naming the airport accordingly, he stated it would honour this heritage while giving the region a distinctive global identity.

The proposal underscores the connection between infrastructure and cultural identity, raising questions about how modern projects can reflect historical and spiritual narratives.

The airport was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi last week.

Raigarh Budget presenting exceeds ₹480 crore projecting a surplus of over ₹22 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raigarh

Mayor Jeevardhan Chauhan on Monday presented the Budget for the financial year 2026-27 during the second Budget session of the current council of the Raigarh Municipal Corporation.

The Budget prioritises the holistic development of the city, the strengthening of infrastructure, and the expansion of civic amenities.

According to the presented budget, the Corporation's total income is estimated at ₹480.36 crore, while total expenditure is proposed at ₹458.1179 crore.

Consequently, the Corporation has set a target of achieving a surplus of ₹22.2421 crore.

Under the revenue head, an income of ₹92.74 crore and an expenditure of ₹85.4974 crore have been proposed. Meanwhile, under the capital head, receipts of ₹387.62 crore and an expenditure of ₹372.6205 crore have been allocated. During the session, Commissioner Brajesh Singh Kshatriya provided detailed clarifications to address the questions and queries raised by councilors and public representatives regarding the Corporation's budget. Prior to this, with the permission of

Council Chairman Mr Degree Lal Sahu, Corporation Secretary RN Patel presented the proposals during the special session of the Council.

The special session was attended by members of the Mayor-in-Council (MIC), councilors, public representatives, Deputy Commissioner Sutikshan Yadav, Executive Engineer Amresh Lohia, and other officers and employees of the Corporation.

Proposal to Keep Property Tax Rates Unchanged Passed Unanimously.

As the second proposal of the special session, an agenda item regarding the retention of existing property tax rates was tabled. It was noted that there has been no increase in the Collector's Guideline Rates from the year 2018-19 through 2025-26. Furthermore, [in accordance with] the Chhattisgarh Municipal Corporation Act. No order regarding an increase in property tax by the State



Government under Section 133 of the 1956 Act has been received. The agenda was passed unanimously.

Review of Last Year's Works. The Budget Speech highlighted that most of the development works proposed for the financial year 2025-26 have been completed, while the remaining works are in progress, and the tender process for some is currently underway.

Over the past year, numerous significant projects were undertaken, including the construction of roads, drains,

bridges and culverts, waterways, water tanks, public lighting systems, the beautification of squares and intersections, and the development of sports grounds.

For the convenience of citizens, the 'Johar Raigarh' chatbot app has been launched, enabling residents to submit their grievances and suggestions from the comfort of their homes and avail themselves of facilities for their resolution.

Key Proposed Works for the Year 2026-27. The upcoming

Budget proposes several significant projects for the city's development. These include the upgradation and development of Balsamund Pond; the creation of an 'Oxzyone' (green zone) at the Kosabadi Center; the construction of 10 roads within the Municipal Corporation limits; the installation of dividers, drains, and footpaths, along with the beautification of squares and intersections; the upgradation and development of major routes – including Kabir Chowk; road upgra-

dation from Chandni Chowk (via Raja Mahal) to the Circuit House; pipeline installation, lighting works, and garden development; the development of a sports ground in Bade Rampur; the construction and upgradation of Sanjay Market; the construction of a stage and pavilion at Ramlila Maidan; the conservation and beautification of Bhujbandhan Pond; the channelisation of the Marine Drive drain in Kewrabadi; the installation of high-mast lighting at Raigarh Stadium; and the construction of a truck parking and service area in Amlibhauna.

Mayor Jeevardhan Chauhan stated that this Budget has been formulated with the holistic development of the city in mind. He remarked, “Our objective is to develop Raigarh into a modern, clean, and well-equipped city.”

In this... The Budget places special emphasis on the citizens' basic necessities: roads, water, lighting, and sanitation. Furthermore, with

a view to promoting digital services, efforts are being made to connect directly with citizens through the 'Johar Raigarh' app.

In the times to come, all developmental projects will be completed in a time-bound manner. Budget Includes Adequate Provisions for the City's Holistic Development – Chairman Sahu. Describing the Budget as both balanced and pro-people, Chairman Digri Lal Sahu stated that this Municipal Corporation budget has been formulated with a careful balance between income and expenditure, incorporating adequate provisions for the holistic development of the city.

The Council's objective is to ensure that developmental works are carried out equitably across every ward and that citizens receive improved amenities.

The suggestions put forth by the councilors have been given due prominence in the Budget.

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar
Engineering Department

Tender Notice

Tender Reference No. GNDU/ENGG/2026/03/04

The Engineering Department of Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar invites online bids for:-

(i) Construction of Entrepreneurship and Innovation Training Centre within GNDU Campus, Amritsar (Under RUSA 2.0 Component 4).

Closing date & time: 09-04-2026 upto 04:00 PM

For details log onto www.eproc.punjab.gov.in

Note: Any Corrigendum / Addendum to the tender shall be published on the above website only.

2426/12/2025-26/10012 Dated CHD :- 30/03/2026

BRIEFLY

Fakhar Zaman denies ball-tampering charges in PSL

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

Pakistan’s opening stalwart Fakhar Zaman has denied ball-tampering charges stemming from the Pakistan Super League match between Lahore Qalandars and Karachi Kings at the Gaddafi Stadium. The 35-year-old was charged on Sunday night by match referee Roshan Mahanama with a Level 3 offence under Article 2.14 of the PSL Code of Conduct for Players and Player Support Personnel. Zaman was found to have violated Article 41.3 of the PSL playing conditions, which prohibits any action that alters the condition of the ball. Appearing before the former Sri Lankan cricketer, Zaman denied the charges against him.

The charge relates to an incident just before the final over of the Karachi Kings’ innings, when they needed 14 runs to win. Zaman was seen in discussion with Haris Rauf and Lahore Qalandars captain Shaheen Shah Afridi before the over. Shortly thereafter, umpire Faisal Afridi requested the ball and, after inspecting it with his colleague, determined that its condition had been altered. The match referee is expected to hold another hearing within the next 48 hours before delivering a verdict.

The umpires penalised Lahore Qalandars five runs for altering the condition of the ball and subsequently replaced it. This left Karachi Kings needing nine runs in the final over, which they successfully chased down.

Shaheen, Sikandar accused of breaching security protocols



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lahore

Pakistan Super League side Lahore Qalandars skipper Shaheen Shah Afridi and overseas player Sikandar Raza have found themselves at the centre of an embarrassing situation after being accused of breaching team security protocols at their hotel.

Muhammad Faisal, DIG (Operations, Lahore), has notified the PSL CEO of a serious violation of the security measures in place for the eight teams staying at a five-star hotel in the city.

According to the police official, despite prior warnings and refusal, Shaheen and Sikandar were found hosting four guests in Raza’s room on the eighth floor until 1:25 a.m.

The liaison officer of Lahore Qalandars, followed by team owner Sameen Rana, had sought permission to allow guests into Raza’s room at around 10:35 pm and again at 11:00 pm on Saturday, but both requests were denied.

According to the police official, the liaison officer initially approached the PCB’s manager for security and the anti-corruption unit, requesting permission for four of Raza’s relatives to visit his room. The request was declined in accordance with the security protocols.

CAF announces reforms in Africa Cup regulations

CIARAN FAHEYAP ■ Rabat (Morocco)

Still dealing with the fallout from a contentious Africa Cup of Nations final, African soccer’s governing body has announced a raft of “changes and improvements” to its statutes and regulations. The structural, legal and administrative reforms will help the Confederation of African Football regain trust in its impartiality and ensure that the scenes from the final in January are never repeated, Confederation of African Football (CAF) president Patrice Motsepe said after a meeting of its executive committee in Cairo on Sunday.

“I can stand here and say we’ve got the best referees, they are independent, they’re impartial. But if the ordinary football spectators on the continent and elsewhere think they are not so impartial, it’s not good for African football,” Motsepe said. The outcome of the final is still in dispute after CAF stripped Senegal of the title two months after the match and awarded it to host nation Morocco. Senegal has appealed to the Swiss-based Court of Arbitration for Sport and both countries claim to be African champion pending the outcome. The Senegal team paraded the trophy in Paris on Saturday.

“We have to move away also from the perception that somehow our problems in Africa and our weaknesses in Africa are greater, bigger, more embarrassing, more extreme than the problems that happen in other parts of the world,” Motsepe said. The South African businessman said CAF was working with FIFA to provide training for referees and VAR operators, and that it was imperative to pay them well to ensure integrity.



General secretary steps down: Earlier, Veron Mosengo-Omba announced he was stepping down after five years as CAF general secretary “to devote myself to more personal projects.”

The Swiss-Congolese official is a university friend of FIFA president Gianni Infantino and followed him from UEFA to FIFA in 2016. Mosengo-Omba left FIFA to take over as CAF general secretary in 2021.

CAF announced in January 2025 that the Swiss Public Prosecutor’s Office had decided to stop investigations against Mosengo-Omba “as they found no facts or legal basis to initiate legal proceedings” after he faced allegations of financial wrongdoing. “Now that I have been able to dispel the suspicions that some people have gone to great lengths to cast on me, I can retire with peace of mind and without constraint, leaving the CAF more prosperous than ever,” Mosengo-Omba said Sunday.

Jannik Sinner beats Lehecka in Miami Open final

MARC BERMAN
■ Miami Gardens (Florida)

Jannik Sinner rolled to a 6-4, 6-4 victory over Jiri Lehecka to capture the Miami Open title and complete the “Sunshine Double” on Sunday, a day after Aryna Sabalenka accomplished the same feat in a win over Coco Gauff.

The last male player to complete the double — winning Indian Wells followed by Miami in the same season — was Roger Federer in 2017. Sinner is the first male to do so without dropping a set in either tournament. “It’s very, very special moment,” Sinner said. “Coming here, performing in a good way after Indian Wells, means a lot to me. Physically, it’s tough when you come here (from California). You’re a little bit tired, but the motivation is very high.”

The second-seeded Sinner didn’t let either of the two 90-minute rain delays slow him. He notched 10 aces in the final, and 70 in the tournament for the second-most of his



career. He often had Number 21 Lehecka running from side to side with his precise, deep groundstrokes. Sinner, 24, won his first 23 first-service points — a streak that lasted midway into the second set.

He became the eighth male to run the table at Indian Wells and Miami, and he and Sabalenka became the first to accomplish the double in the same year since Novak Djokovic and Victoria Azarenka in 2016.

This was Sinner’s second Miami Open title in three years as he ran his Hard Rock Stadium win streak to 12 matches dating to 2024. (AP)

Hyo Joo Kim beat Nelly Korda for second time

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Phoenix (USA)

Hyo Joo Kim beat Nelly Korda for the second straight week, pulling away around the turn Sunday and closing with a 3-under 69 for a two-shot victory in the Ford Championship.

Kim was poised to break the PGA Tour’s scoring record for 72 holes until one mistake led to a double bogey on the eighth hole and gave Korda hope.

Korda, who trailed by four at the start of the final round, suddenly was only one shot behind. But the American missed a short par putt on the ninth, and that was followed by a two-shot swing on the 10th - Kim hit her approach to 18 inches for birdie, and Korda failed to get up-and-down for par.

Korda never got any closer until



the tournament was out of reach, finishing eagle-birdie for a 67.

Kim, who also won the Ford Championship last year, now has back-to-back wins for the first time in her career, both against Korda. Last week in the Founders Cup, the 30-year-old South

Korean held off a Sunday charge by Korda.

“I wanted to ask Nelly how it feels to win back-to-back,” Kim said with a laugh, referring to Korda winning five straight starts during the 2024 season.

Kim finished at 28-under 260.

With three early birdies — and a week in which she twice had posted rounds of 61 — it looked as though she could break the PGA scoring record of 257 set by Sei Young Kim at the 2017 Thornberry Creek PGA Classic.

Those hopes took a hit on the par-4 eighth hole, when Kim pulled her tee shot. She tried to punch a hybrid under tree branches, but it ran hot on the sunbaked fairway, through the crusty green and didn’t stop rolling until it went down a slope and into the desert scrub.

That led to double bogey. Kim twice missed 5-foot birdie chances, and she also had a three-putt bogey on the 16th.

But the putting issues belonged to Korda, who missed a 2-foot par putt on the 15th — her second short miss of the round — that all but ended it.

France downs Colombia 3-1 in World Cup tune-up



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Landover (USA)

Desire Doue scored a pair of goals and France defeated Colombia 3-1 on Sunday as both teams prepare for the men’s World Cup this summer. Marcus Thuram also scored for the French before an announced crowd of 60,734 at Northwest Stadium, home of the NFL’s Washington Commanders. After starting in France’s 2-1 victory over Brazil earlier this week, Kylian Mbappe came in as a substitute in the 78th minute. He remains a goal away from matching France’s all-time goal scoring record, held by Olivier Giroud with 57 goals.

Mbappe was working his way back after a knee injury that has sidelined him in matches for his club team, Real Madrid.

Mbappe and Hugo Ekitike

both scored against Brazil on Thursday in Foxborough, Massachusetts. Bremer scored a late goal for Brazil.

Les Bleus, the World Cup winners in 1998 and 2018, have not dropped a match since last June and are ranked second in the FIFA rankings.

Colombia, ranked No. 13, was coming off a 2-1 loss to Croatia in Orlando, Florida, on Thursday. Doue scored in the 29th minute. Marcus Thuram added a goal off a cross from Maghnes Akliouche before halftime.

Doue’s second goal came in the 56th with an assists from, Thuram, before Jaminton Campaz closed the gap for Colombia in the 77th.

France opens the World Cup in East Rutherford, New Jersey, on June 16 against Senegal in Group I. Colombia opens against Uzbekistan in Mexico City in Group K on June 17.

Gary Woodland wins Houston Open

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Houston

Gary Woodland won the Houston Open on Sunday, an emotional moment that seemed so improbable 30 months ago when he had brain surgery, and even two weeks ago when he opened up about his frightening struggles with post-traumatic stress disorder.

Woodland looked better than ever at Memorial Park, taking a one-shot lead into the final round and stretching it to seven shots until coasting home to a trophy that felt as big as his US Open title at Pebble Beach in 2019.

He closed with a 3-under 67 to win by five shots over Nicolai Hojgaard. The gallery paused chanting his name so Woodland could roll in a 5-foot par putt. He stretched both arms, exhaled and looked to the blue sky before his tears began pouring. “We play an individual sport out here, but I wasn’t alone today,” Woodland said, his voice quivering with emotion. “Anyone struggling with something, I hope they see me and don’t give up. Just keep fighting.”

Woodland has been a popular figure and powerful player since he left a two-sport college career and joined the PGA Tour. But he began to struggle in 2023, only to learn he had a lesion on the part of his brain that caused unfounded fears that he was dying.

Surgery in September 2023, which involved a baseball-sized hole cut from the side of his head, removed much of the lesion. His return in January 2024 looked fine on the outside, particularly last year when he was runner-up at the Houston Open. But he was hurting badly with PTSD, once rushing to a portable bathroom to break down in tears when he was overcome with emotion. He chose two weeks ago to share his struggles in a Golf Channel interview.

“I appreciate that love and support. But inside, I feel like I’m dying, and I feel like I’m living a lie,” he said in the interview. “I want to live my dreams and be successful out here. But I want to help people, too. I realize now



I’ve got to help myself first.” He said this week going public made him feel “1,000 pounds lighter.” He still has moments, such as fans getting too close to him on the ninth tee Friday that made him hypervigilant. He said he was in tears in scoring after the second round before he reset and got on with his routine. “Coming out, talking and asking for help, I didn’t do that last year. I didn’t do that early this year,” Woodland said. “I’m in a fight. With the love and support I have around me, I have hope.” His physical strength sure didn’t leave him. Woodland reached 196 mph ball speed on one tee shot Sunday, and more striking was the smooth control he showed over every shot.

He finished at 21-under 259 for his first victory since the US Open, and the fifth of his career. This one came with a big bonus — it makes him eligible for the Masters in two weeks. Hojgaard fell back with a double bogey on the par-3 seventh hole when it took two shots to get out of a bunker. He closed with 71 and a consolation prize. He secured his position inside the top 50 in the world — going from No. 47 to No. 36 — to earn his invitation to the Masters.

Hojgaard and defending champion Min Woo Lee (67) chose to stay back on their way to the 18th green to give Woodland the stage to himself, a gesture rarely seen outside the majors. It spoke to

Woodland’s standing on the PGA Tour. “We thought it was appropriate to let him have his moment,” Hojgaard said. “It was a pretty cool moment for Gary and it was cool to see. I’m really happy for him.”

Woodland felt huge relief by sharing his PTSD struggles, and he had some technical help with his golf. He went to a new putter to help his alignment, and he consulted coach Randy Smith before going to stiffer shafts in his irons because his speed had returned and that helped him have better control of his shots.

There was no chance controlling his emotions, certainly over the last hour when the outcome was obvious and the 18th hole when it became reality. But he said it’s still golf, and there’s still a battle with his recovery from brain surgery. “It’s just another day. Today was a good day,” Woodland said with a smile and a short laugh. “But I’ve got a big fight ahead of me, and I’m going to keep going. But I’m proud of myself right now.”

His wife, Gabby, was with him all 18 holes with their three children at home. Woodland has said his wife was key to get him through surgery and what followed. “This has been hard on me. It’s been a lot harder on her,” he said. The victory moves him to No. 51 in the world — his highest ranking in five years — and makes him eligible for all the PGA Tour’s remaining elite events this season.

Sheetal Devi named ‘Para Archer of the Year’

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lausanne

India’s Sheetal Devi has been named ‘Para Archer of the Year 2025’ by World Archery, adding to her extraordinary achievements, which also include a historic world championship crown.

The 19-year-old from Jammu & Kashmir became the first and only female armless archer to win gold at the World Para Archery Championships by claiming the top honours in the women’s compound individual event in Gwangju, South Korea last year.

Born without arms, Sheetal skilfully uses her feet, legs, and shoulder to draw the bow and shoot. She also secured a complete set of medals at the World



Championships, winning the women’s team silver and mixed team bronze.

“India’s Sheetal Devi took the honour in the para archer of the year category after another breakthrough season that included a world title in Gwangju,”

said World Archery. Beyond her World Championship gold, Sheetal also boasts of a Paris Paralympics bronze in the mixed team event, along with individual silvers from the 2022 Asian Para Games and the 2023 Asian Championships in Bangkok.

Fabiano Caruana, R Praggnanandhaa share lead

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Paphos (Cyprus)

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa kicked off his campaign at the prestigious Candidates Tournament by breaking through the defenses of Dutchman Anish Giri to secure a full point and now shares the lead after the first round with American GM Fabiano Caruana and Uzbekistan’s Javokhir Sindarov here.

In an eventful first round, World Cup champion Sindarov showcased his excellent tactical skill to turn the tables on Russia’s Andrey Esipenko, while pre-event favourite Caruana stunned fellow American

Hikaru Nakamura.

The other game of the eight-player double round-robin tournament between Germany’s Matthias Bluebaum and China’s Wei Yi ended in a stalemate with both players sharing a point.

In the women’s section being held simultaneously, Indian Grandmaster and Women’s World Cup champion Divya Deshmukh drew with Ukraine’s Anna Muzychuk, a last-minute replacement for Koneru Humpy, while R Vaishali survived some anxious moments before sharing the point with Kazakhstan’s Bibisara Assaubayeva.

It was, in fact, a day of stalemates in the womens’ section as Russia’s



Aleksandra Goryachkina drew with compatriot Kateryna Lagno and the all-Chinese clash between Zhu Jiner and Tan Zhongyi also ended in a shared point.

Praggnanandhaa had

been struggling in recent months leading up to the Candidates but has now bounced back in style, and Giri, one of the most consistent and solid players on the circuit, was simply no

match for him on Saturday.

It was a battle of nerves as the Indian began with the Grand Prix Aataack to challenge Giri’s Sicilian Defense with the black pieces, and whether the opening achieved its intended effect is debatable, but it certainly gave Praggnanandhaa a valuable lead on the clock.

Giri is not used to surprises and while he was resourceful enough in the early middle game and equalised, Praggnanandhaa won a pawn in the ensuing rook-and-minor-pieces endgame. Giri, running low on time, blundered in a lost rook-and-pawns endgame with a pawn less. The rest was easy for Praggnanandhaa.

Roaring start for Royals and Sooryavanshi, uninspiring for CSK

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Indian batting sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi smashed a 15-ball half-century after an impressive show from the bowlers, setting up an emphatic eight-wicket win for Rajasthan Royals in their IPL opener against a sluggish Chennai Super Kings here on Monday.

Royals made good use of the overhead conditions to bowl out Chennai Super Kings for 127.

It was a forgettable batting performance for CSK, who were put in to bat by Riyan Parag on a pitch that had been under cover for a while due to rain.

The 15-year-old Sooryavanshi has made massive strides in his career since his record hundred in the IPL last season. His rare talent was on full display against a hapless CSK attack.

With Sooryavanshi going ballistic from his end, his opening partner Yashasvi Jaiswal was happy to give the strike back to the fellow left-hander. Royals raced to victory in 12.1 overs.

The result was a foregone conclusion after Sooryavanshi enjoyed an 18-run over. He was dropped by Kartik Sharma in that same over and duly made CSK pay heavily for that error.

Some of his awe inducing strokes included a six over



Vaibhav Sooryavanshi plays a shot during an IPL 2026 T20 cricket match between Rajasthan Royals and Chennai Super Kings, at ACA Stadium, Barsapara, in Guwahati, Assam

PTI

point off a slower ball from New Zealand pacer Matt Henry. Sooryavanshi became the third fastest to an IPL fifty with a couple of sixes off spinner Noor Ahmad.

Following his fall, Jaiswal (38 not out off 36) and Riyan Parag (14 not out off 11) completed the formalities for Royals with plenty to spare.

While the home team ticked all boxes, CSK looked completely out of sorts in their opener and will need to go back to the drawing board.

Both CSK and the Royals, the two bottom placed teams last season, had traded their star players Ravindra Jadeja and Sanju Samson ahead of the season.

It was a successful return to

the Royals for Jadeja, who struck twice in his opening over. Samson, star of India's T20 World Cup triumph, could not fire on his CSK debut. In an attempt to dis-patch Nandre Burger over mid-wicket, he saw his off-stump getting dislodged with a sharp delivery that seamed away. Both Nandre and Jofra Archer got the ball to talk in the powerplay.

After Nandre got rid of Samson, Archer sent back CSK skipper Rituraj Gaikwad who backed away to go for an aerial stroke on the off-side only to see his stumps rattled.

Burger was on a hat-trick in the second over after sur-

prising Ayush Mhatre with a bouncer that kissed the batter's gloves on way to the keeper.

Jadeja was introduced in the eighth over. He trapped Sarfaraz Khan (17 off 12) in front with the latter missing a slog sweep while another Indian World Cup star Shivam Dube (6 off 4) failed to clear long-off four balls later, leaving CSK at 57-6 in eight overs.

CSK could not find a way back from thereon despite a handy effort from Jamie Overton (43 off 36).

Royals' medium pacer Brijesh Sharma dismissed Kartik Sharma on his debut.

Archer, Burger and Jadeja ended with couple of wickets each.



I am not here to show how talented I am: Rahane

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Dismissive of the never-ending speculation around his future, experienced India batter and Kolkata Knight Riders captain Ajinkya Rahane says he is playing cricket for personal growth and not to prove a point to the naysayers.

The 37-year-old Rahane had stepped down from Mumbai's Ranji Trophy captaincy last season and he also did not lead the side in white-ball domestic competitions. The move triggered another round of chatter around the future of the batter, who hasn't played for India since 2023.

"Let people talk about me. They have been talking about me since like what, 20 years now. Let them talk," Rahane told reporters when asked if his 40-ball 67 with five sixes and three fours against Mumbai Indians here on Sunday was in any way a statement especially for those in Mumbai's cricket circuit.

"I am really happy with

the way I am batting at the moment. I am not here to show anyone how talented I am and what's my game. People are watching. Let them watch. Let them talk," he said.

"But I am really happy, in the last 2-3 years, (in the) white ball formats (with) the way I have improved my game. It's important to grow as a cricketer, as a batsman, and that's what I am trying to do. People will keep talking and let them talk," he added.

Rahane confirmed he only suffered with cramps during the second half of the contest which KKR lost by six wickets.

"I was just cramping. It's a very bad feeling to sit outside with the cramps and you don't have any control when the bowlers were bowling, it's a bad feeling but first I'm really happy the way I batted," he said.

Rahane credited Jasprit Bumrah for producing another tight spell towards the end which prevented KKR to get the total they were eyeing.

KKR fully aware of Green's bowling unavailability: CA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Sydney

Cricket Australia on Monday said the Kolkata Knight Riders' management is "fully aware" of Cameron Green's injury status after the team's captain Ajinkya Rahane created a flutter by stating that only the all-rounder's home board knew why he could not bowl in their IPL opener against Mumbai Indians.

Rahane deflected queries on Green's absence as a bowler in Mumbai last night by saying, "Ask Cricket Australia," triggering a mild controversy on the player's current fitness status.

"Cameron has a lower back injury which is being managed but requires him to abstain from bowling for a short period," a CA spokesperson told PTI. "Cameron is currently rebuilding his bowling loads in India with a



view to return in around 10-12 days' time. KKR has been communicated with and is fully aware of this information." Green did not bowl competitively for nearly 12 months—from September 2024 to October 2025—after undergoing surgery for a stress fracture in his back and even after that period, his contributions with the ball have been minimal

Green's last competitive outing with the ball came in the T20 World Cup against Oman on February 20 earlier this year at Pallekele, where he bowled just two overs.

Overall, Green just bowled 19 deliveries during the show-piece and took one wicket (against Zimbabwe).

KKR had gone all out at the IPL

SKY as impact sub was precautionary measure: Jayawardene

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Sanju Samson is set for an emotional clash against Rajasthan Royals (RR), the side he led and shaped for over a decade, as he turns out for Chennai Super Kings (CSK), while Ravindra Jadeja will also face his former franchise, adding a poignant sub-plot to the IPL match between the two teams here on Monday.

For more than a decade, Samson was synonymous with RR, their batting mainstay, leader and all-time leading run-scorer



who guided them to the 2022 final.

Much like MS Dhoni at CSK, Samson was the Royals' identity, but in a blockbuster swap that sent Jadeja back to RR, the Kerala batter now finds himself in yellow, adding a new dimension to CSK's evolving core.

Samson also arrives in prime form, having played a decisive role in India's triumphant T20 World Cup campaign. His hat-trick of 50-plus scores in must-win games against West Indies, England and New Zealand has made him the star of the nation as the unassuming keeper-batter will come with a renewed self-belief.

He along with skipper Rituraj Gaikwad, who are set to open

also, will also form the core leadership of the team who will miss Dhoni for at least two weeks due to a calf strain.

Dhoni has not travelled with the side to Guwahati as his absence will put Samson and Gaikwad in the spotlight. Dhoni's absence will also open the door for emerging names like 20-year-old left-arm spin all-rounder Prashant Veer who impressed in domestic T20s and the franchise's big-money (Rs 14.2-core) uncapped recruit Kartik Sharma, known for his six-hitting exploits in the domestic circuit.

With Dewald Brevis showing signs of maturity, Shivam Dube growing into a dependable middle-order force, and youngster Ayush Mhatre developing rapidly, CSK appear better equipped for a rebuild.



Rohit 2.0 is ready to dominate: Kumble

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Former India captain Anil Kumble is quite impressed with how Rohit Sharma has started the new IPL season for Mumbai Indians and he expects the opener's "2.0 avatar" to worry rivals throughout the ongoing edition.

The 38-year-old Rohit smacked a 38-ball 78 in MI's six-wicket win over Kolkata Knight Riders in their IPL opener here on Sunday.

"Rohit Sharma seems to have arrived in his 2.0 avatar, and his innings showed he is ready to dominate again. The way he hit the ball all around the ground reminded me of his prime," Kumble said on 'Star Sports'.

"It is not easy to hit sixes against bowlers like Varun Chakravathy, Sunil Narine and Blessing Muzarabani, but he made it look easy. He has worked a lot on his fitness, and when you come back after a short break, it takes five to seven days to get your timing back and find your rhythm.

"This was a fantastic innings...The six-hitting looked easy, and even though the boundaries were small, those shots were going into the stands. This knock shows that Rohit means business and this version of him will worry all IPL teams," he added.

KKR, missing some key bowlers due to injury, heavily relied on spinners Narine and Chakravathy to come good but neither of them clicked on Sunday.

"KKR are relying too much on Sunil Narine and Varun Chakravathy, and Narine did not even complete his quota of four overs, which was surprising," he pointed out.

Mihika Yadav, Arjun Singh in Indian pickleball squad for US Open



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Mihika Yadav and Arjun Singh are among those selected to represent India in the US Open pickleball tournament to be held in Naples, Florida, from April 9-18.

The other members of the squad include Purvansh Patel (open), Aditya Singh (open), Naga Moksha (girls U-18), Jeet Sood (U-16) and Yuvraj Singh (U-16).

It also features Panth Thakkar and Atharva Sheth in the sub-junior category, and Suryaveer Singh Bhullar (men's 50-plus doubles and mixed doubles), the Indian Pickleball Association said in a release on Monday.

The team will be coached by Dhiren Patel, who will be competing in the 40-plus men's pro singles.

The Indian players will get a direct entry into the tournament due to partnership between IPA and US Open.

Overlooked Gill, Iyer eye redemption in GT-PBKS opener

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullanpur

Shubman Gill and Shreyas Iyer, two India T20I batters who have often been overlooked, will captain Gujarat Titans and Punjab Kings respectively, each eager to make a statement in a high-stakes Indian Premier League opener on Tuesday.

India's Test and ODI captain Gill, who was named T20I vice-captain but later left out of the World Cup squad to accommodate Sanju Samson, has a lot to answer in the shortest format.

While India went on to win a record third ICC T20 World Cup, Gill enters this season at a crucial phase in his T20 career.

Since 2023, only Virat Kohli has scored more IPL runs than Gill, but the focus has shifted from consistency to strike rate. With a career T20 strike rate of around



138, Gill showed signs of improvement last season, scoring at over 155-something he would look to build on.

With Matthew Hayden now part of the coaching staff as batting coach, Gill's six-hitting and intent at the top will be closely watched.

Since Hardik Pandya's exit after IPL 2023, Gill has grown into his leadership role, and the team

now clearly revolves around him.

Having won the title in their debut season in 2022, Gujarat Titans have remained one of the most consistent sides, finishing third last year before losing to Mumbai Indians in the Eliminator.

They look one of the most settled units again, retaining 20 players. The opening pair of Gill and Sai Sudharsan—last season's top scorer with 759 runs—

Komalika eyes Asian Games comeback with sheer hard work

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Raipur

Grinding it out is the only way forward, and out-of-favour Indian archer Komalika Bari has learnt it the hard way. Once seen as the next big thing in Indian archery after Deepika Kumari, the 24-year-old has slipped to a lowly 498 in world rankings and is currently out of the national team since 2024. From a career-best rank of 51 in September 2022, it has been a steep fall. But Komalika is not giving up.

With a packed season ahead,



culminating in the Asian Games in Japan later this year, she is hoping to fight her way back and revive her 2028 LA Olympics dream.

"I am currently in the Top 16 (among Indians) and part of the training camp and I am preparing seriously for the Asian Games selection," Komalika told SAI Media on the sidelines of the inaugural Khelo India Triba Games here. "I am also looking to participate in as many competitions to gain experience while maintaining our training schedule." Her journey had once mirrored that of the five-time Olympian and former world number 1 Deepika Kumari.

In 2021, she won the under-21

remains their biggest strength.

Sudharsan is returning after a rib fracture but was in fine touch in domestic cricket, including an unbeaten 101 and multiple fifties before the injury.

GT also have exciting backup options like wicketkeeper-batter Kumar Kushagra, who impressed in domestic cricket with a strike rate of over 160 and an average above 60 in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy. He would offer flexibility if the middle order struggles.

For Punjab Kings, much will again depend on skipper Shreyas, a proven IPL leader who has now taken three different teams to the final (Delhi Capitals in 2020, KKR in their 2024 triumph and PBKS last season).

Despite his consistent performances, Shreyas continues to be overlooked by the Ajit Agarkar-led selection committee, having last played a T20I in December 2023.

World Championship in Wroclaw, beating Spain's Elia Canales 7-3, two years after clinching the under-18 title in Madrid, to follow the footsteps of her state mate Deepika's rare double.

Komalika went on to be part of India's gold medal-winning teams at the World Cups in Guatemala City and Paris in 2021, and also bagged a team bronze in Gwangju in 2022 and was coached by Deepika's coach Poornima Mahato. But since those early highs, things have not gone her way.

Fitness and tactics set to be in focus at women's hockey camp



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Building combinations, improving fitness levels, and sharpening tactical aspects will be the key focus areas when the tried-and-tested group of 31 probables assemble for the senior women's national hockey camp from April 1 to prepare for the World Cup later this year.

The camp will be conducted at the Sports Authority of India's National Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru.

The team is currently basking in the glory of a strong performance at the recently-concluded FIH World Cup Qualifiers in Hyderabad, where it secured a silver medal to qualify for the World Cup in Belgium and

Netherlands in August.

The camp comes at a crucial juncture as India are also set to compete in the Nations Cup in June, followed by the World Cup and the Asian Games scheduled from September 19 to October 4 in Japan.

The goalkeeping unit includes Savita Punia, returning after missing the FIH World Cup Qualifiers in Hyderabad, alongside Madhuri Kindo, Bansari Solanki, and Bichu Devi Khariabam, the recent Hockey India Baljit Singh Award-winning goalkeeper.

The defensive line-up includes seasoned players like Nikki Pradhan and Udita, alongside Ishika Chaudhary, Jyoti Singh, Lalthantluangi, Jyoti, and Shilpi Dabas offering depth at the back.